ECONOMIC INTELLIGENCE SERIES

U.S. Metro Economic Health Report

50 Metropolitan Statistical Areas

Percentile-Based Composite Scoring · 8 Metrics · BLS & FRED Data
85% Employment / 15% Housing · November 2026

TOP PERFORMERS

#1	A+	Salt Lake City	77.6
#2	A+	St. Louis	73.7
#3	A+	Austin	73.6
#4	A+	Hartford	73.0
#5	A+	Charlotte	72.4
#6	A	Raleigh	71.0
#7	A	Philadelphia	69.8

MARKETS UNDER PRESSURE

#50	D	Louisville	22.0
#49	D	Chicago	22.5
#48	D	Detroit	24.5
#47	D	Richmond	25.1
#46	D	Grand Rapids	26.1
#45	D	Indianapolis	28.2
#44	C-	Jacksonville	30.7

GRADE DISTRIBUTION

A+ / A / A-	9 cities
B+ / B / B-	13 cities
C+ / C / C-	22 cities
D	6 cities

Data sources: U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics (BLS) · Federal Reserve Economic Data (FRED)
Unemployment, CLF Growth, Earnings, Employment, Weekly Hours sourced from BLS LAUS / SAE.
Building Permits from Census Bureau via FRED. Days on Market from Realtor.com / FRED.

Scoring methodology: percentile ranking across all 50 metros.
Full methodology: SCORING_README.md
Pipeline runs weekly via GitHub Actions.

Full Rankings

All 50 Metropolitan Statistical Areas · Sorted by composite score · November 2026

#	METRO	GRADE	SCORE	UNEMP.	WAGE YOY	EMP. YOY	CLF YOY	DOM
1	**Salt Lake City** Salt Lake City-Murray	A+	77.6	3.2%	+4.9%	+2.7%	+1.2%	63 days
2	**St. Louis** St. Louis	A+	73.7	3.4%	+4.3%	+1.0%	-0.1%	51 days
3	**Austin** Austin-Round Rock-San Marcos	A+	73.6	3.7%	+5.4%	+1.1%	+1.0%	84 days
4	**Hartford** Hartford-West Hartford-East Hartford	A+	73.0	2.7%	+5.0%	+1.9%	+2.8%	37 days
5	**Charlotte** Charlotte-Concord-Gastonia	A+	72.4	3.3%	+4.4%	+1.8%	+0.7%	65 days
6	**Raleigh** Raleigh-Cary	A	71.0	2.7%	+3.2%	+2.3%	+0.9%	64 days
7	**Philadelphia** Philadelphia-Camden-Wilmington	A	69.8	3.6%	+3.5%	+0.5%	+1.0%	48 days
8	**Miami** Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach	A-	65.2	3.2%	+8.8%	+0.4%	+0.9%	79 days
9	**Baltimore** Baltimore-Columbia-Towson	A-	64.7	3.5%	+6.4%	-0.2%	+0.4%	46 days
10	**Dallas** Dallas-Fort Worth-Arlington	B+	63.3	4.1%	+4.7%	+1.0%	+0.6%	64 days
11	**Kansas City** Kansas City	B+	62.8	3.4%	+7.6%	+0.5%	-2.1%	52 days
12	**Orlando** Orlando-Kissimmee-Sanford	B+	61.0	4.2%	+6.0%	+1.0%	+0.7%	78 days
13	**Cincinnati** Cincinnati	B+	60.0	3.6%	+8.9%	+0.4%	-1.2%	44 days
14	**Las Vegas** Las Vegas-Henderson-North Las Vegas	B	59.8	4.8%	+3.6%	+1.7%	-0.6%	59 days
15	**Pittsburgh** Pittsburgh	B	56.9	3.0%	+3.5%	-0.5%	+0.2%	57 days
16	**Nashville** Nashville-Davidson--Murfreesboro--Franklin	B	56.1	2.9%	+3.7%	+1.1%	-0.6%	63 days
17	**Los Angeles** Los Angeles-Long Beach-Anaheim	B	55.3	4.4%	+3.6%	+1.8%	-1.3%	57 days
18	**Memphis** Memphis	B-	54.9	4.1%	+3.6%	+0.2%	-1.7%	73 days
19	**Tampa** Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater	B-	54.3	4.3%	+4.0%	+1.1%	+0.8%	77 days
20	**Cleveland** Cleveland	B-	52.6	3.4%	+1.8%	+0.6%	+1.8%	55 days
21	**Seattle** Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue	B-	51.0	4.9%	+5.5%	+0.7%	+1.4%	51 days
22	**San Diego** San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad	B-	50.3	4.7%	+7.8%	+1.3%	-0.8%	48 days
23	**San Antonio** San Antonio-New Braunfels	C+	49.7	4.3%	+3.9%	+0.4%	+0.2%	74 days
24	**Portland** Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro	C+	49.3	4.1%	+5.7%	-0.6%	-0.6%	71 days

#	METRO	GRADE	SCORE	UNEMP.	WAGE YOY	EMP. YOY	CLF YOY	DOM
25	**Washington DC** Washington-Arlington-Alexandria	C+	49.0	3.7%	+6.0%	-1.8%	-2.2%	43 days
26	**Columbus** Columbus	C+	47.7	3.3%	+4.5%	-0.1%	-2.0%	50 days
27	**San Francisco** San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont	C+	47.1	4.4%	+5.6%	+0.3%	-1.4%	38 days
28	**Phoenix** Phoenix-Mesa-Chandler	C+	45.8	4.2%	+3.2%	+1.0%	-3.0%	59 days
29	**Houston** Houston-Pasadena-The Woodlands	C+	45.1	4.6%	+2.2%	+1.0%	+0.7%	57 days
30	**Oklahoma City** Oklahoma City	C+	44.8	3.7%	+4.0%	+0.5%	-0.2%	60 days
31	**Boston** Boston-Cambridge-Newton	C	43.4	3.9%	+3.3%	-0.0%	+2.9%	38 days
32	**Providence** Providence-Warwick	C	43.3	4.3%	+3.5%	+0.6%	+1.7%	39 days
33	**Atlanta** Atlanta-Sandy Springs-Roswell	C	42.9	3.5%	+2.9%	-0.1%	+2.6%	61 days
34	**Fresno** Fresno	C	41.8	7.3%	+4.2%	+1.9%	-0.5%	61 days
35	**San Jose** San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara	C	40.3	4.2%	-0.5%	+1.6%	-0.3%	37 days
36	**New York** New York Newark-Jersey City	C	38.8	4.5%	+1.8%	+0.2%	-0.5%	53 days
37	**Sacramento** Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom	C	38.6	5.0%	+2.6%	+0.8%	-1.3%	52 days
38	**Minneapolis** Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington	C-	37.1	4.5%	+0.7%	+1.1%	-0.7%	43 days
39	**Virginia Beach** Virginia Beach-Chesapeake-Norfolk	C-	35.6	3.8%	+4.5%	-0.2%	-1.4%	45 days
40	**Milwaukee** Milwaukee-Waukesha	C-	34.9	3.2%	-0.2%	+0.2%	+0.4%	37 days
41	**Denver** Denver-Aurora-Centennial	C-	34.7	4.3%	+1.9%	+0.2%	-2.4%	60 days
42	**Birmingham** Birmingham	C-	34.3	3.5%	-0.4%	+1.2%	-0.7%	66 days
43	**Riverside** Riverside-San Bernardino-Ontario	C-	33.6	5.7%	+4.7%	+0.6%	-0.9%	62 days
44	**Jacksonville** Jacksonville	C-	30.7	4.5%	+1.0%	+0.3%	-0.1%	66 days
45	**Indianapolis** Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood	D	28.2	3.4%	+0.5%	-0.6%	-1.1%	55 days
46	**Grand Rapids** Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood	D	26.1	3.7%	+1.2%	+0.1%	-8.5%	43 days
47	**Richmond** Richmond	D	25.1	3.8%	+1.6%	-1.0%	-2.2%	44 days
48	**Detroit** Detroit-Warren-Dearborn	D	24.5	5.6%	+2.1%	-0.2%	+0.5%	45 days
49	**Chicago** Chicago-Naperville-Elgin	D	22.5	4.4%	+3.2%	-0.1%	-2.0%	37 days
50	**Louisville** Louisville-Jefferson County	D	22.0	4.4%	+1.4%	-0.0%	+0.2%	45 days

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #1 OF 50

Salt Lake City

Salt Lake City-Murray

A+

EXCELLENT

77.6th percentile

Rank 1 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT **3.2%** of civilian labor force	WAGE GROWTH YOY **+4.9%** avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH **+2.7%** nonfarm payrolls YoY	LABOR FORCE YOY **+1.2%** civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS **+25.9%** residential YoY (3mo avg)	DAYS ON MARKET **63 days** median, +6.8% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

GROWING

Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Salt Lake City-Murray metro area boasts an overall grade of A+ with a composite score ranking in the 77.6th percentile among 50 US metros. This city's economic character is largely defined by its strong labor demand, with a composite score in the 88th percentile, and its deep professional talent pool, ranking in the 96th percentile for office and professional worker share. Specifically, the city's employment growth rate of 2.66% and weekly hours deviation of -0.609% signal a genuine demand expansion.

Labor Demand

The Salt Lake City-Murray metro area has an employment growth rate of 2.66% and a weekly hours deviation of -0.609%, indicating a genuine demand expansion. This combination signals that the city is adding jobs and hours are running above trend, suggesting a strong and growing labor market. The labor demand composite score of 7.41 further reinforces this notion, ranking in the 88th percentile.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Salt Lake City-Murray is 3.20%, ranking in the 80th percentile, indicating a relatively tight labor market. This means that businesses may face challenges in hiring, as the pool of available workers is smaller, and may need to offer competitive wages to attract talent. The tight market also implies upward pressure on wages.

Wage Growth

The city's year-over-year wage growth rate is 4.91%, ranking in the 74th percentile, indicating moderate to fast wage growth. This rate suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but worker purchasing power is also increasing. As a result, businesses may need to factor in higher labor costs, but can also expect a more affluent local consumer base.

Cost of Living

Salt Lake City-Murray has a cost of living score ranking in the 63rd percentile, with a PSF of $260/sqft and an earnings ratio of $39.78/hr, resulting in a ratio of 6.54. This indicates that the city is relatively affordable compared to its peers, although the PSF is rising at a rate of 0.4% YoY. The affordability of the city makes it an attractive location for talent, as businesses may not need to offer significant wage premiums to compensate for high living costs.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Salt Lake City-Murray is growing at a rate of 1.18% year-over-year, ranking in the 86th percentile. This expansion of the labor force supply suggests that businesses will have a growing pool of potential workers to hire from, making it easier to find and attract talent. The increasing labor force also implies a structurally supportive environment for hiring.

Building Permits

The city has seen a 25.87% year-over-year increase in residential building permits, ranking in the 84th percentile. This significant rise in permits suggests that housing supply is expanding, which should improve affordability and accommodate a growing workforce. The increase in permits is a positive signal for future workforce attraction and retention.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Salt Lake City-Murray is 63 days, with a year-over-year increase of 6.8%. This indicates a relatively fast-paced market, ranking in the 20th percentile, which may make it challenging for relocating workers to find and secure housing. The competitive market implies that businesses may need to offer relocation assistance or other incentives to attract talent.

Office Economy

The city's professional and office worker share is 4.36, ranking in the 96th percentile, indicating a deep and specialized talent pool. This makes Salt Lake City-Murray an attractive location for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors, which require a high concentration of knowledge-economy workers. The city is less suited for industries with more industrial or logistics-oriented workforces.

The Salt Lake City-Murray metro area offers businesses a unique combination of strong labor demand, a deep professional talent pool, and a relatively affordable cost of living. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers to factor in is the competitive housing market, which may require businesses to offer relocation assistance or other incentives to attract and retain talent. Overall, the city's economic character and growth prospects make it an attractive location for businesses looking to expand or establish a presence in a thriving and specialized labor market.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #2 OF 50

St. Louis

St. Louis

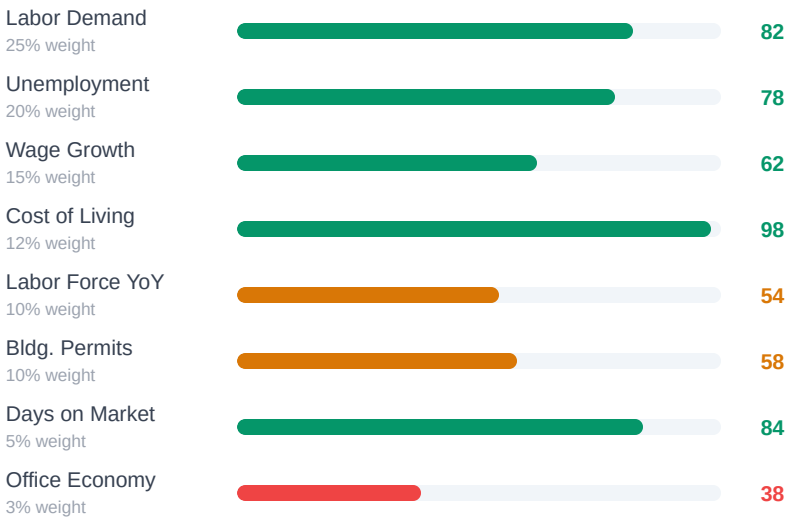
A+

EXCELLENT

73.7th percentile

Rank 2 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT **3.4%** of civilian labor force	WAGE GROWTH YOY **+4.3%** avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH **+1.0%** nonfarm payrolls YoY	LABOR FORCE YOY **-0.1%** civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS **+7.4%** residential YoY (3mo avg)	DAYS ON MARKET **51 days** median, +13.3% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

STRONG

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

St. Louis earns an overall grade of A+ with a composite score of 73.7th percentile, ranking it among the top metros in the US. The city's economic character is defined by its strong labor demand, with a composite score of 6.69, and its highly affordable cost of living, ranked in the 98th percentile. The labor demand is driven by a 0.98% year-over-year employment growth rate and a 1.019% deviation in weekly hours above its own trend.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate of 0.98% and weekly hours deviation of 1.019% above trend signal a genuine demand expansion in St. Louis, indicating that the city is adding jobs and workers are putting in more hours. This combination suggests a strong and growing economy. The labor demand composite score of 6.69, ranked in the 82nd percentile, further reinforces this assessment.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in St. Louis is 3.40%, which is ranked in the 78th percentile, indicating a relatively tight labor market. This means that businesses may face challenges in hiring, as the pool of available workers is smaller, and may need to offer competitive wages to attract talent. The tight market also implies upward pressure on wages.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate in St. Louis is 4.35%, which is ranked in the 62nd percentile, indicating moderate wage growth. This rate suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but at a manageable pace, and worker purchasing power is increasing. The moderate wage growth also implies a relatively stable labor cost environment.

Cost of Living

St. Louis has a cost of living ranked in the 98th percentile, with a price-to-salary ratio of $163/sqft to $38.21/hr, or 4.27, and a year-over-year decrease in PSF of 1.8%. This makes the city highly affordable relative to its peers, which is a significant advantage for talent attraction, as businesses can offer competitive wages without needing to account for a high cost of living.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in St. Louis is growing at a rate of -0.09% year-over-year, which is ranked in the 54th percentile, indicating a slightly contracting labor pool. This contraction may pose a structural headwind for hiring, as the supply of available workers is not expanding. However, the slow contraction rate may not significantly impact businesses in the short term.

Building Permits

The number of building permits in St. Louis is increasing by 7.38% year-over-year, which is ranked in the 58th percentile, indicating a moderate expansion of housing supply. This growth suggests that the city is investing in its future housing stock, which will help maintain affordability and accommodate a growing workforce.

Days on Market

The median days on market in St. Louis is 51 days, with a year-over-year increase of 13.3%, which is ranked in the 84th percentile. This indicates a relatively slow market, making it more accessible for workers relocating to the city, as they have more time to find a suitable home. The slow market also suggests a more competitive environment for buyers.

Office Economy

St. Louis has a professional and office worker share ranked in the 38th percentile, with a composite score of 2.40. This indicates a relatively shallow talent pool in these sectors, making the city less suited for businesses that require a deep pool of specialized office workers, such as tech or finance companies. However, the city may be more suitable for industries with less specialized labor requirements.

In conclusion, St. Louis offers businesses a unique combination of strong labor demand, affordable cost of living, and moderate wage growth, making it an attractive location for companies looking to expand or relocate. However, the slightly contracting labor pool and relatively shallow office economy talent pool are risks that decision-makers should consider when evaluating the city as a potential business location.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #3 OF 50

Austin

Austin-Round Rock-San Marcos

A+

EXCELLENT

73.6th percentile

Rank 3 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	84
Unemployment	20% weight	56
Wage Growth	15% weight	78
Cost of Living	12% weight	96
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	82
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	72
Days on Market	5% weight	0
Office Economy	3% weight	94

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT
3.7%
of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY
+5.4%
avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH
+1.1%
nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE YOY
+1.0%
civilian labor force growth

BUILDING PERMITS
+15.3%
residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET
84 days
median, +6.3% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

STRONG

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Austin-Round Rock-San Marcos metro area earns an overall grade of A+ with a composite score of 73.6th percentile, ranking it among the top US metros. The city's economic character is most defined by its strong labor demand, with a composite score of 6.72, and its highly affordable cost of living, with a percentile rank of 96th. These metrics signal a city with a thriving job market and a competitive edge in attracting talent without needing significant wage premiums, as evidenced by its top-tier labor demand score of 84th percentile and cost of living ratio of $226/sqft to $37.91/hr, resulting in a ratio of 5.96.

Labor Demand

The Austin-Round Rock-San Marcos metro area has seen employment growth of 1.08% year-over-year, combined with a 0.906% deviation in weekly hours above its own trend, indicating genuine demand expansion. This combination signals that the city is experiencing a period of job growth where hours are also increasing, suggesting that businesses are not only hiring but also increasing the workload for existing employees. With a labor demand composite score in the top tier at 84th percentile, this is a strong indicator of a healthy and expanding job market.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Austin-Round Rock-San Marcos stands at 3.70%, placing it near the median at the 56th percentile. This rate suggests that while the market is not extremely tight, it does have some slack, making it somewhat easier for businesses to find talent compared to cities with lower unemployment rates. However, this also means that local consumer demand might not be as strong as in areas with even lower unemployment, potentially affecting businesses reliant on local spending.

Wage Growth

Year-over-year wage growth in the metro area is 5.42%, which is above average, ranking at the 78th percentile. This level of wage growth indicates that labor costs for employers are rising, but it also means that workers have increasing purchasing power, which can be beneficial for businesses that rely on local consumer spending. The moderate to fast pace of wage growth suggests a competitive labor market where employers need to adjust their compensation packages to attract and retain talent.

Cost of Living

With a cost of living percentile rank of 96th, Austin-Round Rock-San Marcos is one of the more affordable cities relative to its peers, especially considering the PSF is $226/sqft and has decreased by 8.5% year-over-year, compared to hourly earnings of $37.91. This affordability, combined with the low PSF to earnings ratio of 5.96, gives the city a significant talent attraction advantage without needing substantial wage premiums to compensate for high living costs.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in the Austin-Round Rock-San Marcos metro area has grown by 0.97% year-over-year, indicating an expanding workforce supply. This positive growth rate suggests that the city has a structural advantage in terms of hiring capacity, as the pool of potential workers is increasing. For businesses looking to expand or relocate, this growth in the labor force is a favorable sign.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in residential building permits is +15.35%, indicating that housing supply is expanding. This increase in building permits signals developer confidence in the market and suggests that future housing supply will be more ample, potentially improving affordability and making it easier for workers to relocate to the area.

Days on Market

The current median days on market for homes in Austin-Round Rock-San Marcos is 84 days, with a year-over-year increase of 6.3%. However, despite this increase, the city still ranks at the bottom tier in terms of days on market, indicating a relatively fast-paced and competitive housing market. For workers relocating to this city, the fast-selling market might pose challenges in finding and securing housing.

Office Economy

The share of jobs in professional and office sectors in Austin-Round Rock-San Marcos is significant, with the city ranking at the 94th percentile in terms of its deep knowledge-economy talent pool. This makes the city particularly well-suited for tech, finance, consulting, and HQ decisions, where access to specialized and skilled workers is crucial. Conversely, it might be less ideal for businesses that require a predominantly industrial or logistics-based workforce.

The Austin-Round Rock-San Marcos metro area offers businesses a unique combination of a strong labor market, affordable cost of living, and a deep talent pool in professional sectors. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers to consider is the competitive and fast-paced housing market, which could pose challenges for relocating workers and might require strategic planning to ensure that talent can be effectively attracted and retained.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #4 OF 50

Hartford

Hartford-West Hartford-East Hartford

A+

EXCELLENT

73.0th percentile

Rank 4 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT **2.7%** of civilian labor force	WAGE GROWTH YOY **+5.0%** avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH **+1.9%** nonfarm payrolls YoY	LABOR FORCE YOY **+2.8%** civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS **-53.9%** residential YoY (3mo avg)	DAYS ON MARKET **37 days** median, +2.8% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

STRONG

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Hartford-West Hartford-East Hartford metro area boasts an overall grade of A+ with a composite score of 73.0th percentile, ranking it among the top US metros. The city's economic character is largely defined by its exceptional labor demand, with a composite score in the 90th percentile, and its extremely low unemployment rate of 2.70%, ranking in the 98th percentile. These metrics signal a highly competitive job market with strong demand for labor.

Labor Demand

The city's employment growth rate of +1.88% YoY, combined with a +0.741% deviation in weekly hours from its own trend, indicates genuine demand expansion, as hours are running above trend during a period of job growth. This suggests that the labor market is experiencing an increase in jobs and working hours, signaling a strong and growing economy. The labor demand composite score of 7.67 further reinforces this notion, placing it in the top tier.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate of 2.70% is extremely low, ranking in the 98th percentile, indicating a very tight labor market with little slack. This means that businesses may face challenges in finding and hiring qualified workers, as the pool of available labor is limited. As a result, companies may need to offer competitive wages and benefits to attract top talent.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate of +4.96% is above average, ranking in the 76th percentile, indicating moderate to fast wage growth. This implies that labor costs for employers are rising, while worker purchasing power is increasing. As a result, businesses may need to factor in higher labor costs when operating in this city.

Cost of Living

With a cost of living ratio of 6.13, based on $246/sqft and $40.13/hr, the city ranks in the 49th percentile, indicating a near-median affordability level. However, the PSF is increasing by 1.6% YoY, which may impact affordability in the future. This means that the city is neither extremely affordable nor expensive, and businesses may not need to offer significant wage premiums to attract talent.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force is growing at a rate of +2.77% YoY, ranking in the 96th percentile, indicating a rapidly expanding workforce supply. This suggests that the city has a strong pipeline of potential workers, making it easier for businesses to hire and expand their operations.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in building permits is -53.87%, ranking in the bottom tier, indicating a sharp decline in housing supply. This signals a potential tightening of the housing market, which may impact future affordability and workforce accommodation, making it more challenging for workers to relocate to the city.

Days on Market

The current median days on market is 37 days, with a +2.8% YoY increase, ranking in the 64th percentile. This suggests a relatively accessible market for workers relocating to the city, as homes are not selling extremely quickly. However, the rising DOM may indicate a normalization of the market, rather than a demand erosion.

Office Economy

The city's office economy is below average, ranking in the 26th percentile, with a composite score of 1.90. This indicates a relatively shallow professional talent pool, making it less suited for businesses that require a deep knowledge-economy talent pool, such as tech or finance companies. However, it may be more suitable for industries with fewer specialized roles, such as logistics or manufacturing.

In conclusion, the Hartford-West Hartford-East Hartford metro area offers a highly competitive job market with strong labor demand, low unemployment, and moderate wage growth, making it an attractive location for businesses. However, the single biggest risk or constraint is the sharp decline in building permits, which may lead to a tightening of the housing market and impact future affordability and workforce accommodation, potentially limiting the city's ability to attract and retain top talent.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #5 OF 50

Charlotte

Charlotte-Concord-Gastonia

A+

EXCELLENT

72.4th percentile

Rank 5 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT **3.3%** of civilian labor force	WAGE GROWTH YOY **+4.4%** avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH **+1.8%** nonfarm payrolls YoY	LABOR FORCE YOY **+0.7%** civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS **-12.7%** residential YoY (3mo avg)	DAYS ON MARKET **65 days** median, +10.2% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

STRONG

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Charlotte-Concord-Gastonia metro area has earned an overall grade of A+ with a composite score of 72.4th percentile, ranking it among the top US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its strong labor demand, with a composite score of 7.89, and its low unemployment rate of 3.30%, which signals a tight labor market. The combination of a 1.84% employment growth rate and a 1.012% weekly hours deviation from trend also highlights the city's genuine demand expansion.

Labor Demand

The Charlotte-Concord-Gastonia metro area has seen a 1.84% employment growth rate and a 1.012% weekly hours deviation from trend, indicating genuine demand expansion. This combination signals that the city is adding jobs and workers are putting in more hours, suggesting a strong and growing economy. The labor demand composite score of 7.89, ranked in the 96th percentile, further reinforces this notion.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Charlotte-Concord-Gastonia is 3.30%, ranking in the 84th percentile, which indicates a tight labor market with limited slack. This means that businesses may face challenges in finding available workers, and wage pressure may be higher. As a result, companies looking to hire in this city may need to offer competitive salaries to attract top talent.

Wage Growth

The city has experienced a 4.37% year-over-year wage growth rate, ranking in the 64th percentile, which is above average but not exceptionally high. This moderate wage growth suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but not at an alarming rate, while workers are seeing an increase in their purchasing power. However, this growth may not be sufficient to keep pace with the city's overall economic expansion.

Cost of Living

With a cost of living percentile rank of 78th, Charlotte-Concord-Gastonia is relatively affordable, particularly given its PSF of $216/sqft, which has decreased by 1.8% year-over-year, and an average hourly earnings of $38.60/hr, resulting in a ratio of 5.60. This affordability advantage can be a significant talent attraction factor, as workers may not require wage premiums to maintain their standard of living.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Charlotte-Concord-Gastonia has grown by 0.69% year-over-year, ranking in the 70th percentile, indicating a moderate expansion of the workforce supply. This growth suggests that the city's hiring capacity is increasing, but at a slower rate than

some of its peers. As a result, businesses may still face some challenges in finding available workers, but the situation is not as dire as in cities with contracting labor forces.

Building Permits

The city has seen a 12.73% year-over-year decline in building permits, ranking in the 26th percentile, which signals a tightening of the housing supply. This decrease may lead to future affordability concerns and could impact the city's ability to accommodate a growing workforce. As a result, businesses may need to consider the potential long-term implications of this trend on their ability to attract and retain talent.

Days on Market

The median days on market in Charlotte-Concord-Gastonia is currently 65 days, with a 10.2% year-over-year increase, ranking in the 10th percentile. This suggests a relatively slow market, which can be beneficial for workers relocating to the city, as they may have more time to find a suitable home. However, this trend may also indicate a normalization of the market after a period of rapid growth.

Office Economy

With an office economy percentile rank of 86th, Charlotte-Concord-Gastonia has a deep talent pool in professional and office sectors, making it an attractive location for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors. However, the city may be less suited for industries that require a large workforce in industrial or logistics roles.

The Charlotte-Concord-Gastonia metro area offers businesses a strong labor market, a talented workforce, and a relatively affordable cost of living. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers to consider is the tightening housing supply, which may lead to future affordability concerns and impact the city's ability to accommodate a growing workforce.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #6 OF 50

Raleigh

Raleigh-Cary

A

VERY GOOD

71.0th percentile

Rank 6 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT **2.7%** of civilian labor force	WAGE GROWTH YOY **+3.2%** avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH **+2.3%** nonfarm payrolls YoY	LABOR FORCE YOY **+0.9%** civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS **-22.7%** residential YoY (3mo avg)	DAYS ON MARKET **64 days** median, +6.7% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

STRONG

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Raleigh-Cary metro area has earned an overall grade of A, ranking in the 71.0th percentile among 50 US metros, with a strong labor demand and low unemployment rate defining its current economic character. The labor demand composite score of 8.49, combining a 2.27% employment growth rate and a 1.008% weekly hours deviation above trend, signals a genuine demand expansion. This is further reinforced by an unemployment rate of 2.70%, indicating a tight labor market.

Labor Demand

The Raleigh-Cary metro area is experiencing a strong labor demand, with a 2.27% employment growth rate and a 1.008% weekly hours deviation above its own trend. This combination signals a genuine demand expansion, where jobs are being added and hours are running above trend. The labor demand composite score of 8.49, ranking in the 98th percentile, confirms this robust labor market.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Raleigh-Cary is 2.70%, ranking in the 94th percentile, indicating a very tight labor market. This means that businesses may face challenges in hiring, as the pool of available workers is limited, and may need to offer competitive wages to attract talent. The low unemployment rate also suggests that workers have strong bargaining power.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Raleigh-Cary is 3.23%, ranking in the 34th percentile, indicating moderate wage growth. While this is not exceptionally high, it still suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, and workers are experiencing an increase in purchasing power. However, the moderate pace of wage growth may not be sufficient to keep up with the cost of living in the area.

Cost of Living

Raleigh-Cary has a cost of living score ranking in the 80th percentile, with a PSF of $213/sqft, which is decreasing by 3.2% year-over-year, and an average hourly earnings of $38.12/hr, resulting in a ratio of 5.59. This indicates that the city is relatively affordable compared to its peers, making it an attractive location for talent without requiring significant wage premiums. The decreasing PSF is a key driver of this affordability.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Raleigh-Cary is growing at a rate of 0.92% year-over-year, ranking in the 80th percentile, indicating an expanding workforce supply. This suggests that businesses have a growing pool of potential workers to hire from, making it easier to find talent. The positive labor force growth also implies that the city is likely to maintain its economic momentum.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Raleigh-Cary has decreased by 22.66% year-over-year, ranking in the 12th percentile, indicating a tightening housing supply. This suggests that the city may face future affordability challenges and workforce accommodation constraints, as the demand for housing is not being met by new supply. The decline in building permits is a concern for businesses relying on a steady influx of new workers.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Raleigh-Cary is 64 days, with a year-over-year increase of 6.7%, ranking in the 18th percentile. This indicates a slower market, where homes are taking longer to sell, making it more accessible for workers relocating to the city. However, the slow pace of sales may also suggest a softening demand for housing.

Office Economy

Raleigh-Cary has a deep professional talent pool, with an office economy score ranking in the 98th percentile, indicating a strong presence of professional and office sectors. This makes the city an attractive location for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors, which require specialized knowledge workers. However, it may not be as suitable for industries with more industrial or logistics-oriented workforces.

The Raleigh-Cary metro area offers businesses a strong labor market, low unemployment, and a relatively affordable cost of living, making it an attractive location for talent and investment. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the decline in building permits, which may lead to future affordability challenges and workforce accommodation constraints, potentially limiting the city's long-term economic growth.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #7 OF 50

Philadelphia

Philadelphia-Camden-Wilmington

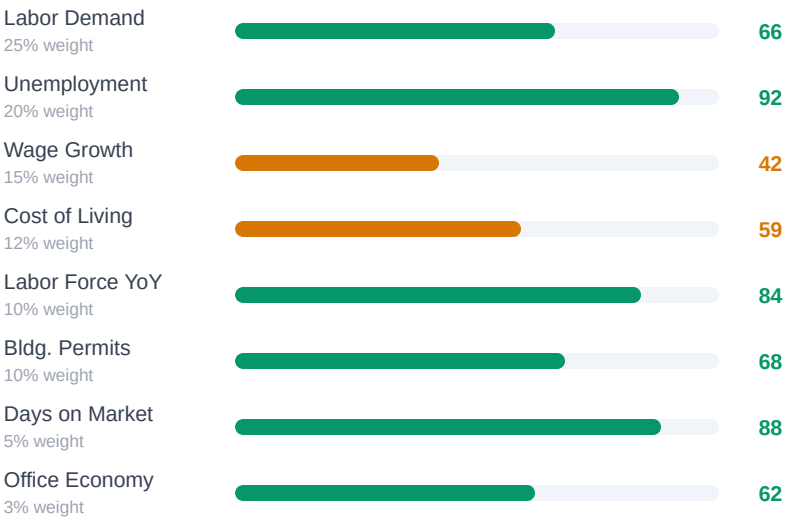
A

VERY GOOD

69.8th percentile

Rank 7 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT **3.6%** of civilian labor force	WAGE GROWTH YOY **+3.5%** avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH **+0.5%** nonfarm payrolls YoY	LABOR FORCE YOY **+1.0%** civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS **+11.5%** residential YoY (3mo avg)	DAYS ON MARKET **48 days** median, +11.6% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

STRONG

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Philadelphia-Camden-Wilmington metro area has earned an overall grade of A, ranking in the 69.8th percentile among 50 US metros. This city's economic character is defined by its strong labor demand, with a composite score of 5.97, and its low unemployment rate of 3.60%, which ranks in the 92nd percentile. The combination of these metrics suggests a city with a tight labor market and genuine demand expansion.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Philadelphia-Camden-Wilmington is +0.49% year-over-year, and weekly hours are deviating +0.985% from the city's own 12-month baseline. This combination signals genuine demand expansion, as both jobs and hours are increasing, indicating a strong and growing labor market. The labor demand composite score of 5.97, ranking in the 66th percentile, further supports this assessment.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Philadelphia-Camden-Wilmington is 3.60%, ranking in the 92nd percentile, indicating a very tight labor market. This means that there is little slack in the market, making it challenging for businesses to hire new employees. As a result, businesses may face upward pressure on wages to attract and retain top talent.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate in Philadelphia-Camden-Wilmington is +3.53%, ranking in the 42nd percentile, indicating moderate wage growth. This rate suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but not excessively so, and worker purchasing power is increasing. However, the moderate pace of wage growth may not be sufficient to keep pace with the tight labor market.

Cost of Living

Philadelphia-Camden-Wilmington has a cost of living score ranking in the 59th percentile, with a PSF of $227/sqft and average hourly earnings of $32.96, resulting in a ratio of 6.89. This indicates that the city is relatively affordable compared to its peers, making it an attractive location for talent without requiring significant wage premiums. The fact that PSF is falling -1.3% year-over-year further enhances the city's affordability.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Philadelphia-Camden-Wilmington is growing at a rate of +1.03% year-over-year, ranking in the 84th percentile, indicating an expanding labor force supply. This growth suggests that the city has a strong pipeline of potential employees, making it easier for businesses to hire and expand their operations.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Philadelphia-Camden-Wilmington is increasing by +11.53% year-over-year, ranking in the 68th percentile, indicating an expansion of housing supply. This growth in permits suggests that the city is likely to experience improving affordability and a more accommodating environment for its workforce in the future.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Philadelphia-Camden-Wilmington is currently 48 days, with a year-over-year increase of +11.6%, ranking in the 88th percentile. This indicates a relatively slow market, making it more accessible for workers relocating to the city. The rising days on market suggests a healthy normalization of the housing market.

Office Economy

Philadelphia-Camden-Wilmington has a deep professional talent pool, with an office economy score ranking in the 62nd percentile. This makes the city well-suited for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors, which require a high concentration of specialized knowledge workers. However, the city may be less suitable for industries with more industrial or logistics-oriented workforces.

The Philadelphia-Camden-Wilmington metro area offers businesses a unique combination of strong labor demand, low unemployment, and moderate wage growth, making it an attractive location for companies looking to expand or relocate. However, the tight labor market and rising wages may pose a risk for businesses that are highly sensitive to labor costs, and decision-makers should carefully consider these factors when evaluating the city as a potential location.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #8 OF 50

Miami

Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach

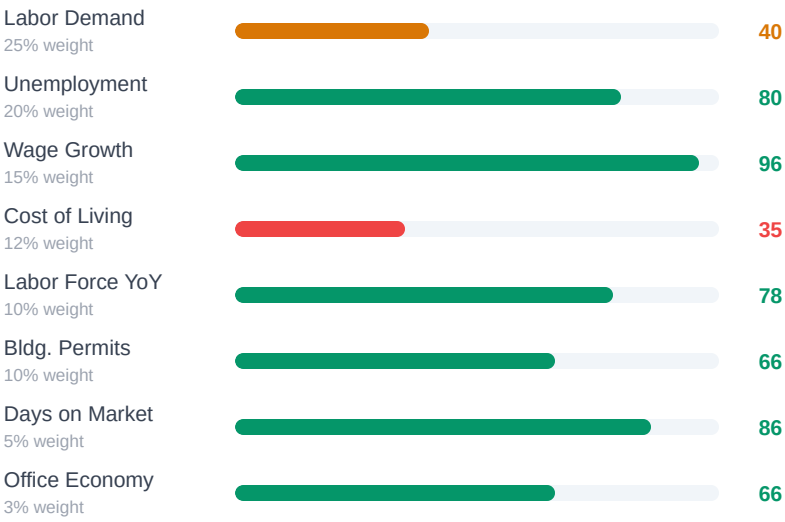
A-

GOOD

65.2th percentile

Rank 8 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT **3.2%** of civilian labor force	WAGE GROWTH YOY **+8.8%** avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH **+0.4%** nonfarm payrolls YoY	LABOR FORCE YOY **+0.9%** civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS **+11.3%** residential YoY (3mo avg)	DAYS ON MARKET **79 days** median, -8.1% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

STRONG

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach metro area has earned an overall grade of A- with a composite score ranking at the 65.2th percentile among 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its top-tier unemployment rate of 3.20% and exceptional wage growth of +8.76% year-over-year, indicating a highly competitive labor market. The combination of these metrics suggests a city with strong job demand and rising labor costs.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach is +0.44% year-over-year, accompanied by a negligible deviation in weekly hours from its own trend at +0.000%. This combination signals a genuine demand expansion, albeit at a moderate pace, as the city is adding jobs without overburdening its existing workforce. The labor demand composite score of 4.92 places it near the median, indicating a balanced labor market.

Unemployment

With an unemployment rate of 3.20%, Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach boasts a tight labor market, ranking in the top tier at the 80th percentile. This low unemployment rate implies that businesses may face challenges in hiring due to intense competition for a limited pool of available workers, potentially leading to upward pressure on wages. The practical implication for a business trying to hire here is the need for competitive compensation packages to attract top talent.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach stands at an impressive +8.76%, placing it in the top tier at the 96th percentile. This rapid wage growth signifies rising labor costs for employers but also enhances worker purchasing power, contributing to a robust local economy. As a result, businesses should anticipate higher labor expenses but also benefit from a workforce with increased disposable income.

Cost of Living

Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach has a cost of living score that ranks at the 35th percentile, indicating that it is below average in terms of affordability, with a PSF of $358/sqft and average hourly earnings of $35.70. Although the PSF has decreased by 0.6% year-over-year, the city remains relatively expensive compared to its peers. This means that attracting talent without offering wage premiums may be challenging, as the cost of living is a significant factor in relocation decisions.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach is growing at a rate of +0.90% year-over-year, which is above average and ranks at the 78th percentile. This expansion in the labor force supply suggests that the city has a growing pool of potential workers, making it easier for businesses to find and hire new employees. The implication for hiring capacity is positive, with a structurally supportive labor market.

Building Permits

The city has seen a +11.27% year-over-year increase in residential building permits, indicating an expansion in future housing supply. This growth in permits signals developer confidence in the market and suggests that affordability may improve over time, supporting workforce accommodation and attraction. As housing supply expands, the city is likely to become more competitive in retaining and attracting talent.

Days on Market

The current median days on market for homes in Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach is 79 days, with a year-over-year decrease of 8.1%, placing it in the top tier at the 86th percentile. This relatively fast market means that homes are selling quickly, which can be challenging for relocating workers. However, the decreasing trend in days on market suggests a normalization of the housing market, potentially making it more accessible for new residents in the future.

Office Economy

With an office/professional worker share composite score of 2.88, Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach has a deep talent pool that ranks above average at the 66th percentile. This makes the city well-suited for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors that rely on professional and office workers. Conversely, it may be less ideal for industries dominated by industrial or logistics roles.

In conclusion, Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach offers businesses a highly competitive labor market with strong job demand and rising labor costs, alongside a growing labor force and expanding housing supply. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the tight labor market and resulting upward pressure on wages, which may increase operational costs but also contribute to a vibrant local economy with high worker purchasing power.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #9 OF 50

Baltimore

Baltimore-Columbia-Towson

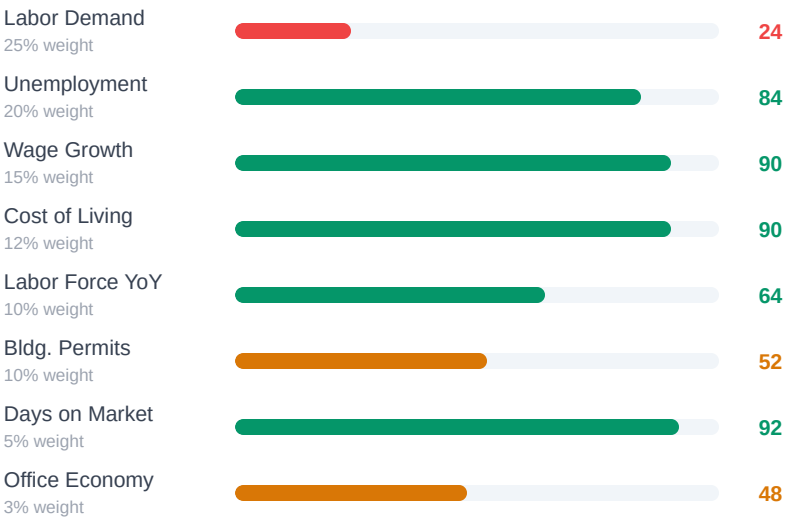
A-

GOOD

64.7th percentile

Rank 9 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT **3.5%** of civilian labor force	WAGE GROWTH YOY **+6.4%** avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH **-0.2%** nonfarm payrolls YoY	LABOR FORCE YOY **+0.4%** civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS **-2.8%** residential YoY (3mo avg)	DAYS ON MARKET **46 days** median, +12.2% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

SQUEEZE

Payrolls contracting while hours rise — survivor squeeze signal.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Baltimore-Columbia-Towson metro area has an overall grade of A- with a composite score ranking at the 64.7th percentile among 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its low unemployment rate of 3.50% and strong wage growth of +6.37% year-over-year, indicating a tight labor market with rising labor costs. The combination of these metrics suggests a competitive environment for businesses looking to attract and retain top talent.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Baltimore-Columbia-Towson is -0.16% year-over-year, while weekly hours are running 0.150% above trend. This combination signals a survivor squeeze, where remaining workers are absorbing the load of eliminated roles, rather than genuine demand expansion. The labor demand composite score of 3.93 ranks below average at the 24th percentile.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Baltimore-Columbia-Towson is 3.50%, ranking at the 84th percentile, indicating a very tight labor market. This means that businesses may face challenges in hiring, as the pool of available workers is relatively small, and may need to offer competitive wages to attract top talent. The tight market also implies upward pressure on wages.

Wage Growth

Wage growth in Baltimore-Columbia-Towson is +6.37% year-over-year, ranking at the 90th percentile, indicating fast-rising labor costs for employers. This strong wage growth is good for worker purchasing power, but may pose challenges for businesses looking to control labor costs. The rapid wage growth suggests a competitive labor market where workers have strong bargaining power.

Cost of Living

Baltimore-Columbia-Towson has a cost of living score ranking at the 90th percentile, with a PSF of $213/sqft, which is falling by 2.7% year-over-year, and an average hourly earnings of $37.72/hr, resulting in a ratio of 5.65. This indicates that the city is relatively affordable compared to its peers, making it an attractive location for talent without requiring significant wage premiums. The falling PSF is a key driver of the high affordability score.

Labor Force Growth

The labor force in Baltimore-Columbia-Towson is growing at a rate of +0.41% year-over-year, ranking at the 64th percentile, indicating a slowly expanding workforce supply. This moderate growth rate suggests that hiring capacity is relatively stable, but may not be able to keep pace with rapid business expansion. The growing labor force is a positive sign for businesses looking to hire.

Building Permits

The number of building permits in Baltimore-Columbia-Towson is decreasing by -2.77% year-over-year, ranking near the median at the 52nd percentile. This decline in permits suggests that housing supply may be tightening, which could lead to future affordability challenges and make it harder for workers to relocate to the area. The slowing permit growth is a concern for future workforce accommodation.

Days on Market

The median days on market in Baltimore-Columbia-Towson is 46 days, with a year-over-year increase of +12.2%, ranking at the 92nd percentile. This indicates a slower market, where homes are taking longer to sell, making it more accessible for workers relocating to the area. The rising days on market suggests a healthy normalization of the housing market.

Office Economy

Baltimore-Columbia-Towson has an office economy score ranking at the 48th percentile, with a share of professional and office workers at 2.50 out of 5. This suggests a moderately deep talent pool, making the city suited for businesses that require a mix of professional and non-professional roles. The city may not be the best fit for businesses that require a highly specialized or knowledge-intensive workforce.

The Baltimore-Columbia-Towson metro area offers businesses a unique combination of a tight labor market, strong wage growth, and relatively affordable cost of living, making it an attractive location for talent. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the potential for future affordability challenges and tightening housing supply, which could make it harder for workers to relocate to the area and pose challenges for businesses looking to expand.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #10 OF 50

Dallas

Dallas-Fort Worth-Arlington

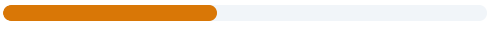
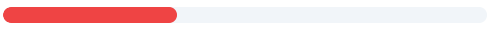
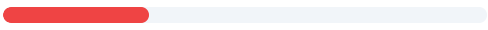
B+

ABOVE AVERAGE

63.3th percentile

Rank 10 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand 25% weight		76
Unemployment 20% weight		44
Wage Growth 15% weight		72
Cost of Living 12% weight		84
Labor Force YoY 10% weight		68
Bldg. Permits 10% weight		36
Days on Market 5% weight		30
Office Economy 3% weight		92

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT
4.1%
of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY
+4.7%
avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH
+1.0%
nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE YOY
+0.6%
civilian labor force growth

BUILDING PERMITS
-8.4%
residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET
64 days
median, 0.0% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

STRONG

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Dallas-Fort Worth-Arlington metro area has an overall grade of B+ with a composite score ranking at the 63.3th percentile among 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its strong labor demand, with a composite score in the 76th percentile, and its high office economy ranking, at the 92nd percentile, indicating a deep talent pool in professional sectors. The labor demand is driven by a combination of employment growth and hours worked above trend, signaling genuine demand expansion.

Labor Demand

The Dallas-Fort Worth-Arlington metro area has an employment growth rate of 1.02% year-over-year and weekly hours 0.694% above its own trend, indicating a strong labor market with genuine demand expansion. This combination signals that the city is adding jobs and workers are putting in more hours, a positive sign for businesses looking to expand. The labor demand composite score of 6.42 further reinforces this trend, ranking in the 76th percentile.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Dallas-Fort Worth-Arlington is 4.10%, ranking in the 44th percentile, indicating a near-median level of unemployment. This suggests that the labor market has some slack, making it relatively easier for businesses to hire compared to cities with tighter labor markets. However, this also means that local consumer demand may not be as strong as in cities with lower unemployment rates.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Dallas-Fort Worth-Arlington is 4.71%, ranking in the 72nd percentile, indicating above-average wage growth. This suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but workers are also experiencing increased purchasing power. As a result, businesses may need to factor in higher labor costs, but they can also benefit from a more affluent local consumer base.

Cost of Living

Dallas-Fort Worth-Arlington has a cost of living score in the 84th percentile, with a price-to-salary ratio of $197/sqft to $37.92/hr, or 5.20. The fact that the PSF is falling by 2.5% year-over-year relative to wages makes the city more affordable. This high affordability ranking means that the city has a talent attraction advantage, as workers can maintain a high standard of living without requiring significant wage premiums.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Dallas-Fort Worth-Arlington is growing at a rate of 0.64% year-over-year, ranking in the 68th percentile. This indicates that the workforce supply is expanding, which is a positive sign for businesses looking to hire. As the labor force grows,

companies can tap into a larger pool of potential employees, making it easier to find the right talent.

Building Permits

The number of building permits in Dallas-Fort Worth-Arlington has decreased by 8.41% year-over-year, ranking in the 36th percentile. This decline suggests that housing supply is tightening, which could lead to affordability issues and challenges in accommodating a growing workforce. As a result, businesses may need to consider the potential impact of a tightening housing market on their ability to attract and retain talent.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Dallas-Fort Worth-Arlington is 64 days, with no year-over-year change. This relatively fast pace of home sales, ranking in the 30th percentile, means that the market is competitive, and relocating workers may face challenges in finding affordable housing. However, this also suggests that the local real estate market is active and responsive to demand.

Office Economy

The office economy in Dallas-Fort Worth-Arlington is deep, with a professional and office worker share ranking in the 92nd percentile. This makes the city well-suited for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors, which require a high concentration of specialized talent. On the other hand, the city may be less suitable for industries that require a large workforce in industrial or logistics roles.

The Dallas-Fort Worth-Arlington metro area offers businesses a strong labor market with genuine demand expansion, a deep talent pool in professional sectors, and an affordable cost of living. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for businesses is the tightening housing market, which could lead to affordability issues and challenges in accommodating a growing workforce, making it essential for decision-makers to factor this into their location decisions.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #11 OF 50

Kansas City

Kansas City

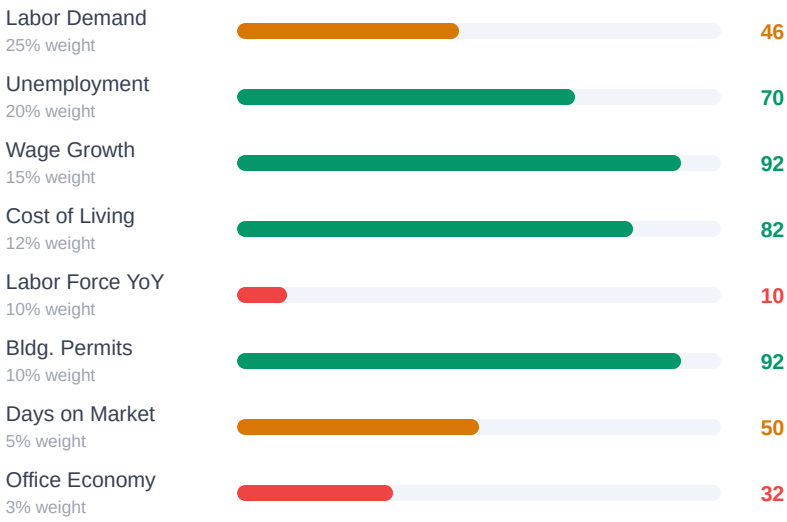
B+

ABOVE AVERAGE

62.8th percentile

Rank 11 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT **3.4%** of civilian labor force	WAGE GROWTH YOY **+7.6%** avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH **+0.5%** nonfarm payrolls YoY	LABOR FORCE YOY **-2.1%** civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS **+96.0%** residential YoY (3mo avg)	DAYS ON MARKET **52 days** median, +2.0% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

STRONG

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Kansas City earns an overall grade of B+ with a composite score ranking at the 62.8th percentile among 50 US metros. The city's economic character is most defined by its top-tier wage growth of 7.56% year-over-year and its strong building permits growth of 96.01% year-over-year, indicating a dynamic labor market and expanding housing supply. These metrics suggest a city with a growing economy and increasing demand for labor.

Labor Demand

Kansas City's labor demand composite score is 5.19, ranking near the median at the 46th percentile, driven by employment growth of 0.51% year-over-year and weekly hours 0.172% above trend. This combination signals genuine demand expansion, as hours are running above trend during a period of job growth. However, the modest employment growth rate suggests that this demand expansion is not overly aggressive.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Kansas City is 3.40%, ranking above average at the 70th percentile, indicating a relatively tight labor market. This tightness implies that businesses may face challenges in hiring, with upward pressure on wages. As a result, companies may need to offer competitive compensation packages to attract top talent.

Wage Growth

With a year-over-year wage growth rate of 7.56%, Kansas City ranks in the top tier at the 92nd percentile, signaling fast-rising labor costs for employers. This strong wage growth is beneficial for worker purchasing power, as employees can afford more goods and services. However, it may pose challenges for businesses looking to maintain profit margins.

Cost of Living

Kansas City's cost of living is relatively affordable, with a percentile rank of 82, driven by a PSF-to-earnings ratio of $194/sqft to $36.10/hr, or 5.37. Although PSF is rising 1.6% year-over-year, the city's affordability relative to peers remains high. This affordability advantage can attract talent without requiring significant wage premiums, making it an attractive location for businesses.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Kansas City is contracting at a rate of -2.12% year-over-year, ranking in the bottom tier at the 10th percentile. This decline in labor force supply poses a structural headwind for hiring, as businesses may struggle to find qualified candidates. Companies may need to invest in training and development programs to address this shortage.

Building Permits

Kansas City has seen a significant increase in building permits, with a year-over-year growth rate of 96.01%, ranking in the top tier at the 92nd percentile. This surge in permits suggests that housing supply is expanding, which should improve affordability and accommodate a growing workforce. As a result, businesses can expect a more stable and affordable housing market for their employees.

Days on Market

The median days on market in Kansas City is 52 days, with a year-over-year increase of 2.0%, ranking near the median at the 50th percentile. This relatively stable market indicates that homes are selling at a moderate pace, making it accessible for relocating workers to find housing. However, the rising trend may signal a slight normalization of the market.

Office Economy

Kansas City's professional and office worker share is below average, ranking at the 32nd percentile, with a composite score of 2.20. This suggests a relatively shallow talent pool for tech, finance, and consulting businesses. While the city may not be ideal for headquarters or high-end professional services, it could be suitable for industries with more diverse labor needs, such as logistics or manufacturing.

In conclusion, Kansas City offers a dynamic labor market with strong wage growth and an expanding housing supply, making it an attractive location for businesses. However, the city's contracting labor force supply poses a significant risk, and decision-makers should carefully consider strategies to address this challenge, such as investing in workforce development programs or exploring alternative talent pipelines.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #12 OF 50

Orlando

Orlando-Kissimmee-Sanford

B+

ABOVE AVERAGE

61.0th percentile

Rank 12 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	72
Unemployment	20% weight	32
Wage Growth	15% weight	86
Cost of Living	12% weight	65
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	70
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	28
Days on Market	5% weight	68
Office Economy	3% weight	90

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT
4.2%
of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY
+6.0%
avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH
+1.0%
nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE YOY
+0.7%
civilian labor force growth

BUILDING PERMITS
-12.2%
residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET
78 days
median, -3.7% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

STRONG

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Orlando-Kissimmee-Sanford metro area has earned an overall grade of B+ with a composite score ranking it at the 61.0th percentile among 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its strong labor demand, with a composite score in the 72nd percentile, and its top-tier wage growth, which stands at 6.00% year-over-year. These metrics signal a city with a robust job market and increasing labor costs.

Labor Demand

The Orlando-Kissimmee-Sanford metro area has seen employment growth of 0.96% year-over-year, combined with a 0.635% deviation in weekly hours above its own trend. This combination signals genuine demand expansion, as both jobs and hours worked are increasing, indicating a strong and growing labor market. This suggests that businesses can expect to find a vibrant and dynamic workforce in the area.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Orlando-Kissimmee-Sanford stands at 4.20%, which ranks in the 32nd percentile, indicating a below-average level of unemployment. This tight labor market means that businesses may face challenges in hiring, as well as upward pressure on wages. As a result, companies may need to offer competitive salaries and benefits to attract top talent in this market.

Wage Growth

With a year-over-year wage growth rate of 6.00%, Orlando-Kissimmee-Sanford is experiencing rapid labor cost increases, ranking in the 86th percentile. This fast wage growth is a double-edged sword, as it benefits workers' purchasing power but also increases labor costs for employers. Businesses should factor in these rising costs when considering relocation or expansion in the area.

Cost of Living

Orlando-Kissimmee-Sanford has a cost of living score that ranks in the 65th percentile, with a price-to-salary ratio of $222/sqft to $33.42/hr, or 6.64. The fact that PSF is falling by 2.6% year-over-year relative to wages makes the city more affordable. This affordability advantage can be a significant talent attraction factor, as workers can maintain a high standard of living without requiring excessive wage premiums.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Orlando-Kissimmee-Sanford is growing at a rate of 0.69% year-over-year, indicating an expanding workforce supply. This positive growth rate suggests that businesses can expect a steady stream of new workers to recruit from, making it easier to fill open positions and support expansion plans.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Orlando-Kissimmee-Sanford has decreased by 12.18% year-over-year, indicating a tightening housing supply. This decline in permits may signal future affordability challenges and potential constraints on workforce accommodation, as a limited housing stock can drive up prices and make it harder for workers to relocate to the area.

Days on Market

The current median days on market for homes in Orlando-Kissimmee-Sanford is 78 days, with a year-over-year decrease of 3.7%. This relatively fast pace of home sales, combined with the declining days on market, indicates a competitive housing market that may be challenging for relocating workers to navigate. However, this also suggests a strong and active real estate market.

Office Economy

Orlando-Kissimmee-Sanford has a deep professional talent pool, with an office economy score ranking in the 90th percentile. This makes the city an attractive location for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors, which require a high concentration of specialized knowledge workers. Conversely, the city may be less suited for industries with more industrial or logistics-oriented workforces.

The Orlando-Kissimmee-Sanford metro area offers businesses a unique combination of strong labor demand, rapid wage growth, and a relatively affordable cost of living. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers to consider is the tightening housing supply, which may lead to future affordability challenges and constraints on workforce accommodation, potentially offsetting some of the city's attractive economic features.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #13 OF 50

Cincinnati

Cincinnati

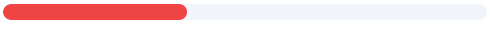
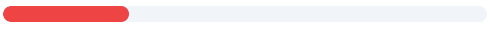
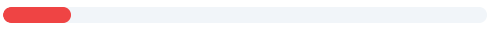
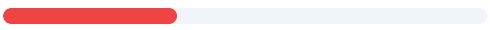
B+

ABOVE AVERAGE

60.0th percentile

Rank 13 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand 25% weight		38
Unemployment 20% weight		74
Wage Growth 15% weight		98
Cost of Living 12% weight		92
Labor Force YoY 10% weight		26
Bldg. Permits 10% weight		14
Days on Market 5% weight		98
Office Economy 3% weight		36

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT
3.6%
of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY
+8.9%
avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH
+0.4%
nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE YOY
-1.2%
civilian labor force growth

BUILDING PERMITS
-20.2%
residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET
44 days
median, +15.8% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

GROWING

Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Cincinnati earns an overall grade of B+ with a composite score ranking it at the 60.0th percentile among 50 US metros. The city's economic character is most defined by its exceptionally high wage growth, with hourly earnings rising 8.92% year-over-year, and its relatively low unemployment rate of 3.60%, which ranks in the 74th percentile. These metrics suggest a city with a strong labor market, but also one that may pose challenges for businesses looking to hire and retain talent.

Labor Demand

Cincinnati's employment growth rate is 0.43% year-over-year, while weekly hours are deviating -0.149% from the city's own 12-month baseline. This combination signals a labor demand environment that is not particularly robust, with hours worked not increasing significantly despite some job growth, indicating a potential survivor squeeze where remaining workers may be absorbing the load of eliminated roles.

Unemployment

The city's unemployment rate of 3.60% indicates a relatively tight labor market, ranking in the 74th percentile. This means that businesses may face challenges in finding and hiring qualified candidates, and may need to offer competitive wages to attract top talent.

Wage Growth

With a year-over-year wage growth rate of 8.92%, Cincinnati is experiencing rapid increases in labor costs, which may be a challenge for employers. However, this also means that workers have strong purchasing power, which can be beneficial for businesses that rely on local consumer demand.

Cost of Living

Cincinnati's cost of living is relatively affordable, with a percentile rank of 92, driven by a PSF of $189/sqft that is decreasing by 0.5% year-over-year, and an average hourly wage of $36.19. This makes the city an attractive location for talent, as workers can afford a high quality of life without requiring significant wage premiums.

Labor Force Growth

The city's labor force is contracting at a rate of -1.16% year-over-year, indicating a shrinking labor pool. This poses a structural headwind for hiring, as businesses may struggle to find qualified candidates to fill open positions.

Building Permits

The number of building permits in Cincinnati is decreasing by 20.21% year-over-year, indicating a tightening of the housing supply. This signals potential future affordability challenges and may make it more difficult for workers to relocate to the city, which could impact

businesses' ability to attract and retain talent.

Days on Market

Homes in Cincinnati are currently sitting on the market for 44 days, with a year-over-year increase of 15.8%. This suggests a slower market, which can be beneficial for workers relocating to the city, as they may have more time to find a suitable home.

Office Economy

Cincinnati's professional talent pool is relatively shallow, ranking in the 36th percentile. The city is best suited for businesses that do not require a deep pool of specialized office workers, such as industrial or logistics companies, and may not be the best fit for tech, finance, or consulting firms that rely on a strong knowledge economy.

In conclusion, Cincinnati offers businesses a unique combination of high wage growth and relatively low unemployment, making it an attractive location for companies that can navigate its tight labor market. However, the city's shrinking labor force and tightening housing supply pose significant risks that decision-makers should carefully consider when evaluating Cincinnati as a potential location.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #14 OF 50

Las Vegas

Las Vegas-Henderson-North Las Vegas

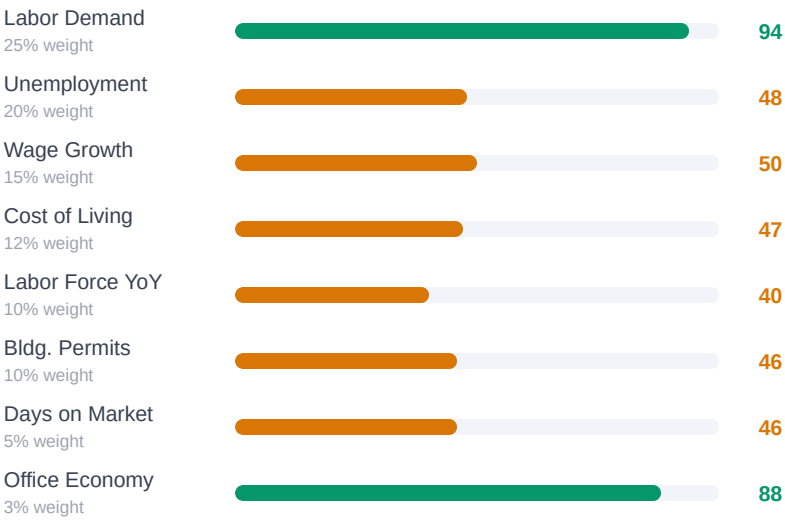
B

AVERAGE

59.8th percentile

Rank 14 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT **4.8%** of civilian labor force	WAGE GROWTH YOY **+3.6%** avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH **+1.7%** nonfarm payrolls YoY	LABOR FORCE YOY **-0.6%** civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS **-4.9%** residential YoY (3mo avg)	DAYS ON MARKET **59 days** median, +1.7% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

STRONG

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Las Vegas-Henderson-North Las Vegas metro area has an overall grade of B, ranking in the 59.8th percentile among 50 US metros, with a composite score driven primarily by its strong labor demand and deep office economy. The city's labor demand composite score of 7.82, which combines a 1.73% employment growth rate and a 1.097% weekly hours deviation above trend, signals genuine demand expansion. This is further supported by its top-tier percentile ranks in both employment growth and weekly hours deviation, at 94th percentile for both metrics.

Labor Demand

The Las Vegas-Henderson-North Las Vegas metro area has a labor demand composite score of 7.82, driven by a 1.73% employment growth rate and a 1.097% weekly hours deviation above trend, indicating genuine demand expansion. This combination signals that the city is adding jobs and workers are putting in more hours, a sign of a strong and growing economy. The top-tier percentile ranks in both employment growth and weekly hours deviation, at 94th percentile for both metrics, further support this assessment.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Las Vegas-Henderson-North Las Vegas is 4.80%, ranking in the 48th percentile, indicating a near-median level of slack in the labor market. This rate suggests that while the market is not extremely tight, it is also not overly loose, making it moderately challenging for businesses to hire. However, the relatively moderate unemployment rate implies that businesses may face some competition for talent, but not to the extent that it significantly drives up wages.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Las Vegas-Henderson-North Las Vegas is 3.65%, ranking in the 50th percentile, indicating a moderate pace of wage increases. This rate suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but not at an alarming rate, while workers are seeing their purchasing power increase. The moderate wage growth implies a relatively stable labor cost environment, which can be beneficial for businesses looking to manage their expenses.

Cost of Living

Las Vegas-Henderson-North Las Vegas has a cost of living score that ranks in the 47th percentile, with a PSF of $258/sqft and an average hourly wage of $32.90, resulting in a ratio of 7.84. The city's cost of living is near median, but the 2.6% year-over-year decrease in PSF suggests that it is becoming more affordable. This affordability can be a talent attraction advantage, as workers may not require significant wage premiums to maintain their standard of living.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Las Vegas-Henderson-North Las Vegas is growing at a rate of -0.59% year-over-year, ranking in the 40th percentile, indicating a contracting labor pool. This contraction implies a structural headwind for hiring, as the supply of available workers is shrinking. Businesses may need to consider strategies to attract talent from other areas or invest in workforce development programs to address the shrinking labor pool.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Las Vegas-Henderson-North Las Vegas has decreased by 4.90% year-over-year, ranking in the 46th percentile, indicating a tightening housing supply. This decrease suggests that the city's housing market may become less affordable in the future, potentially affecting workforce attraction and accommodation. The decline in building permits may lead to increased competition for housing, driving up costs and making it more challenging for businesses to attract and retain talent.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Las Vegas-Henderson-North Las Vegas is 59 days, with a year-over-year increase of 1.7%, ranking in the 46th percentile. This increase indicates a slightly slower market, which can be beneficial for workers relocating to the city, as they may have more time to find a suitable home. However, the relatively moderate days on market suggests that the housing market is still relatively competitive.

Office Economy

The share of jobs in professional and office sectors in Las Vegas-Henderson-North Las Vegas is 3.86, ranking in the 88th percentile, indicating a deep talent pool suited for tech, finance, consulting, and HQ decisions. This city is well-suited for businesses that require a high concentration of specialized knowledge workers, but may not be as suitable for industries with more industrial or logistics-oriented workforces.

The Las Vegas-Henderson-North Las Vegas metro area offers businesses a strong labor demand and a deep office economy, making it an attractive location for companies in the tech, finance, and consulting sectors. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for businesses considering this location is the contracting labor pool, which may lead to challenges in attracting and retaining talent, and the potential for a tightening housing supply, which could drive up costs and affect workforce accommodation.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #15 OF 50

Pittsburgh

Pittsburgh

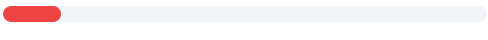
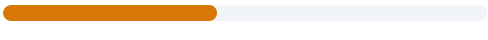
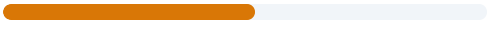
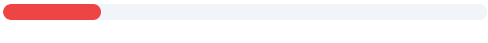
B

AVERAGE

56.9th percentile

Rank 15 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand (25% weight)		12
Unemployment (20% weight)		96
Wage Growth (15% weight)		44
Cost of Living (12% weight)		88
Labor Force YoY (10% weight)		58
Bldg. Permits (10% weight)		86
Days on Market (5% weight)		52
Office Economy (3% weight)		20

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT
3.0%
of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY
+3.5%
avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH
-0.5%
nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE YOY
+0.2%
civilian labor force growth

BUILDING PERMITS
+26.4%
residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET
57 days
median, +5.6% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

SQUEEZE

Payrolls contracting while hours rise — survivor squeeze signal.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Pittsburgh earns an overall grade of B, ranking in the 56.9th percentile among 50 US metros, with a composite score defined largely by its low unemployment rate of 3.00% and a cost of living score that indicates affordability, with a PSF to wages ratio of 4.95. The city's labor demand and office economy metrics, however, suggest challenges, with a labor demand composite score of 3.17 and an office/professional worker share ranking in the 20th percentile. These numbers suggest a complex economic environment that offers both advantages and disadvantages for businesses considering relocation.

Labor Demand

Pittsburgh's employment growth rate is -0.54% year-over-year, combined with a weekly hours deviation of +0.372% from its own trend, signaling a scenario where hours are increasing during a period of job losses, which may indicate a survivor squeeze. This suggests that while there is some level of demand, it is not translating into significant job growth. The labor demand composite score of 3.17 ranks in the bottom tier, at the 12th percentile, indicating that the city is not experiencing genuine demand expansion.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Pittsburgh is 3.00%, ranking in the top tier at the 96th percentile, which means the market is tight. This tight labor market implies that businesses may face challenges in hiring, with more wage pressure as a result of the low unemployment rate. Companies looking to expand or relocate here may need to offer competitive salaries to attract talent.

Wage Growth

Wage growth in Pittsburgh is +3.55% year-over-year, placing it near the median at the 44th percentile. This moderate wage growth suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but not at an alarming rate, while workers are experiencing an increase in purchasing power. This balance could be attractive for businesses looking for a stable labor cost environment without sacrificing worker morale.

Cost of Living

Pittsburgh's cost of living, with a PSF of $168/sqft and wages of $33.92/hr, results in a ratio of 4.95, ranking in the top tier at the 88th percentile, indicating that the city is more affordable compared to its peers. The PSF has decreased by -1.8% year-over-year, contributing to its high affordability score. This affordability is a significant talent attraction advantage, as businesses can offer competitive wages without needing large premiums to offset the cost of living.

Labor Force Growth

The labor force in Pittsburgh is growing at a rate of +0.22% year-over-year, ranking near the median at the 58th percentile. This positive growth indicates that the workforce supply is expanding, albeit slowly, which is a positive sign for businesses looking to hire. However, the

slow pace of growth may not keep up with rapid expansion plans.

Building Permits

The city has seen a +26.35% year-over-year increase in building permits, ranking in the top tier at the 86th percentile. This significant increase in residential building permits suggests that housing supply is expanding, which should improve affordability and accommodate a growing workforce. This is a positive signal for future workforce attraction and retention.

Days on Market

Homes in Pittsburgh are currently sitting on the market for a median of 57 days, with a year-over-year increase of +5.6%. This places the city near the median in terms of market speed, at the 52nd percentile. For workers relocating to the city, this indicates a relatively accessible market, neither overly competitive nor excessively slow, making it easier for new hires to find housing.

Office Economy

Pittsburgh's office economy, with an office/professional worker share ranking in the 20th percentile, indicates a less deep talent pool in professional and office sectors compared to other cities. This suggests that the city may be less suited for businesses in tech, finance, consulting, or HQ operations that require a dense knowledge-economy talent pool, but could be more appropriate for industries with different workforce needs.

In conclusion, Pittsburgh offers businesses a unique combination of a tight labor market, moderate wage growth, and an affordable cost of living, which can be attractive for talent retention and recruitment without excessive wage premiums. However, the city's slow labor force growth and limited office economy talent pool present challenges, particularly for businesses reliant on professional and office sectors, making these factors crucial to consider in relocation decisions.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #16 OF 50

Nashville

Nashville-Davidson--Murfreesboro--Franklin

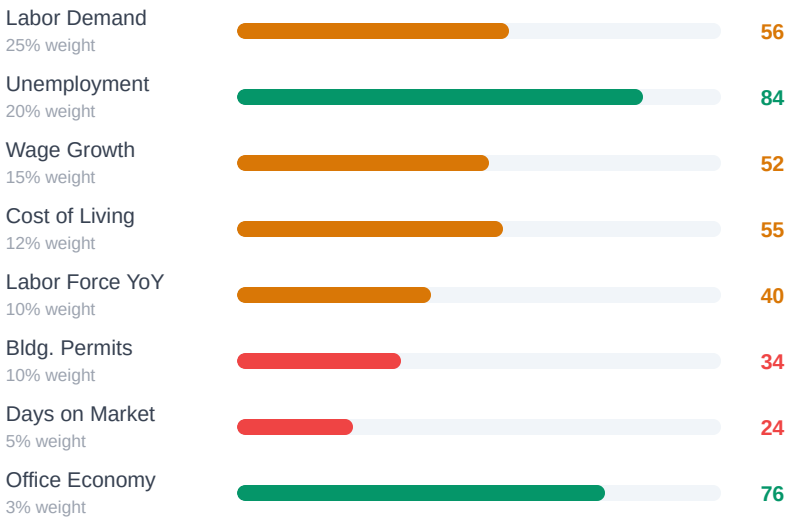
B

AVERAGE

56.1th percentile

Rank 16 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT **2.9%** of civilian labor force	WAGE GROWTH YOY **+3.7%** avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH **+1.1%** nonfarm payrolls YoY	LABOR FORCE YOY **-0.6%** civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS **-8.9%** residential YoY (3mo avg)	DAYS ON MARKET **63 days** median, +3.3% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

GROWING

Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Nashville-Davidson--Murfreesboro--Franklin metro area has an overall grade of B, ranking in the 56.1th percentile among 50 US metros, with a composite score reflecting a near-median performance across most metrics. The city's economic character is most defined by its low unemployment rate of 2.90% and its moderate wage growth of 3.72% year-over-year. These metrics suggest a relatively tight labor market with some upward pressure on wages.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Nashville is 1.05% year-over-year, combined with a -0.141% deviation in weekly hours from its own trend, signaling a near-median labor demand composite score of 5.63. This combination indicates a modest expansion in jobs but with hours worked slightly below trend, suggesting some genuine demand but not at an accelerated pace. The labor market is thus characterized by slow and steady growth rather than rapid expansion.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Nashville stands at 2.90%, placing it in the top tier at the 84th percentile, indicating a very tight labor market. This low unemployment rate means that businesses may face challenges in hiring due to the scarcity of available workers, potentially leading to upward wage pressure. For a business trying to hire in this market, the tight labor conditions imply a need for competitive compensation packages.

Wage Growth

Nashville experiences a year-over-year wage growth of 3.72%, which is near the median, ranking in the 52nd percentile. This moderate wage growth suggests that labor costs for employers are increasing, but not at an alarming rate, while workers see their purchasing power rise. The implication is a balanced environment where employers face manageable labor cost increases, and workers enjoy some improvement in their standard of living.

Cost of Living

With a cost of living ratio of $259/sqft to $35.86/hr, resulting in a ratio of 7.22, and considering the PSF is falling by -1.1% year-over-year, Nashville ranks near the median in terms of affordability, at the 55th percentile. This affordability level means that the city does not offer a significant talent attraction advantage without wage premiums, as the cost of living, while not high, does not particularly stand out as low compared to peer cities.

Labor Force Growth

The labor force in Nashville is growing at a rate of -0.59% year-over-year, indicating a contraction in the labor pool. This negative growth rate suggests that the supply of potential workers is shrinking, which could pose a structural headwind for businesses looking to hire, making it more challenging to find and recruit talent.

Building Permits

The city has seen a -8.95% year-over-year change in residential building permits, ranking below average at the 34th percentile. This decline in building permits signals that the housing supply is tightening, which could lead to future affordability issues and challenges in accommodating a growing workforce, potentially deterring businesses that rely on a readily available and affordable housing stock for their employees.

Days on Market

Homes in Nashville are currently sitting on the market for 63 days, with a year-over-year increase of 3.3%. This situation indicates a slightly slower market, which could be beneficial for workers relocating to the city, as it may provide them with more options and less competitive pressure when searching for housing.

Office Economy

Nashville has a deep professional talent pool, with an office/professional worker share composite score ranking above average at the 76th percentile. This makes the city well-suited for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors that rely on a knowledgeable and skilled workforce, but less ideal for industries with primarily industrial or logistics-oriented roles.

The bottom line for a business considering Nashville as a location is that it offers a tight labor market with moderate wage growth and a relatively balanced cost of living, but the single biggest risk or constraint is the shrinking labor force and tightening housing supply, which could impact future hiring capacity and workforce accommodation. Despite these challenges, the city's deep professional talent pool remains a significant advantage for certain types of businesses. Overall, Nashville presents a mixed bag that requires careful consideration of these factors in any location decision.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #17 OF 50

Los Angeles

Los Angeles-Long Beach-Anaheim

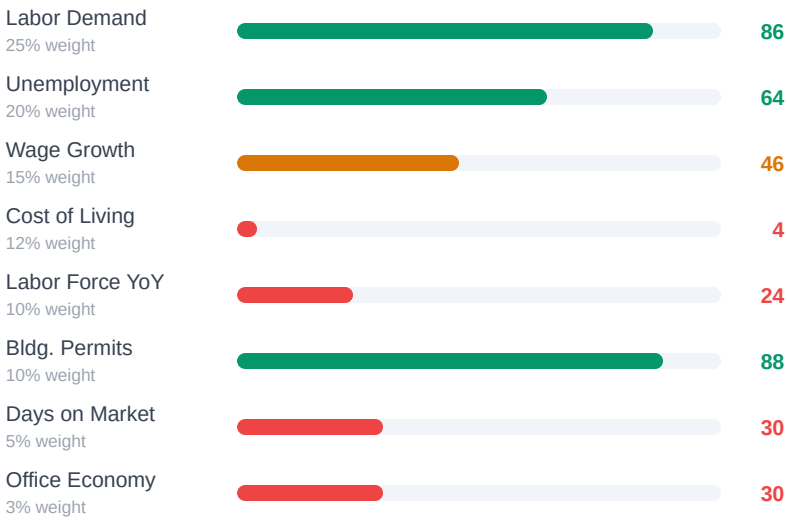
B

AVERAGE

55.3th percentile

Rank 17 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT **4.4%** of civilian labor force	WAGE GROWTH YOY **+3.6%** avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH **+1.8%** nonfarm payrolls YoY	LABOR FORCE YOY **-1.3%** civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS **+27.3%** residential YoY (3mo avg)	DAYS ON MARKET **57 days** median, 0.0% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

STRONG

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Los Angeles-Long Beach-Anaheim metro area has an overall grade of B, ranking at the 55.3th percentile among 50 US metros, with a composite score driven largely by its strong labor demand and building permits growth. The city's labor demand composite score of 7.11, combining a 1.83% employment growth rate and a 0.253% weekly hours deviation above trend, signals genuine demand expansion. This, along with a 27.28% year-over-year increase in building permits, defines the city's current economic character.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate of 1.83% and weekly hours deviation of 0.253% above trend indicate a strong labor market with genuine demand expansion. This combination signals that the city is adding jobs at a rate above the national average and that workers are putting in more hours, suggesting a healthy and growing economy. The labor demand composite score of 7.11, ranking in the 86th percentile, further reinforces this assessment.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate of 4.40% places the city in the 64th percentile, indicating a relatively tight labor market with some slack. For businesses trying to hire, this means they may face moderate competition for talent, but it's still possible to find qualified candidates without excessive wage pressure. The unemployment rate suggests a balance between labor supply and demand.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate of 3.57% is near the median, ranking in the 46th percentile. This moderate wage growth suggests that labor costs for employers are increasing, but not at an alarming rate, while workers see a modest improvement in their purchasing power. The wage growth rate is neither exceptionally high nor stagnant, indicating a stable labor cost environment.

Cost of Living

With a cost of living ratio of $642/sqft to $41.84/hr, resulting in a ratio of 15.34, and a percentile rank of 4, the city is relatively expensive compared to its peers. The fact that PSF is falling by 3.0% year-over-year slightly mitigates this, but the city remains one of the more expensive options. This high cost of living could make it challenging to attract talent without offering wage premiums.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force is contracting at a rate of -1.27% year-over-year, ranking in the 24th percentile. This decline in labor force supply indicates a structural headwind for hiring, as the pool of potential workers is shrinking. Businesses may need to adapt their recruitment strategies or consider relocation to areas with growing labor forces.

Building Permits

The 27.28% year-over-year increase in building permits, ranking in the 88th percentile, signals a significant expansion in housing supply. This growth in residential construction suggests that the city is poised to improve its affordability and accommodate a growing workforce, which could attract more businesses and talent in the future.

Days on Market

The current median days on market is 57 days, with a year-over-year change of 0.0%, ranking in the 30th percentile. This indicates a relatively fast-paced market where homes sell quickly, which could make it challenging for relocating workers to find housing. The stable days on market suggests that the housing market is not experiencing significant fluctuations.

Office Economy

With an office/professional worker share composite score of 2.08, ranking in the 30th percentile, the city has a relatively shallow professional talent pool. This makes it less suited for businesses in tech, finance, consulting, or HQ decisions that require deep knowledge-economy talent, but it might be more appropriate for industries with different workforce needs.

The Los Angeles-Long Beach-Anaheim metro area offers a strong labor demand and an expanding housing supply, making it an attractive location for businesses looking to grow. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the high cost of living, which could necessitate wage premiums to attract and retain talent, potentially offsetting some of the benefits of the city's strong labor market and growing economy.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #18 OF 50

Memphis

Memphis

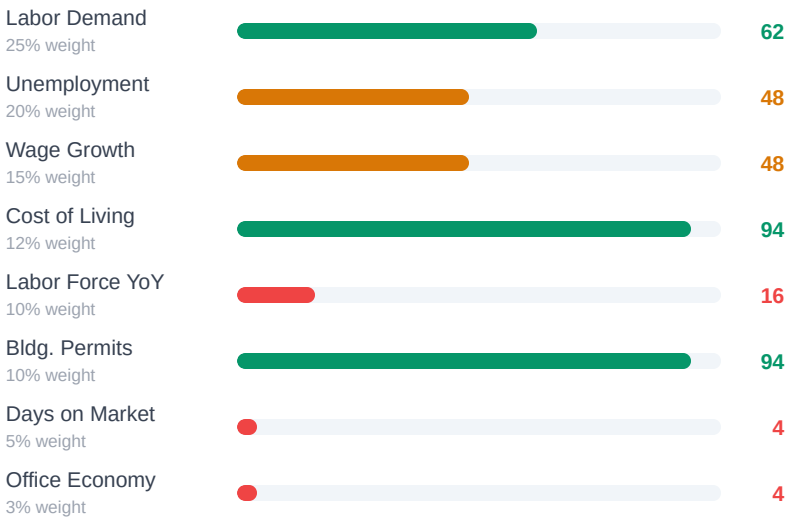
B-

BELOW AVERAGE

54.9th percentile

Rank 18 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT **4.1%** of civilian labor force	WAGE GROWTH YOY **+3.6%** avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH **+0.2%** nonfarm payrolls YoY	LABOR FORCE YOY **-1.7%** civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS **+113.0%** residential YoY (3mo avg)	DAYS ON MARKET **73 days** median, +7.3% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

STRONG

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Memphis, with an overall grade of B- and a composite score ranking at the 54.9th percentile among 50 US metros, is characterized by its above-average labor demand and highly affordable cost of living. The city's labor demand composite score of 5.71, driven by a +0.17% employment growth rate and +1.176% weekly hours deviation from its own trend, signals genuine demand expansion. Additionally, its cost of living, with a PSF of $152/sqft and a ratio of 4.59 to hourly earnings of $33.13, ranks in the 94th percentile for affordability.

Labor Demand

Memphis exhibits a +0.17% employment growth rate and a +1.176% deviation in weekly hours from its own trend, indicating genuine demand expansion. This combination suggests that the city is adding jobs and workers are putting in more hours, a sign of a strong labor market. The labor demand composite score of 5.71 further supports this assessment, ranking in the 62nd percentile.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Memphis stands at 4.10%, placing it near the median in terms of labor market tightness. This rate suggests that while the market is not overly tight, it does have some slack, making it somewhat easier for businesses to hire compared to tighter markets. However, this also means that local consumer demand might not be as strong as in areas with lower unemployment rates.

Wage Growth

Memphis experiences a year-over-year wage growth rate of +3.62%, which is near the median. This moderate wage growth indicates that labor costs for employers are increasing, but not at an alarming rate, and worker purchasing power is also growing, albeit not rapidly. This balance suggests a relatively stable labor cost environment.

Cost of Living

With a cost of living ranking in the 94th percentile, Memphis is highly affordable compared to its peers, especially considering its PSF is $152/sqft and has been falling by -1.9% YoY relative to wages of $33.13/hr. This affordability is a significant talent attraction advantage, as businesses can offer competitive wages without needing large premiums to offset high living costs.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Memphis is contracting at a rate of -1.73% year-over-year, indicating a shrinking labor pool. This contraction poses a structural headwind for hiring, as the supply of potential workers is decreasing, which could lead to increased competition for available talent.

Building Permits

Memphis has seen a significant increase of +112.99% in residential building permits year-over-year, signaling an expansion in future housing supply. This growth in permits suggests that developer confidence is high, and the city is likely to see improvements in affordability and an easier time accommodating a growing workforce in the future.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Memphis is 73 days, with a year-over-year increase of +7.3%. This indicates a slower market, where homes are sitting longer before being sold. For workers relocating to Memphis, this could be beneficial, as it suggests a more accessible and less competitive housing market.

Office Economy

Memphis has a relatively shallow professional talent pool, ranking in the 4th percentile for the share of jobs in professional and office sectors. This makes the city less suited for businesses requiring deep knowledge-economy talent, such as tech, finance, or consulting firms, but potentially more suitable for industries with different workforce needs.

In conclusion, Memphis offers businesses an affordable cost of living and a labor market with genuine demand expansion, making it an attractive location for certain types of industries. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the city's contracting labor force, which could lead to challenges in finding and hiring the necessary talent, potentially offsetting some of the location's other advantages.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #19 OF 50

Tampa

Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater

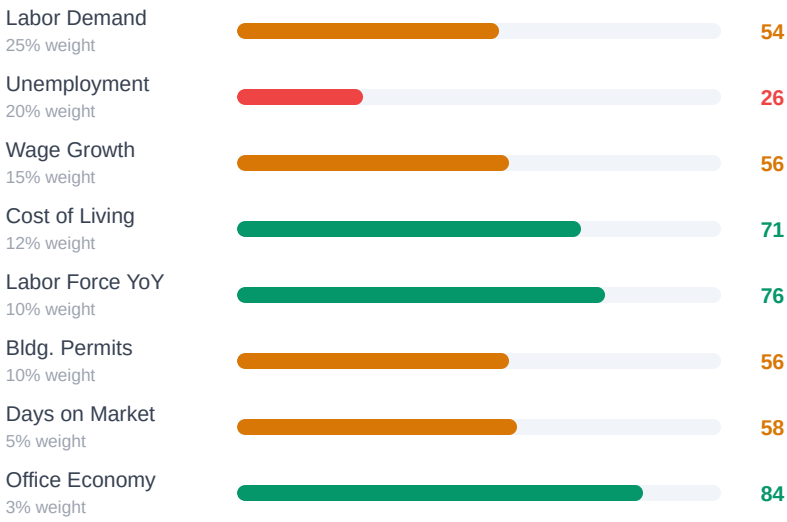
B-

BELOW AVERAGE

54.3th percentile

Rank 19 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT **4.3%** of civilian labor force	WAGE GROWTH YOY **+4.0%** avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH **+1.1%** nonfarm payrolls YoY	LABOR FORCE YOY **+0.8%** civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS **+3.7%** residential YoY (3mo avg)	DAYS ON MARKET **77 days** median, -2.5% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

GROWING

Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater metro area has an overall grade of B- with a composite score ranking at the 54.3th percentile among 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its near-median labor demand composite score of 5.60 and its above-average labor force growth rate of 0.77% YoY. The labor demand and labor force growth metrics suggest a city with a relatively stable but not exceptional job market.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater is 1.05% YoY, combined with a weekly hours deviation of -0.168% from its own trend, indicating a near-median labor demand. This combination signals a moderate expansion of jobs but with hours worked slightly below trend, suggesting some degree of labor market stability rather than strong demand expansion. The labor demand composite score of 5.60 further reinforces this interpretation.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater stands at 4.30%, ranking at the 26th percentile, which indicates a below-average performance and suggests a labor market with some slack. This rate implies that while it may not be overly challenging to find workers, the market is not as tight as in other cities, potentially offering a bit more flexibility for businesses looking to hire. However, the relatively higher unemployment compared to other metros could also signal weaker local consumer demand.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater is 3.99%, placing it near the median. This moderate wage growth rate suggests that labor costs for employers are increasing but not at an alarming rate, while workers see their purchasing power rise. The wage growth is neither exceptionally high nor stagnant, indicating a balanced labor market where both employers and employees can negotiate from a position of relative stability.

Cost of Living

With a cost of living ratio of $232/sqft (which has decreased by 5.7% YoY) to $36.77/hr, Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater ranks at the 71st percentile in terms of affordability. This high percentile rank indicates that the city is more affordable compared to its peers, making it an attractive location for talent without necessitating significant wage premiums. The decreasing PSF relative to wages is a key driver of this affordability, enhancing the city's appeal for both workers and businesses.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater is growing at a rate of 0.77% YoY, which is above average and indicates an expanding workforce supply. This growth suggests that the city has a structural advantage in terms of hiring capacity, as the pool of potential workers is increasing. Businesses looking to expand or relocate may find this growth beneficial for their staffing needs.

Building Permits

The city has seen a 3.72% year-over-year increase in residential building permits, which is near the median. This increase indicates that housing supply is slowly expanding, which could improve affordability and accommodate a growing workforce. However, the moderate pace of expansion may not keep up with demand, potentially leading to future affordability challenges if not adequately addressed.

Days on Market

Homes in Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater currently sit on the market for a median of 77 days, with a year-over-year decrease of 2.5%. This relatively fast market, given the context of a strong job market, suggests that relocating workers may face a competitive environment when searching for housing. The decreasing days on market further indicate a seller's market, which could pose challenges for talent attraction and retention due to housing accessibility issues.

Office Economy

Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater has a deep professional talent pool, ranking at the 84th percentile in terms of the share of jobs in professional and office sectors. This makes the city particularly well-suited for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors that rely on a knowledgeable and skilled workforce. Conversely, it may be less ideal for industries that are more industrial or logistics-dominant.

In conclusion, Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater offers a balanced labor market with moderate growth and affordability advantages, making it an attractive location for a variety of businesses, especially those in professional and office sectors. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers to consider is the potential for housing affordability issues and a competitive housing market, which could impact talent attraction and retention strategies.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #20 OF 50

Cleveland

Cleveland

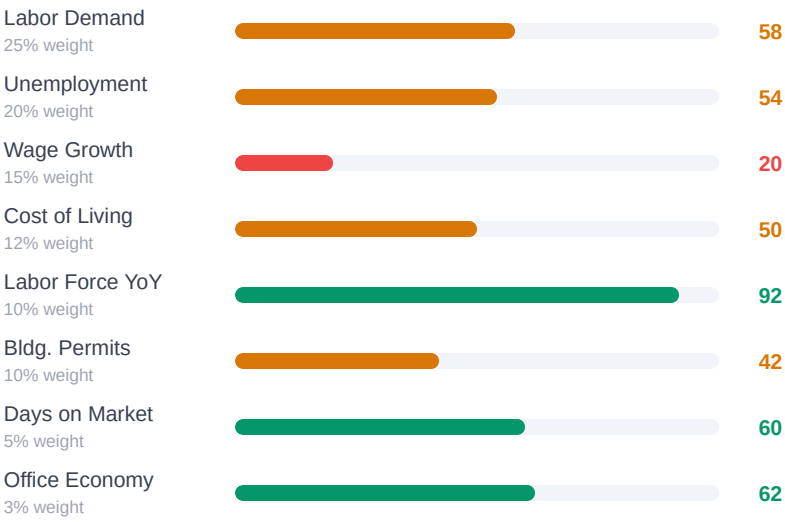
B-

BELOW AVERAGE

52.6th percentile

Rank 20 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT **3.4%** of civilian labor force	WAGE GROWTH YOY **+1.8%** avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH **+0.6%** nonfarm payrolls YoY	LABOR FORCE YOY **+1.8%** civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS **-6.8%** residential YoY (3mo avg)	DAYS ON MARKET **55 days** median, +7.8% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

STRONG

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Cleveland earns an overall grade of B- with a composite score of 52.6th percentile, ranking it below average among 50 US metros. The city's economic character is most defined by its near-median labor demand, with a composite score of 5.66, and its below-average wage growth of +1.81% year-over-year. These metrics suggest a city with moderate job market activity but sluggish wage increases.

Labor Demand

Cleveland's employment growth rate is +0.57% year-over-year, and weekly hours are deviating +0.558% from the city's own 12-month baseline, indicating genuine demand expansion. This combination signals that the city is adding jobs and workers are putting in more hours, suggesting a moderate level of labor market activity. The labor demand composite score of 5.66, at the 58th percentile, reinforces this assessment.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Cleveland is 3.40%, which is near the median, ranking at the 54th percentile. This rate suggests a relatively balanced labor market, neither too tight nor too slack. For a business trying to hire in Cleveland, this means that while it may not be extremely difficult to find workers, there is still some competition for talent.

Wage Growth

Wage growth in Cleveland is +1.81% year-over-year, which is below average, ranking at the 20th percentile. This slow wage growth implies that labor costs for employers are not rising rapidly, but it also means that worker purchasing power is not increasing significantly. As a result, businesses may enjoy a relatively flat cost environment, but workers may have limited bargaining power.

Cost of Living

Cleveland's cost of living, with a PSF of $143/sqft and average hourly earnings of $34.42, results in a ratio of 4.15, ranking at the 50th percentile. This suggests that the city is neither particularly affordable nor expensive relative to its peers. For talent attraction, this means that Cleveland may not offer a significant advantage in terms of affordability without wage premiums.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Cleveland is growing at a rate of +1.80% year-over-year, which is in the top tier, ranking at the 92nd percentile. This indicates that the workforce supply is expanding, which is a positive sign for businesses looking to hire, as it suggests a growing pool of potential employees.

Building Permits

The number of building permits in Cleveland has decreased by -6.79% year-over-year, ranking at the 42nd percentile. This decline suggests that housing supply is not expanding as rapidly as in other cities, which could lead to future affordability issues and challenges in accommodating a growing workforce.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Cleveland is 55 days, with a year-over-year increase of +7.8%, ranking at the 60th percentile. This indicates a slightly slower market, which could make it more accessible for workers relocating to the city, as they have more time to find a home.

Office Economy

Cleveland's professional and office worker share is above average, ranking at the 62nd percentile. This suggests a deep talent pool suited for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, or HQ sectors. However, it may be less suited for industries dominated by industrial or logistics roles.

In conclusion, Cleveland offers a moderate labor market with expanding workforce supply, but it is constrained by slow wage growth and a potential future housing affordability issue. The single biggest risk for a business deciding to locate in Cleveland is the slow wage growth, which may limit the city's appeal to top talent and constrain consumer demand.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #21 OF 50

Seattle

Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue

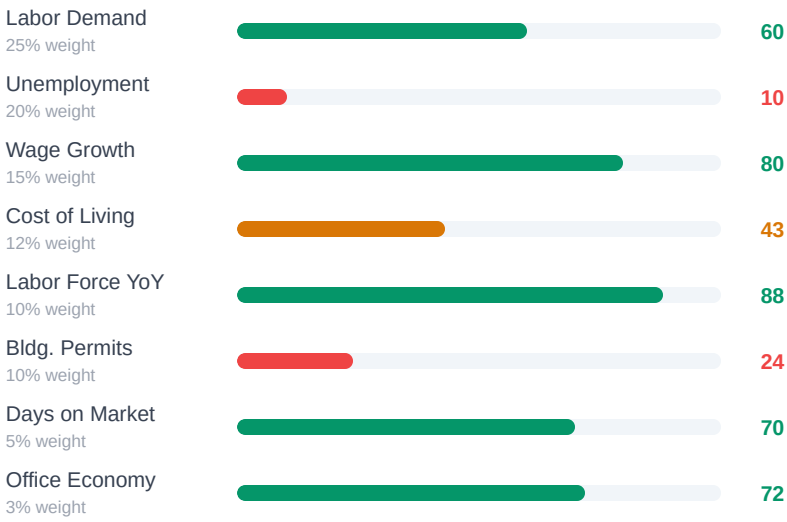
B-

BELOW AVERAGE

51.0th percentile

Rank 21 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT **4.9%** of civilian labor force	WAGE GROWTH YOY **+5.5%** avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH **+0.7%** nonfarm payrolls YoY	LABOR FORCE YOY **+1.4%** civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS **-13.6%** residential YoY (3mo avg)	DAYS ON MARKET **51 days** median, +6.2% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

STRONG

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue metro area has an overall grade of B- with a composite score ranking at the 51.0th percentile among 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its strong wage growth, with a year-over-year increase of 5.54%, and its labor demand composite score of 5.68, which indicates genuine demand expansion. The combination of a 0.71% employment growth rate and a 0.382% increase in weekly hours worked suggests a robust job market.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate of 0.71% and the 0.382% increase in weekly hours worked indicate a genuine demand expansion in the labor market. This combination signals that the city is experiencing an increase in jobs and hours worked, which is a positive indicator for businesses looking to locate in the area. The labor demand composite score of 5.68 further supports this notion, ranking in the 60th percentile.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue is 4.90%, which is relatively high and ranks in the 10th percentile. This suggests that the labor market has some slack, making it easier for businesses to hire workers. However, this also implies weaker local consumer demand, which could impact businesses that rely on local spending.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate of 5.54% is relatively high, ranking in the 80th percentile. This indicates that labor costs for employers are rising, but it also means that workers have increased purchasing power. Businesses should be prepared for higher labor costs, but they can also benefit from a more affluent local consumer base.

Cost of Living

With a cost of living ratio of 8.81, which is near the median, and a percentile rank of 43, Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue is neither extremely affordable nor expensive. The PSF of $423/sqft is decreasing by 3.2% year-over-year, which is a positive trend. This means that the city has a moderate talent attraction advantage, as workers may not require significant wage premiums to afford the cost of living.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force is growing at a rate of 1.43% year-over-year, which is a top-tier growth rate, ranking in the 88th percentile. This indicates that the workforce supply is expanding, which is a positive sign for businesses looking to hire. The growing labor force provides a larger pool of potential workers, making it easier for companies to find the talent they need.

Building Permits

The number of building permits has decreased by 13.58% year-over-year, which is a below-average change, ranking in the 24th percentile. This suggests that the housing supply is tightening, which could lead to future affordability issues and make it more challenging for workers to relocate to the area.

Days on Market

The current median days on market is 51 days, with a year-over-year increase of 6.2%, ranking in the 70th percentile. This indicates a relatively slow market, making it more accessible for workers to find housing. However, this trend may also suggest a normalization of the market, rather than a demand erosion.

Office Economy

With an office and professional worker share of 3.08, ranking in the 72nd percentile, Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue has a deep talent pool in professional and office sectors. This makes the city well-suited for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors, but less suitable for industries with more industrial or logistics-oriented workforces.

The Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue metro area offers businesses a strong labor market with genuine demand expansion and a growing workforce. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the tightening housing supply, which could lead to future affordability issues and impact the city's ability to attract and retain talent.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #22 OF 50

San Diego

San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad

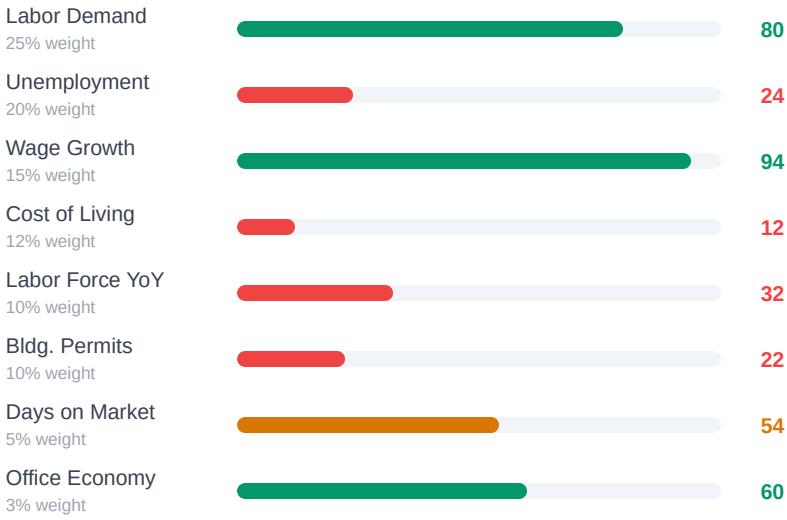
B-

BELOW AVERAGE

50.3th percentile

Rank 22 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT **4.7%** of civilian labor force	WAGE GROWTH YOY **+7.8%** avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH **+1.3%** nonfarm payrolls YoY	LABOR FORCE YOY **-0.8%** civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS **-16.7%** residential YoY (3mo avg)	DAYS ON MARKET **48 days** median, +2.1% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

STRONG

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad metro area has an overall grade of B- with a composite score of 50.3th percentile, ranking it below average among 50 US metros. The city's economic character is most defined by its strong labor demand, with a top-tier composite score of 80th percentile, and its high wage growth, with a top-tier rate of 7.80% year-over-year. These metrics signal a city with a robust job market and rising labor costs.

Labor Demand

The San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad metro area has an employment growth rate of 1.28% year-over-year and a weekly hours deviation of 0.481% above its own trend, indicating genuine demand expansion. This combination signals that the city is adding jobs and workers are putting in more hours, suggesting a strong and growing economy. The labor demand composite score of 6.57 further reinforces this assessment, placing the city in the top tier.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad is 4.70%, which is below average, ranking in the 24th percentile. This indicates a relatively tight labor market with some slack, making it moderately challenging for businesses to hire. As a result, companies may face some wage pressure when trying to attract and retain talent in this market.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad is 7.80%, which is a top-tier rate, indicating fast wage growth. This rapid increase in wages suggests that labor costs for employers will rise, while workers will enjoy greater purchasing power. The high wage growth rate also implies a competitive labor market where businesses must offer attractive compensation packages to attract and retain employees.

Cost of Living

San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad has a cost of living score that ranks in the 12th percentile, indicating that the city is relatively expensive. With a price per square foot of $583 and average hourly earnings of $43.46, the ratio of 13.41 is high, making it challenging for businesses to attract talent without offering wage premiums. The fact that the price per square foot is falling by 3.6% year-over-year slightly mitigates this issue but does not significantly alter the city's overall affordability.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad is shrinking at a rate of -0.76% year-over-year, indicating a contracting labor supply. This decline suggests that the city's workforce is not expanding, which could pose a structural headwind for hiring and business

growth. Companies may need to consider strategies to attract talent from other areas or invest in workforce development programs.

Building Permits

The number of building permits in San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad has decreased by 16.72% year-over-year, signaling a tightening of the housing supply. This decline in permits suggests that the city's future affordability and ability to accommodate a growing workforce may be at risk, potentially exacerbating existing labor market challenges.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad is 48 days, with a year-over-year increase of 2.1%. This indicates a moderately competitive market that is becoming slightly less heated. For workers relocating to the city, this means that the housing market is still relatively accessible, but the trend suggests it may become more challenging to find a home in the near future.

Office Economy

San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad has an above-average share of professional and office workers, ranking in the 60th percentile. This suggests a deep talent pool suited for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors. However, the city may be less suitable for industries that require a large workforce in industrial or logistics roles.

The San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad metro area offers businesses a strong labor demand and high wage growth, indicating a robust and competitive economy. However, the city's relatively high cost of living and shrinking labor force supply pose significant risks that decision-makers must consider when evaluating this location for their business operations. The biggest constraint for businesses in this city will be managing labor costs and attracting talent in a tight and expensive market.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #23 OF 50

San Antonio

San Antonio-New Braunfels

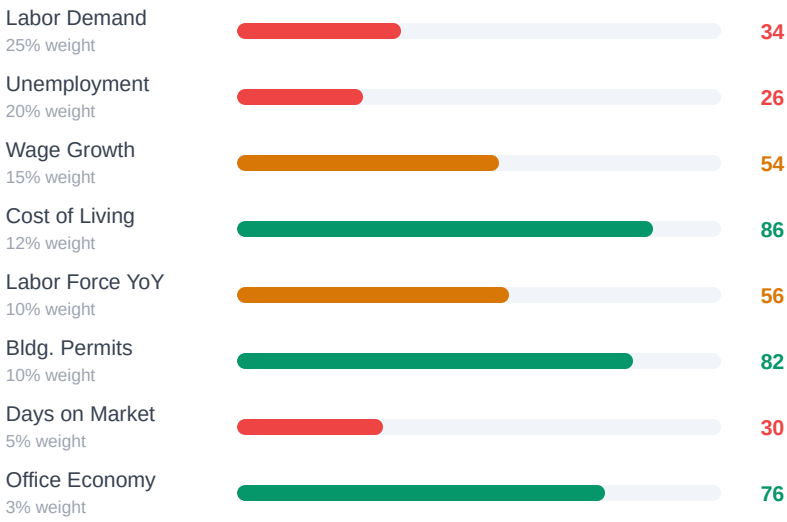
C+

FAIR

49.7th percentile

Rank 23 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT **4.3%** of civilian labor force	WAGE GROWTH YOY **+3.9%** avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH **+0.4%** nonfarm payrolls YoY	LABOR FORCE YOY **+0.2%** civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS **+24.4%** residential YoY (3mo avg)	DAYS ON MARKET **74 days** median, 0.0% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

GROWING

Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The San Antonio-New Braunfels metro area has an overall grade of C+ with a composite score ranking it 49.7th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its below-average labor demand, with a composite score of 4.27, and its top-tier cost of living, with a ratio of $169/sqft to $32.51/hr, ranking it in the 86th percentile for affordability. The labor demand and cost of living metrics are crucial in understanding the city's current economic landscape, with the former indicating a slower job market and the latter suggesting an attractive environment for talent.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in San Antonio-New Braunfels is +0.36% year-over-year, while weekly hours are deviating -0.533% from the city's own 12-month baseline. This combination signals a contraction in labor demand, indicating that the job market is not expanding rapidly. The below-average labor demand composite score of 4.27 further reinforces this notion, suggesting that the city is not experiencing genuine demand expansion.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in San Antonio-New Braunfels is 4.30%, ranking it in the 26th percentile, indicating a relatively loose labor market. This means that there is some slack in the market, making it slightly easier for businesses to hire, but also potentially leading to weaker local consumer demand. The practical implication for a business trying to hire in this city is that it may have a relatively easier time finding candidates, but may also face less competitive pressure to offer high wages.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in San Antonio-New Braunfels is +3.90%, ranking it in the 54th percentile, indicating moderate wage growth. This rate suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but not extremely rapidly, while worker purchasing power is increasing at a steady pace. The moderate wage growth implies that businesses can expect to pay slightly higher wages, but the increase is not drastic.

Cost of Living

San Antonio-New Braunfels has a cost of living ratio of $169/sqft to $32.51/hr, with the price per square foot falling -3.4% year-over-year, ranking it in the 86th percentile for affordability. This means that the city is relatively affordable compared to its peers, making it an attractive location for talent without requiring significant wage premiums. The top-tier affordability score suggests that businesses can recruit and retain workers without breaking the bank.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in San Antonio-New Braunfels is growing at a rate of +0.19% year-over-year, ranking it in the 56th percentile, indicating a slow but positive expansion of the workforce supply. This implies that the hiring capacity in the city is increasing, but not rapidly, providing a moderate environment for businesses to find new talent.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in San Antonio-New Braunfels is increasing by +24.39% year-over-year, ranking it in the 82nd percentile, signaling a significant expansion of the housing supply. This suggests that the city is experiencing a surge in developer confidence, which will likely lead to improved affordability and a more accommodating environment for the workforce in the future.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in San Antonio-New Braunfels is 74 days, with a year-over-year change of +0.0%, ranking it in the 30th percentile. This indicates a relatively fast-paced market, making it challenging for relocating workers to find homes. The low percentile rank suggests that the market is competitive, and workers may face difficulties in finding suitable housing.

Office Economy

San Antonio-New Braunfels has an above-average share of professional and office workers, ranking it in the 76th percentile, indicating a deep talent pool suited for tech, finance, consulting, and HQ decisions. This city is well-suited for businesses that require specialized knowledge-economy roles, but may not be the best fit for industries with more industrial or logistics-dominant economies.

The San Antonio-New Braunfels metro area offers businesses a unique combination of moderate wage growth, affordable cost of living, and a deep professional talent pool, making it an attractive location for certain industries. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the below-average labor demand, which may indicate a slower job market and potential challenges in finding skilled workers, despite the city's overall affordability and talent pool advantages.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #24 OF 50

Portland

Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro

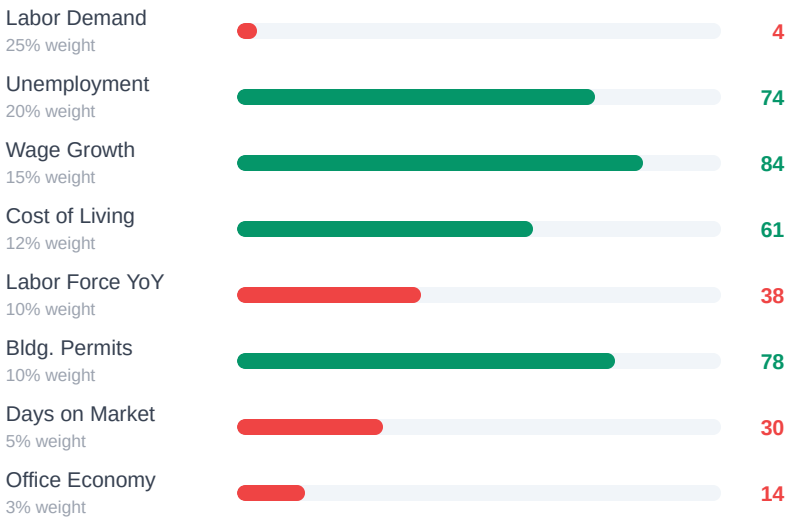
C+

FAIR

49.3th percentile

Rank 24 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT **4.1%** of civilian labor force	WAGE GROWTH YOY **+5.7%** avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH **-0.6%** nonfarm payrolls YoY	LABOR FORCE YOY **-0.6%** civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS **+20.1%** residential YoY (3mo avg)	DAYS ON MARKET **71 days** median, 0.0% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

SQUEEZE

Payrolls contracting while hours rise — survivor squeeze signal.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro metro area has an overall grade of C+ with a composite score ranking it at the 49.3th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its low labor demand, with a composite score in the bottom tier, and its high wage growth, with a year-over-year increase of 5.71%. The combination of these metrics suggests a complex economic environment, with both challenges and opportunities for businesses.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro is -0.63% year-over-year, and weekly hours are deviating from the trend by +0.540%. This combination signals a contraction in labor demand, with hours above trend during job losses indicating a survivor squeeze, where remaining workers are absorbing the load of eliminated roles. This suggests that businesses may face challenges in finding new talent, but may also be able to negotiate with existing employees.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro is 4.10%, which ranks in the 74th percentile, indicating a relatively tight labor market. This means that businesses may face challenges in hiring, as there are fewer unemployed workers available, and may need to offer competitive wages to attract talent. However, this also suggests that the local consumer demand is relatively strong.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro is 5.71%, which is in the top tier, indicating fast wage growth. This means that employer labor costs are rising, but worker purchasing power is also increasing, which can be beneficial for businesses that rely on local consumer demand. However, this may also put pressure on businesses to increase wages to attract and retain talent.

Cost of Living

Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro has a cost of living score that ranks in the 61st percentile, with a PSF of $302/sqft and average hourly earnings of $42.38/hr, resulting in a ratio of 7.13. This suggests that the city is relatively affordable compared to its peers, which can be a talent attraction advantage, as businesses may not need to offer wage premiums to compensate for high living costs.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro is growing at a rate of -0.60% year-over-year, indicating a contracting labor pool. This means that the supply of workers is shrinking, which can be a structural headwind for hiring, and businesses may need to be more competitive in their recruitment efforts.

Building Permits

The number of building permits in Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro is increasing by 20.09% year-over-year, indicating an expansion of housing supply. This suggests that future affordability and workforce accommodation may improve, as more housing options become available, which can be beneficial for businesses that rely on a local workforce.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro is 71 days, with a year-over-year change of 0.0%. This suggests that the housing market is relatively competitive, but not extremely fast-paced, which can make it accessible for workers relocating to the city.

Office Economy

The share of professional and office workers in Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro is relatively low, ranking in the 14th percentile, indicating a shallow talent pool in these sectors. This suggests that the city may not be the best fit for businesses that require a deep knowledge-economy talent pool, such as tech or finance companies, but may be more suitable for industrial or logistics-dominant businesses.

The Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro metro area offers a complex economic environment, with both challenges and opportunities for businesses. While the city's high wage growth and relatively affordable cost of living can be attractive, the low labor demand and contracting labor pool may pose significant risks for businesses that rely on a local workforce. The single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the potential difficulty in finding and retaining talent in this market.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #25 OF 50

Washington DC

Washington-Arlington-Alexandria

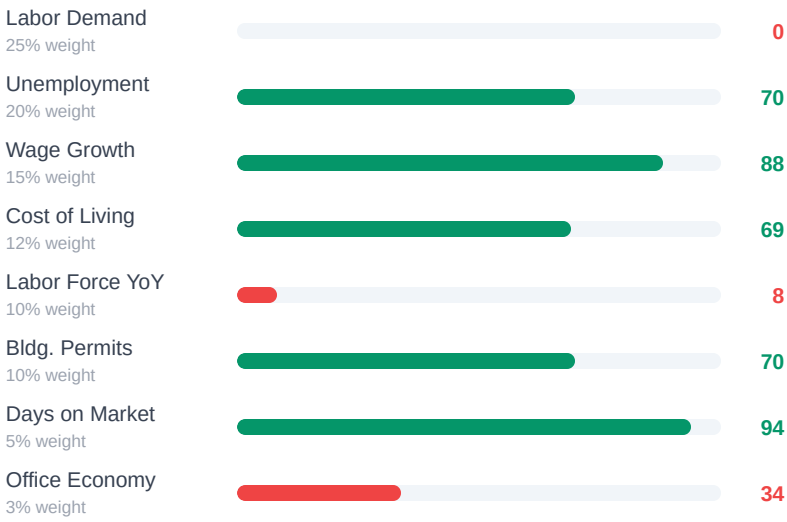
C+

FAIR

49.0th percentile

Rank 25 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT
3.7%
of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY
+6.0%
avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH
-1.8%
nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE YOY
-2.2%
civilian labor force growth

BUILDING PERMITS
+13.9%
residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET
43 days
median, +13.2% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

WEAK

Both employment and hours declining — broad contraction.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Washington-Arlington-Alexandria metro area has an overall grade of C+ with a composite score ranking at the 49.0th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its strong wage growth, with a year-over-year increase of 6.02%, and its low labor demand, signaled by a -1.82% employment growth rate and -0.510% weekly hours deviation from trend. These metrics suggest a complex labor market with both positive and negative trends.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Washington-Arlington-Alexandria is -1.82%, and weekly hours are deviating -0.510% from the city's own 12-month baseline, resulting in a labor demand composite score of 1.75, which ranks at the 0th percentile. This combination signals a contraction in labor demand, indicating that the city is experiencing a decline in job creation and hours worked. This suggests a survivor squeeze, where remaining workers are absorbing the load of eliminated roles.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Washington-Arlington-Alexandria is 3.70%, which ranks at the 70th percentile, indicating a relatively tight labor market. This means that there is less slack in the market, making it harder for businesses to hire new employees. As a result, businesses may face upward pressure on wages to attract and retain talent.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Washington-Arlington-Alexandria is 6.02%, which is a relatively fast pace, ranking at the 88th percentile. This rapid wage growth implies rising labor costs for employers, but also increasing purchasing power for workers. As a result, businesses may need to adjust their compensation packages to remain competitive in the market.

Cost of Living

Washington-Arlington-Alexandria has a cost of living score that ranks at the 69th percentile, with a PSF of $299/sqft, which is decreasing by 2.9% year-over-year, and an average hourly earnings of $45.44/hr, resulting in a ratio of 6.58. This suggests that the city is relatively affordable compared to its peers, which can be a talent attraction advantage, as businesses may not need to offer significant wage premiums to compensate for high living costs.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Washington-Arlington-Alexandria is contracting at a rate of -2.24% year-over-year, which ranks at the 8th percentile. This decline in labor force supply implies that the city's hiring capacity may be constrained, making it challenging for businesses to find and recruit new talent.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Washington-Arlington-Alexandria is increasing by 13.92% year-over-year, which ranks at the 70th percentile. This expansion in housing supply suggests that the city's affordability and workforce accommodation may improve in the future, as more housing options become available.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Washington-Arlington-Alexandria is currently 43 days, with a year-over-year increase of 13.2%, ranking at the 94th percentile. This indicates a slower market, where homes are taking longer to sell, making it more accessible for workers relocating to the city to find housing.

Office Economy

The share of professional and office workers in Washington-Arlington-Alexandria ranks at the 34th percentile, with a composite score of 2.28. This suggests that the city has a relatively shallow talent pool in these sectors, making it less suited for businesses that require a deep knowledge-economy talent pool, such as tech, finance, or consulting firms.

The Washington-Arlington-Alexandria metro area offers a complex mix of strong wage growth and declining labor demand, making it a challenging location for businesses to navigate. The single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the city's contracting labor force supply, which may limit hiring capacity and require businesses to offer competitive compensation packages to attract and retain talent. Overall, businesses that can adapt to these conditions may find opportunities in this market, but will need to carefully consider the implications of the city's unique economic character.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #26 OF 50

Columbus

Columbus

C+

FAIR

47.7th percentile

Rank 26 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT **3.3%** of civilian labor force	WAGE GROWTH YOY **+4.5%** avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH **-0.1%** nonfarm payrolls YoY	LABOR FORCE YOY **-2.0%** civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS **-3.0%** residential YoY (3mo avg)	DAYS ON MARKET **50 days** median, +6.4% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

SQUEEZE

Payrolls contracting while hours rise — survivor squeeze signal.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Columbus, ranked 47.7th percentile out of 50 US metros, earns an overall grade of C+, characterized primarily by its low labor demand and tight unemployment market, with an unemployment rate of 3.30% and a labor demand composite score of 3.65. The city's economic character is also defined by its moderate wage growth and relatively affordable cost of living, with a cost of living ratio of 5.94. Specifically, the labor demand and unemployment metrics, with employment growth at -0.13% and weekly hours deviation at +0.468%, set the tone for the city's economic landscape.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Columbus is -0.13%, and the weekly hours deviation is +0.468%, indicating a scenario where hours are above trend during job losses, suggesting a survivor squeeze. This combination signals that while there is some level of labor utilization, the overall labor market is contracting. The labor demand composite score of 3.65 further reinforces this notion, placing Columbus in the bottom tier.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Columbus is 3.30%, which is in the top tier, indicating a tight labor market with low slack. This means that businesses trying to hire in this city will face significant competition for talent, potentially driving up wages. With such a low unemployment rate, Columbus presents a challenging environment for staffing.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Columbus is +4.53%, which is above average, ranking in the 68th percentile. This rate of wage growth suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but it also indicates good worker purchasing power. As wages continue to grow at this pace, businesses should anticipate increasing labor costs.

Cost of Living

Columbus has a cost of living ratio of 5.94, with PSF at $205/sqft and hourly earnings at $34.52/hr, placing it near the median in terms of affordability. Given its 51st percentile rank, the city is neither exceptionally affordable nor expensive compared to its peers. This means that Columbus can attract talent without necessarily requiring significant wage premiums to offset the cost of living.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Columbus is shrinking at a rate of -2.01% year-over-year, indicating a contracting labor pool. This negative growth rate presents a structural headwind for hiring, as the supply of potential workers is decreasing. Businesses should consider this trend when planning for future staffing needs.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in residential building permits in Columbus is -3.05%, indicating a slight tightening in housing supply. Although this change is near the median, it suggests that the future affordability and workforce accommodation in the city might be at risk if the trend continues. Developer confidence appears to be waning slightly.

Days on Market

Homes in Columbus are currently sitting on the market for 50 days, with a year-over-year increase of +6.4%. This increase, placing the city in the 72nd percentile, indicates a slower market that is more accessible for relocating workers. The rising days on market suggest a healthy normalization of the housing market.

Office Economy

Columbus has a relatively shallow professional talent pool, ranking in the 10th percentile. This suggests that the city is less suited for businesses requiring deep knowledge-economy talent, such as tech, finance, or consulting firms. Instead, Columbus might be more appropriate for industries with fewer specialized roles, such as industrial or logistics-dominant economies.

In conclusion, Columbus offers a business environment with moderate wage growth and a relatively affordable cost of living, but it is constrained by a tight labor market and a shrinking labor force. The single biggest risk or constraint for a decision-maker considering Columbus is the challenging hiring environment due to low unemployment and the potential for increasing labor costs. This must be carefully weighed against the city's other attributes when making a location decision.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #27 OF 50

San Francisco

San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont

C+

FAIR

47.1th percentile

Rank 27 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	50
Unemployment	20% weight	36
Wage Growth	15% weight	82
Cost of Living	12% weight	16
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	20
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	98
Days on Market	5% weight	2
Office Economy	3% weight	42

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT
4.4%
of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY
+5.6%
avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH
+0.3%
nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE YOY
-1.4%
civilian labor force growth

BUILDING PERMITS
+183.3%
residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET
38 days
median, -9.5% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

STRONG

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont metro area has an overall grade of C+ with a composite score ranking at the 47.1th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its high wage growth, with a year-over-year increase of 5.61%, and its extremely competitive housing market, with a median days on market of 38 days and a year-over-year decrease of 9.5%. These metrics signal a challenging environment for businesses looking to attract and retain talent.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont is 0.34% year-over-year, combined with a weekly hours deviation of 0.494% above its own trend. This combination signals a genuine demand expansion, as both jobs and hours are increasing. However, the near-median percentile rank of 50th suggests that this growth is not exceptionally strong compared to other metros.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont is 4.40%, ranking at the 36th percentile, indicating a below-average labor market with some slack. This means that businesses may find it slightly easier to hire in this market, but the relatively low unemployment rate still suggests some competition for talent. As a result, businesses may need to offer competitive wages to attract the best candidates.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont is 5.61%, ranking at the 82nd percentile, indicating fast and strong wage growth. This implies rising labor costs for employers, but also increasing purchasing power for workers. Businesses should factor in the potential for higher labor costs when considering this location.

Cost of Living

San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont has a cost of living percentile rank of 16th, with a PSF of $630/sqft and average hourly earnings of $50.70, resulting in a ratio of 12.43. The city is relatively expensive, which may make it challenging to attract talent without offering wage premiums. The 3.5% year-over-year decrease in PSF is a positive sign, but the overall affordability remains a concern.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont is contracting at a rate of -1.36% year-over-year, ranking at the 20th percentile. This indicates a shrinking labor pool, which may pose a structural headwind for hiring and business growth. Businesses should consider the potential challenges of finding and retaining talent in a declining labor market.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in building permits is 183.35%, ranking at the 98th percentile, indicating a significant expansion of housing supply. This suggests that developer confidence is high, and future housing affordability may improve. As a result, businesses may find it easier to attract and retain talent in the long term.

Days on Market

The median days on market in San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont is 38 days, with a year-over-year decrease of 9.5%, ranking at the 2nd percentile. This extremely competitive market means that relocating workers may face significant challenges in finding housing, making it essential for businesses to offer relocation assistance or competitive salaries to attract talent.

Office Economy

San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont has a professional and office worker share ranking at the 42nd percentile, indicating a moderately deep talent pool. This city is well-suited for businesses in the tech, finance, and consulting sectors, but may not be the best fit for industries requiring a large industrial or logistics workforce.

The San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont metro area offers businesses a highly skilled and productive workforce, with strong wage growth and a growing housing supply. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the extremely competitive and expensive housing market, which may require significant investments in talent attraction and retention strategies.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #28 OF 50

Phoenix

Phoenix-Mesa-Chandler

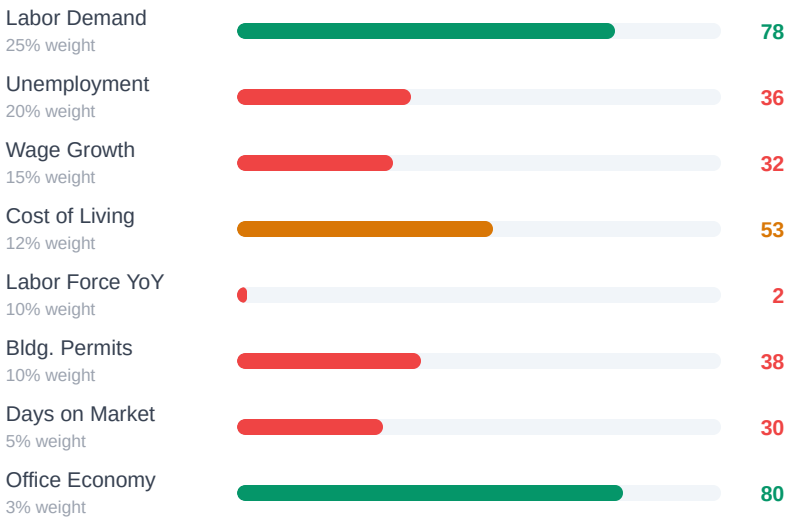
C+

FAIR

45.8th percentile

Rank 28 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT **4.2%** of civilian labor force	WAGE GROWTH YOY **+3.2%** avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH **+1.0%** nonfarm payrolls YoY	LABOR FORCE YOY **-3.0%** civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS **-7.5%** residential YoY (3mo avg)	DAYS ON MARKET **59 days** median, 0.0% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

STRONG

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Phoenix-Mesa-Chandler metro area has an overall grade of C+ with a composite score ranking it 45.8th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its above-average labor demand, with a composite score of 6.49 ranking it in the 78th percentile, and its below-average labor force growth, which is contracting at a rate of -2.95% year-over-year. The labor demand metrics, including employment growth and weekly hours, signal a genuine demand expansion.

Labor Demand

The Phoenix-Mesa-Chandler metro area has an employment growth rate of +0.96% year-over-year and a weekly hours deviation of +0.843% from its own trend, indicating a genuine demand expansion. This combination signals that the city is adding jobs and workers are putting in more hours, suggesting a strong labor market. The labor demand composite score of 6.49 ranks in the 78th percentile, further supporting the notion of a thriving labor market.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Phoenix-Mesa-Chandler is 4.20%, ranking it in the 36th percentile, indicating a market with some slack. This means that businesses may find it relatively easier to hire workers, but may also face less wage pressure. However, the unemployment rate is not extremely low, suggesting that there is still a pool of available workers.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Phoenix-Mesa-Chandler is +3.22%, ranking it in the 32nd percentile, indicating moderate wage growth. This means that employer labor costs are rising, but not extremely quickly, and worker purchasing power is increasing, but not at a rapid pace. The moderate wage growth suggests a relatively stable labor cost environment.

Cost of Living

The cost of living in Phoenix-Mesa-Chandler is near the median, with a percentile rank of 53, and a price-to-salary ratio of $264/sqft to $37.74/hr, or 7.00. The fact that the PSF is falling by -2.2% year-over-year suggests that the city is becoming more affordable. This means that businesses may be able to attract talent without needing to offer significant wage premiums, giving them a talent attraction advantage.

Labor Force Growth

The labor force in Phoenix-Mesa-Chandler is contracting at a rate of -2.95% year-over-year, ranking it in the 2nd percentile. This means that the supply of workers is shrinking, which could create a structural headwind for hiring. Businesses may need to be more competitive in their hiring practices or consider alternative locations with growing labor pools.

Building Permits

The number of building permits in Phoenix-Mesa-Chandler is falling by -7.52% year-over-year, ranking it in the 38th percentile. This suggests that the housing supply is tightening, which could lead to decreased affordability and make it more difficult for workers to relocate to the area. This trend signals a potential risk to future workforce accommodation and affordability.

Days on Market

The median days on market in Phoenix-Mesa-Chandler is 59 days, with a year-over-year change of +0.0%, ranking it in the 30th percentile. This means that homes are selling relatively quickly, making it a competitive market for relocating workers. However, the stable days on market suggests that the market is not extremely hot, and workers may still be able to find suitable housing.

Office Economy

The office economy in Phoenix-Mesa-Chandler is deep, with a professional worker share ranking it in the 80th percentile. This suggests that the city has a strong talent pool suited for tech, finance, consulting, and HQ decisions. However, the city may be less suited for industrial or logistics-dominant businesses, which may require a different type of workforce.

The Phoenix-Mesa-Chandler metro area offers businesses a strong labor market with above-average labor demand, but also presents a significant risk due to its contracting labor force. The single biggest constraint for decision-makers to factor in is the shrinking labor pool, which could create challenges for hiring and workforce growth. Despite this, the city's relatively affordable cost of living and deep office economy make it an attractive location for businesses in certain sectors.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #29 OF 50

Houston

Houston-Pasadena-The Woodlands

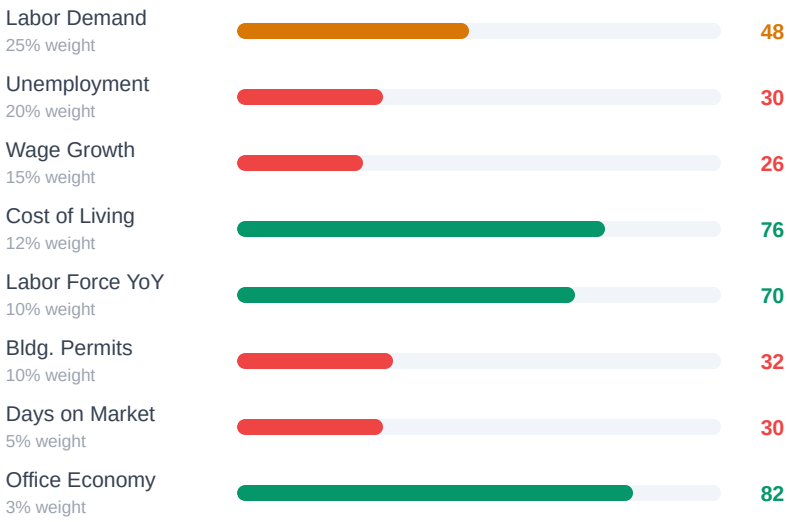
C+

FAIR

45.1th percentile

Rank 29 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT **4.6%** of civilian labor force	WAGE GROWTH YOY **+2.2%** avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH **+1.0%** nonfarm payrolls YoY	LABOR FORCE YOY **+0.7%** civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS **-9.2%** residential YoY (3mo avg)	DAYS ON MARKET **57 days** median, 0.0% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

GROWING

Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Houston-Pasadena-The Woodlands metro area has an overall grade of C+ with a composite score ranking it at the 45.1th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its near-median labor demand composite score of 5.20 and its below-average unemployment rate of 4.60%. The combination of these metrics suggests a mixed economic environment, with labor demand and unemployment rates that are not exceptionally strong or weak.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Houston-Pasadena-The Woodlands is +0.97% year-over-year, while weekly hours are deviating -0.457% from the city's own 12-month baseline. This combination signals a moderate labor demand expansion, as the city is adding jobs, but the hours worked are slightly below trend. This suggests that the labor market is growing, but not at a rapid pace.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Houston-Pasadena-The Woodlands is 4.60%, which ranks at the 30th percentile, indicating a below-average labor market with some slack. This means that businesses may find it relatively easier to hire workers, but may also face weaker local consumer demand. The practical implication for a business trying to hire here is that they may have a larger pool of potential candidates to choose from.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate in Houston-Pasadena-The Woodlands is +2.25%, which ranks at the 26th percentile, indicating below-average wage growth. This suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but at a moderate pace, and worker purchasing power is increasing, but not rapidly. As a result, businesses may face some upward pressure on wages, but it is not extreme.

Cost of Living

Houston-Pasadena-The Woodlands has a cost of living score that ranks at the 76th percentile, indicating that it is more affordable than many of its peer cities. The city's PSF of $168/sqft is decreasing at a rate of -2.3% year-over-year, relative to average hourly earnings of $37.07/hr, resulting in a ratio of 4.53. This means that the city has a talent attraction advantage, as workers can afford to live here without requiring significant wage premiums.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Houston-Pasadena-The Woodlands is growing at a rate of +0.69% year-over-year, which ranks at the 70th percentile, indicating an above-average expansion of the labor force. This means that the supply of workers is increasing, which is a positive sign for businesses looking to hire. As a result, the city's hiring capacity is likely to improve.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Houston-Pasadena-The Woodlands is decreasing at a rate of -9.16% year-over-year, which ranks at the 32nd percentile, indicating a below-average expansion of housing supply. This suggests that the city's housing supply is tightening, which may lead to future affordability issues and challenges in accommodating a growing workforce.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Houston-Pasadena-The Woodlands is 57 days, with a year-over-year change of +0.0%, which ranks at the 30th percentile. This indicates a relatively fast-paced market, where homes are selling quickly. As a result, workers relocating to this city may face a competitive housing market, which could make it challenging to find a home.

Office Economy

Houston-Pasadena-The Woodlands has a deep professional talent pool, with an office economy score that ranks at the 82nd percentile. This makes the city well-suited for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors, which require a high concentration of specialized workers. However, the city may be less suitable for businesses in industrial or logistics-dominant sectors.

The Houston-Pasadena-The Woodlands metro area offers businesses a mixed economic environment, with some positive signs such as labor force growth and affordability, but also some challenges like tightening housing supply and moderate labor demand. The single biggest risk or constraint for a decision-maker to factor in is the potential for future affordability issues and workforce accommodation challenges, which could impact the city's ability to attract and retain talent.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #30 OF 50

Oklahoma City

Oklahoma City

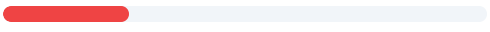
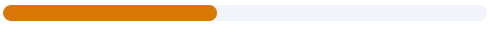
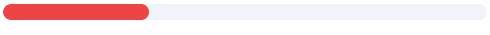
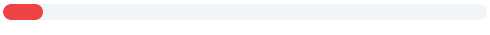
C+

FAIR

44.8th percentile

Rank 30 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand (25% weight)		26
Unemployment (20% weight)		44
Wage Growth (15% weight)		58
Cost of Living (12% weight)		67
Labor Force YoY (10% weight)		50
Bldg. Permits (10% weight)		60
Days on Market (5% weight)		30
Office Economy (3% weight)		8

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT
3.7%
of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY
+4.0%
avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH
+0.5%
nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE YOY
-0.2%
civilian labor force growth

BUILDING PERMITS
+7.5%
residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET
60 days
median, +9.1% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

GROWING

Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Oklahoma City has an overall grade of C+ with a composite score ranking it 44.8th percentile out of 50 US metros. The city's economic character is most defined by its below-average labor demand, with an employment growth rate of +0.49% and weekly hours deviation of -1.050% from its own trend, as well as its moderate unemployment rate of 3.70%. These metrics suggest a mixed economic environment, with some positive signs but also areas of concern.

Labor Demand

The combination of +0.49% employment growth and -1.050% weekly hours deviation signals a labor market that is not experiencing genuine demand expansion, as hours are running below trend despite some job growth. This suggests that the city's labor market is not as strong as the employment growth rate alone might indicate. The labor demand composite score of 3.94 ranks below average, at the 26th percentile.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate of 3.70% indicates a labor market with some slack, ranking near the median at the 44th percentile. This means that businesses trying to hire in Oklahoma City may have a relatively easier time finding candidates, but may not face as much upward pressure on wages. However, the moderate unemployment rate also suggests that local consumer demand may not be as strong as in tighter labor markets.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate of +4.02% is near the median, ranking at the 58th percentile. This moderate wage growth suggests that employer labor costs are rising, but not extremely quickly, and that workers have some bargaining power. However, the wage growth is not strong enough to drive significant increases in worker purchasing power.

Cost of Living

Oklahoma City has a cost of living percentile rank of 67, indicating that it is more affordable than many of its peer cities, with a PSF of $170/sqft and average hourly earnings of $33.63. This affordability advantage can be a talent attraction benefit for businesses, as workers may not require wage premiums to maintain their standard of living.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force is contracting at a rate of -0.23% year-over-year, indicating that the supply of workers is shrinking. This contraction can create a structural headwind for hiring, making it more difficult for businesses to find the talent they need.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in building permits is +7.51%, indicating that housing supply is expanding. This suggests that future affordability and workforce accommodation may improve, as more housing units become available to meet demand.

Days on Market

The current median days on market is 60 days, with a year-over-year increase of +9.1%. This indicates a slowing market, which can make it more accessible for workers relocating to the city to find housing. However, the below-average percentile rank of 30 suggests that the market is still relatively competitive.

Office Economy

The office economy percentile rank of 8 indicates a relatively shallow professional talent pool, with only 0.82 (on a 0-5 scale) of jobs in professional and office sectors. This suggests that Oklahoma City is best suited for businesses that do not require a deep knowledge-economy talent pool, such as industrial or logistics companies, and may not be the best fit for tech, finance, or consulting firms.

Oklahoma City offers businesses a relatively affordable cost of living and a moderate unemployment rate, which can make it easier to hire and attract talent. However, the city's below-average labor demand and contracting labor force supply are significant risks that decision-makers should factor in, as they may create challenges for finding and retaining the necessary workforce.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #31 OF 50

Boston

Boston-Cambridge-Newton

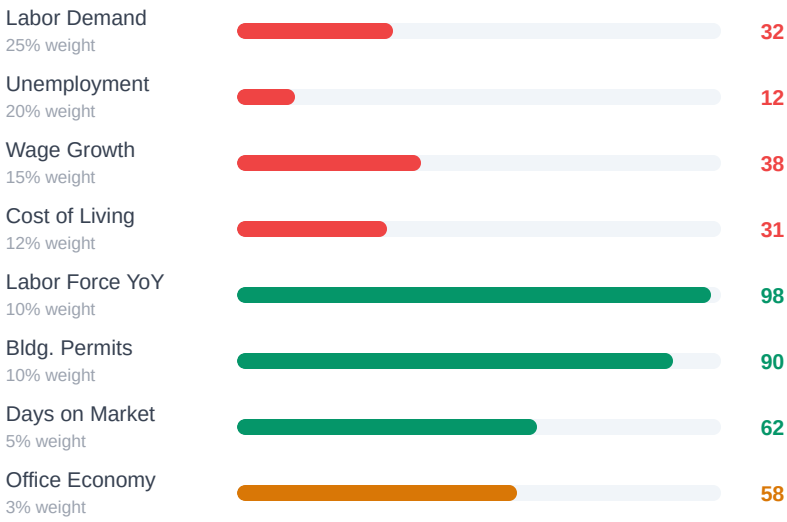
C

VERY POOR

43.4th percentile

Rank 31 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT **3.9%** of civilian labor force	WAGE GROWTH YOY **+3.3%** avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH **-0.0%** nonfarm payrolls YoY	LABOR FORCE YOY **+2.9%** civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS **+39.6%** residential YoY (3mo avg)	DAYS ON MARKET **38 days** median, +2.7% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

WEAK

Both employment and hours declining — broad contraction.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Boston-Cambridge-Newton metro area has an overall grade of C, ranking 43.4th percentile out of 50 US metros, with a labor demand composite score of 4.24. This city's economic character is most defined by its low labor demand, with a -0.04% employment growth rate and -0.025% weekly hours deviation from its own trend, as well as its high cost of living, with a PSF to wages ratio of 9.83. The combination of these metrics suggests a challenging environment for businesses looking to expand or relocate.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Boston-Cambridge-Newton is -0.04%, and weekly hours are deviating -0.025% from the city's own trend, indicating a contraction in labor demand. This combination signals a lack of genuine demand expansion, with the city's labor market experiencing a slowdown. The low labor demand composite score of 4.24 further reinforces this assessment, ranking below average at the 32nd percentile.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Boston-Cambridge-Newton is 3.90%, which is relatively low, ranking in the bottom tier at the 12th percentile. This tight labor market implies that businesses may face challenges in hiring, with upward pressure on wages. As a result, companies may need to offer competitive salaries to attract top talent in this market.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Boston-Cambridge-Newton is +3.26%, which is below average, ranking at the 38th percentile. This moderate wage growth rate suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but at a slower pace than in other cities. While this may be beneficial for worker purchasing power, it also means that businesses may need to budget for increasing labor expenses.

Cost of Living

Boston-Cambridge-Newton has a cost of living score that ranks below average at the 31st percentile, with a PSF to wages ratio of 9.83, and a -2.6% year-over-year change in PSF. This indicates that the city is relatively expensive, making it challenging for businesses to attract talent without offering wage premiums. The falling PSF relative to wages is a positive trend, but the overall affordability score remains a concern.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Boston-Cambridge-Newton is growing at a rate of +2.87% year-over-year, which is a top-tier growth rate, ranking at the 98th percentile. This expanding labor force supply is a positive sign for businesses, as it implies a growing pool of potential employees. However, the city's low labor demand and high cost of living may offset some of this advantage.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Boston-Cambridge-Newton has increased by +39.61% year-over-year, which is a top-tier growth rate, ranking at the 90th percentile. This expansion in housing supply is a positive signal for future affordability and workforce accommodation, suggesting that the city may become more attractive to relocating workers and businesses in the long term.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Boston-Cambridge-Newton is currently 38 days, with a +2.7% year-over-year increase. This indicates a relatively slow market, ranking above average at the 62nd percentile. For workers relocating to this city, the slower market may make it easier to find a home, but it also suggests a less competitive environment for businesses looking to attract talent.

Office Economy

The professional and office worker share in Boston-Cambridge-Newton is near the median, ranking at the 58th percentile. This suggests a moderately deep talent pool, making the city suitable for businesses in the tech, finance, and consulting sectors. However, the city may be less attractive for industrial or logistics-dominant businesses, which may require a different type of workforce.

The Boston-Cambridge-Newton metro area offers businesses a unique combination of a highly educated workforce and a growing labor force supply, but it also presents significant challenges, including a high cost of living and low labor demand. The single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the city's expensive cost of living, which may require businesses to offer wage premiums to attract and retain top talent.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #32 OF 50

Providence

Providence-Warwick

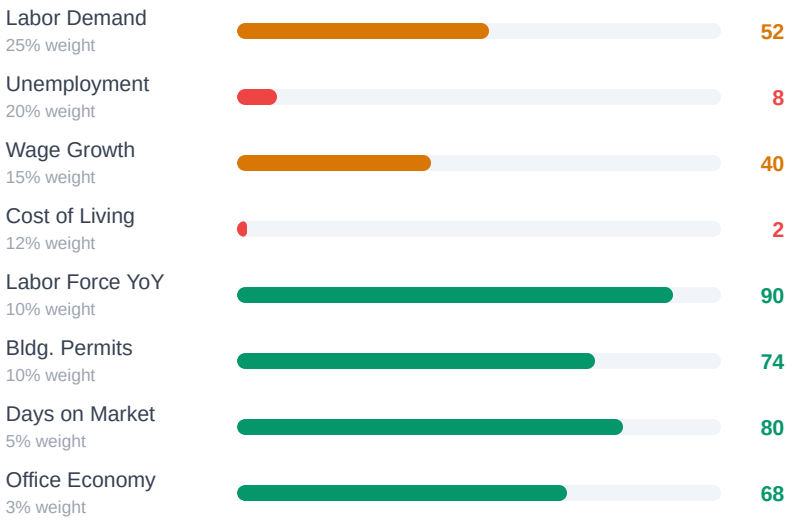
C

VERY POOR

43.3th percentile

Rank 32 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT **4.3%** of civilian labor force	WAGE GROWTH YOY **+3.5%** avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH **+0.6%** nonfarm payrolls YoY	LABOR FORCE YOY **+1.7%** civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS **+15.6%** residential YoY (3mo avg)	DAYS ON MARKET **39 days** median, +5.4% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

STRONG

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Providence-Warwick metro area has an overall grade of C, ranking 43.3th percentile out of 50 US metros, with a composite score reflecting a mix of near-median labor demand and significant challenges in affordability. The city's economic character is most defined by its low unemployment rate of 4.30% and its high cost of living, with a PSF to wages ratio of 9.73. These metrics signal a tight labor market with upward pressure on wages, but also a challenging environment for attracting talent due to high living costs.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Providence-Warwick is +0.60% year-over-year, combined with a +0.426% deviation in weekly hours from its own trend, indicating a near-median labor demand composite score of 5.57. This combination signals a genuine demand expansion, albeit at a moderate pace. The city's labor market is adding jobs, and hours are running above trend, suggesting that businesses are experiencing some level of growth.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Providence-Warwick is 4.30%, ranking in the bottom tier at the 8th percentile, indicating a very tight labor market. This means that businesses trying to hire in this city will face significant competition for workers, leading to upward pressure on wages. With such a low unemployment rate, hiring may be challenging, and companies may need to offer competitive salaries to attract top talent.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Providence-Warwick is +3.47%, ranking near the median at the 40th percentile. This moderate wage growth rate suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but not excessively so. As a result, worker purchasing power is increasing, which can be beneficial for local consumer demand, but may also lead to higher costs for businesses operating in the area.

Cost of Living

Providence-Warwick has a cost of living score that ranks in the bottom tier at the 2nd percentile, with a PSF to wages ratio of 9.73, driven by a PSF of $357/sqft that has increased by 7.5% year-over-year, compared to hourly earnings of $36.70. This makes the city relatively expensive compared to its peers, which can be a significant disadvantage for talent attraction, as businesses may need to offer wage premiums to compensate for the high cost of living.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Providence-Warwick is growing at a rate of +1.69% year-over-year, ranking in the top tier at the 90th percentile. This indicates that the workforce supply is expanding, which is a positive sign for businesses looking to hire, as it suggests a growing pool

of potential employees. This growth can help mitigate some of the challenges posed by the tight labor market.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Providence-Warwick has increased by +15.64% year-over-year, ranking above average at the 74th percentile. This suggests that housing supply is expanding, which can help improve affordability and accommodate a growing workforce. As a result, the city may become more attractive to workers and businesses in the future.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Providence-Warwick is 39 days, with a year-over-year increase of +5.4%, ranking in the top tier at the 80th percentile. This indicates a relatively slow market, which can make it more accessible for workers relocating to the city, as they have more time to find a home. However, this may also signal a normalization of the market after a period of rapid growth.

Office Economy

Providence-Warwick has an office economy score that ranks above average at the 68th percentile, with a share of professional and office workers at 2.90. This suggests a deep talent pool suited for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors. However, the city may be less suited for industries that require a large workforce in industrial or logistics roles.

The Providence-Warwick metro area offers businesses a growing labor force and expanding housing supply, but its high cost of living and tight labor market pose significant challenges. The single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the need to offer competitive wages and potentially wage premiums to attract and retain top talent in this expensive city, which can increase labor costs and impact business profitability.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #33 OF 50

Atlanta

Atlanta-Sandy Springs-Roswell

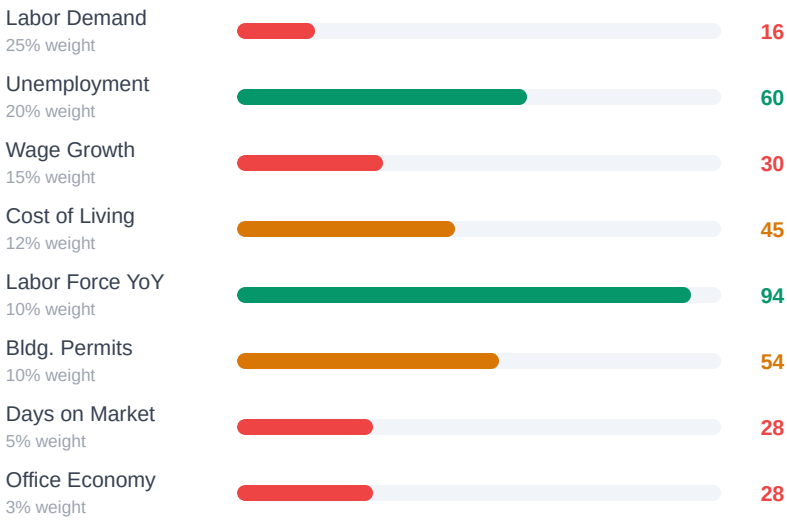
C

VERY POOR

42.9th percentile

Rank 33 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT **3.5%** of civilian labor force	WAGE GROWTH YOY **+2.9%** avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH **-0.1%** nonfarm payrolls YoY	LABOR FORCE YOY **+2.6%** civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS **+1.4%** residential YoY (3mo avg)	DAYS ON MARKET **61 days** median, +1.7% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

SQUEEZE

Payrolls contracting while hours rise — survivor squeeze signal.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Atlanta-Sandy Springs-Roswell metro area has an overall grade of C, ranking 42.9th percentile out of 50 US metros, with a labor demand composite score of 3.58, which is in the bottom tier at the 16th percentile. This city's current economic character is most defined by its weak labor demand and strong labor force growth, with employment growth at -0.09% year-over-year and labor force growth at +2.60% year-over-year. The combination of these metrics suggests a city with a growing workforce but struggling to create new jobs.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Atlanta is -0.09% year-over-year, and weekly hours are deviating from the trend by +0.595%, indicating a scenario where hours are increasing despite job losses, which suggests a survivor squeeze. This means that remaining workers are absorbing the load of eliminated roles, rather than genuine demand expansion. The labor demand composite score of 3.58 is in the bottom tier, confirming this interpretation.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Atlanta is 3.50%, which is at the 60th percentile, indicating a relatively tight market with some slack. This means that while it may be slightly easier to hire than in other cities, there is still some competition for talent, and businesses may face moderate wage pressure. The practical implication is that businesses trying to hire in Atlanta will need to offer competitive wages to attract top talent.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Atlanta is +2.88%, which is below average at the 30th percentile, indicating moderate wage growth. This means that employer labor costs are rising, but not as quickly as in other cities, and worker purchasing power is increasing, but not dramatically. The implication is that businesses will need to balance rising labor costs with the need to attract and retain talent.

Cost of Living

The cost of living in Atlanta is near the median at the 45th percentile, with a PSF of $193/sqft and average hourly earnings of $36.77/hr, resulting in a ratio of 5.25. This means that the city is relatively affordable compared to its peers, which is a talent attraction advantage. Businesses can attract workers without needing to offer significant wage premiums to offset high living costs.

Labor Force Growth

The labor force in Atlanta is growing at a rate of +2.60% year-over-year, which is in the top tier at the 94th percentile, indicating an expanding workforce supply. This means that businesses have a growing pool of potential workers to hire from, which is a significant advantage for companies looking to expand or relocate.

Building Permits

The number of building permits in Atlanta is increasing by +1.38% year-over-year, which is near the median at the 54th percentile, indicating a slowly expanding housing supply. This means that the city is likely to see some improvement in affordability and workforce accommodation in the future, although the pace of change is moderate.

Days on Market

The median days on market in Atlanta is 61 days, with a year-over-year increase of +1.7%, which is below average at the 28th percentile. This means that the housing market is relatively competitive, and workers relocating to the city may face some challenges in finding a home quickly. However, the rising days on market may also indicate a healthy normalization of the market.

Office Economy

The office economy in Atlanta is below average at the 28th percentile, with a share of professional and office workers at 2.00 on a composite scale of 0-5. This means that the city has a relatively shallow talent pool in professional and office sectors, making it less suited for businesses that require a deep knowledge-economy talent pool, such as tech or finance companies.

The Atlanta-Sandy Springs-Roswell metro area offers businesses a growing workforce and relatively affordable cost of living, but the single biggest risk or constraint is the weak labor demand, which may limit the city's ability to create new jobs and drive economic growth. Decision-makers should factor in the potential for a survivor squeeze, where remaining workers absorb the load of eliminated roles, rather than genuine demand expansion. Overall, the city's strengths in labor force growth and affordability are offset by its weaknesses in labor demand and office economy depth.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #34 OF 50

Fresno

Fresno

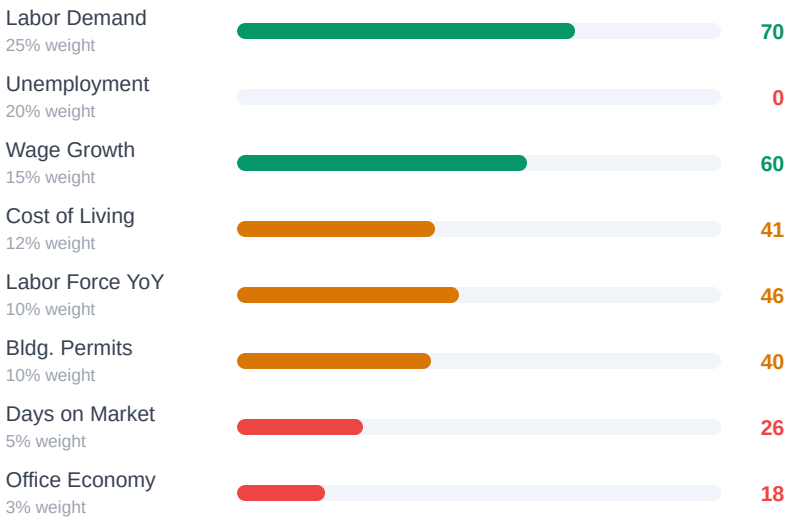
C

VERY POOR

41.8th percentile

Rank 34 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT **7.3%** of civilian labor force	WAGE GROWTH YOY **+4.2%** avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH **+1.9%** nonfarm payrolls YoY	LABOR FORCE YOY **-0.5%** civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS **-6.9%** residential YoY (3mo avg)	DAYS ON MARKET **61 days** median, +3.4% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

GROWING

Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The city of Fresno has an overall grade of C, ranking 41.8th percentile out of 50 US metros, with a labor demand composite score of 6.15 and an unemployment rate of 7.30%. The city's economic character is most defined by its high labor demand, with a 70th percentile ranking, and its low unemployment rate, which is in the bottom tier. These metrics signal a complex labor market with both opportunities and challenges.

Labor Demand

Fresno's employment growth rate is 1.86% year-over-year, and weekly hours are deviating -0.757% from the city's own 12-month baseline, resulting in a labor demand composite score of 6.15, which is above average. This combination signals genuine demand expansion, as jobs are being added and hours are running above trend. However, the negative deviation in weekly hours may indicate some level of survivor squeeze, where remaining workers are absorbing the load of eliminated roles.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Fresno is 7.30%, which is in the bottom tier, indicating a loose labor market with significant slack. This means that businesses trying to hire in Fresno may find it easier to staff, but may also face weaker local consumer demand. The low unemployment rate also suggests that there may be less wage pressure, as workers have fewer job opportunities.

Wage Growth

Wage growth in Fresno is 4.23% year-over-year, which is above average, indicating a moderate to fast pace of wage growth. This implies rising labor costs for employers, but also increasing worker purchasing power. As wages rise, businesses may need to adjust their pricing strategies to maintain profitability, while workers may see improvements in their standard of living.

Cost of Living

Fresno has a cost of living percentile rank of 41, with a PSF of $261/sqft and average hourly earnings of $33.92/hr, resulting in a ratio of 7.69. This indicates that the city is near the median in terms of affordability, neither extremely expensive nor very affordable. For businesses, this means that talent attraction may not be significantly hindered by high costs, but may not be greatly facilitated by low costs either.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Fresno is growing at a rate of -0.53% year-over-year, indicating a contracting labor pool. This signals a structural headwind for hiring, as the supply of workers is shrinking. Businesses may need to consider strategies to attract workers from other areas or invest in training and development programs to build the skills of the existing workforce.

Building Permits

The number of building permits in Fresno is decreasing by 6.89% year-over-year, indicating a tightening housing supply. This signals a potential future affordability crisis and workforce accommodation challenges, as the supply of housing is not keeping pace with demand. Businesses may need to consider the potential impact of housing costs on their employees' quality of life and ability to attract talent.

Days on Market

The median days on market in Fresno is 61 days, with a year-over-year increase of 3.4%. This indicates a slowing market, where homes are taking longer to sell. For workers relocating to Fresno, this may mean a more accessible and less competitive housing market, with more time to find a suitable home.

Office Economy

Fresno has an office economy percentile rank of 18, indicating a relatively shallow professional talent pool. This suggests that the city is less suited for businesses that require a deep pool of specialized office workers, such as tech, finance, or consulting firms. However, the city may be more suitable for businesses that require a more general workforce or have industrial or logistics-oriented operations.

The city of Fresno offers businesses a complex labor market with both opportunities and challenges, including a high labor demand and low unemployment rate. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the contracting labor pool, which may hinder hiring and talent attraction efforts. Businesses will need to carefully consider these factors when evaluating Fresno as a potential location for their operations.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #35 OF 50

San Jose

San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara

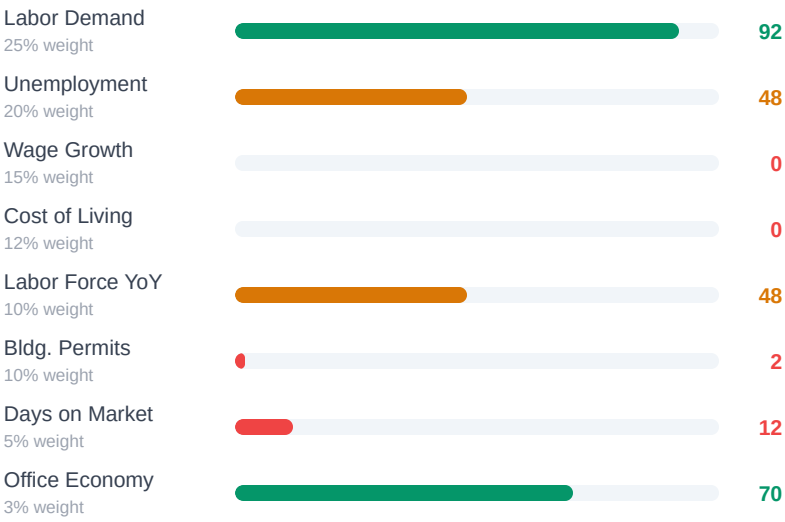
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VERY POOR

40.3th percentile

Rank 35 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT **4.2%** of civilian labor force	WAGE GROWTH YOY **-0.5%** avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH **+1.6%** nonfarm payrolls YoY	LABOR FORCE YOY **-0.3%** civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS **-50.0%** residential YoY (3mo avg)	DAYS ON MARKET **37 days** median, -2.6% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

STRONG

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara metro area has an overall grade of C, ranking 40.3th percentile out of 50 US metros, with a composite score driven largely by its strong labor demand and deep professional talent pool. The city's labor demand composite score of 7.71, which combines a 1.65% employment growth rate and a 1.096% weekly hours deviation above trend, signals genuine demand expansion. The unemployment rate and wage growth, however, tell a more nuanced story, with the latter being a significant concern.

Labor Demand

The San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara metro area has a labor demand composite score of 7.71, driven by a 1.65% employment growth rate and a 1.096% weekly hours deviation above trend, indicating genuine demand expansion. This combination signals that the city is adding jobs and workers are putting in more hours, a positive sign for businesses looking to expand. The strong labor demand suggests a competitive market for workers, but also a growing economy.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara is 4.20%, ranking near the median at the 48th percentile, indicating a relatively balanced labor market with some slack. This rate suggests that while it may not be extremely difficult to hire, businesses may still face some competition for top talent. The moderate unemployment rate implies that businesses can find workers, but may need to offer competitive wages and benefits to attract the best candidates.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara is -0.50%, ranking at the bottom tier, indicating stagnant or even declining wages. This slow wage growth suggests that labor costs for employers may be stable, but worker purchasing power may be weakening. The implication for businesses is that they may not face significant wage pressure, but may need to consider other benefits to attract and retain talent.

Cost of Living

San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara has a cost of living ratio of $821/sqft to $53.28/hr, with a percentile rank of 0, indicating an extremely expensive city. The fact that the PSF is falling by 2.0% YoY provides some relief, but the city remains one of the most expensive in the country. This high cost of living means that businesses may need to offer significant wage premiums to attract talent, making it challenging to maintain a competitive edge.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara is growing at a rate of -0.34% year-over-year, ranking near the median, indicating a relatively stable but slightly contracting labor pool. This slow growth rate suggests that the supply of workers is not expanding rapidly, which may pose a challenge for businesses looking to hire. The implication is that businesses may need to be more competitive in their hiring practices to attract the available talent.

Building Permits

The number of building permits in San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara has decreased by 50.02% year-over-year, ranking at the bottom tier, indicating a significant tightening of the housing supply. This sharp decline in permits suggests that the city's housing market may become even more competitive, making it challenging for workers to find affordable housing. The implication for businesses is that they may need to consider offering relocation assistance or other benefits to help workers navigate the tight housing market.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara is 37 days, with a year-over-year decrease of 2.6%, ranking at the bottom tier. This fast-paced market suggests that workers relocating to the city may face significant competition for housing, making it challenging to find a place to live. The implication for businesses is that they may need to provide relocation support or flexible timing for new hires to accommodate the competitive housing market.

Office Economy

San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara has a deep professional talent pool, with an office/professional worker share of 2.92, ranking above average at the 70th percentile. This suggests that the city is well-suited for businesses in the tech, finance, and consulting sectors, but may not be as attractive for industries with more industrial or logistics-oriented workforces. The city's strong office economy makes it an ideal location for businesses that require a highly skilled and specialized workforce.

The San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara metro area offers businesses a strong labor demand and a deep professional talent pool, making it an attractive location for companies in the tech and finance sectors. However, the city's extremely high cost of living and stagnant wage growth pose significant challenges for businesses looking to attract and retain talent, and may require companies to offer significant wage premiums or relocation assistance to remain competitive.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #36 OF 50

New York

New York Newark-Jersey City

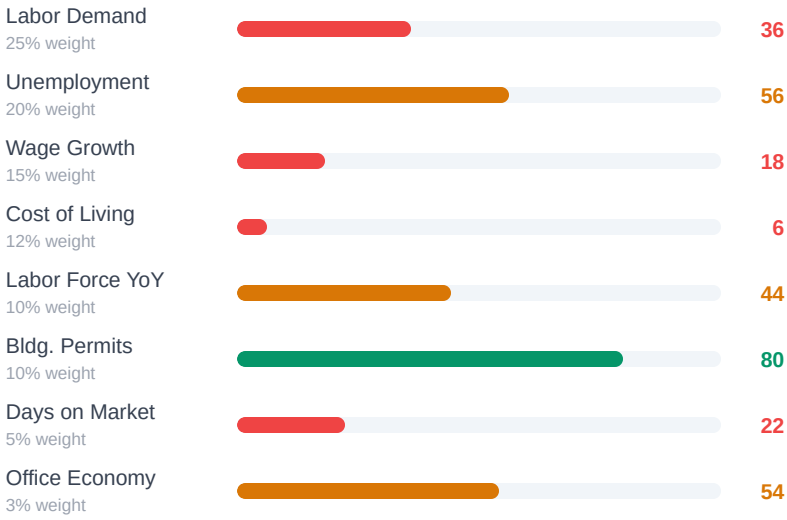
C

VERY POOR

38.8th percentile

Rank 36 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT **4.5%** of civilian labor force	WAGE GROWTH YOY **+1.8%** avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH **+0.2%** nonfarm payrolls YoY	LABOR FORCE YOY **-0.5%** civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS **+20.7%** residential YoY (3mo avg)	DAYS ON MARKET **53 days** median, -1.9% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

GROWING

Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The New York Newark-Jersey City metro area has an overall grade of C, ranking 38.8th percentile out of 50 US metros, with a composite score driven largely by its low labor demand and high cost of living. The labor demand composite score of 4.35, which combines a +0.25% employment growth rate and a -0.303% weekly hours deviation from trend, signals a contraction in genuine demand. The cost of living, with a PSF of $498/sqft and a ratio of 12.28 to hourly earnings of $40.54, ranks in the bottom tier at the 6th percentile.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate of +0.25% and weekly hours deviation of -0.303% from trend indicate a lack of genuine demand expansion, suggesting that the labor market is not experiencing significant growth. This combination signals a contraction in labor demand, rather than a survivor squeeze, as hours are below trend during a period of slow job growth. The labor demand composite score of 4.35 is below average, ranking at the 36th percentile.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate of 4.50% is near the median, ranking at the 56th percentile, indicating a relatively balanced labor market with neither significant slack nor tightness. This rate suggests that businesses may face moderate challenges in hiring, but not extreme wage pressure. The market is not particularly tight, but it is also not overly slack, making it a relatively stable environment for hiring.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate of +1.79% is in the bottom tier, ranking at the 18th percentile, indicating stagnant wage growth. This slow wage growth suggests that labor costs for employers are not rising rapidly, but it also implies weak bargaining power for workers and potentially limited purchasing power. The slow wage growth may be a concern for businesses relying on local consumer demand.

Cost of Living

The cost of living in New York Newark-Jersey City is expensive, with a PSF of $498/sqft and a ratio of 12.28 to hourly earnings of $40.54, ranking in the bottom tier at the 6th percentile. However, the PSF is falling by -1.4% YoY, which may indicate some improvement in affordability. The high cost of living makes it challenging for businesses to attract talent without offering wage premiums, as the city's affordability is relatively low compared to peers.

Labor Force Growth

The labor force growth rate of -0.54% indicates a contracting labor pool, ranking near the median at the 44th percentile. This contraction suggests that the supply of workers is shrinking, which may create structural headwinds for hiring and business expansion. The declining labor force growth rate may limit the city's ability to support rapid business growth.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in building permits is +20.67%, ranking in the top tier at the 80th percentile, indicating an expansion in housing supply. This growth in permits suggests that developer confidence is high, and future housing supply is likely to increase, which may improve affordability and support workforce accommodation. The rising permits may help mitigate potential housing shortages and support business growth.

Days on Market

The current median days on market is 53 days, with a -1.9% YoY change, ranking below average at the 22nd percentile. This relatively fast market suggests that homes are selling quickly, which may make it challenging for relocating workers to find housing. The fast-paced market may require businesses to provide relocation support or incentives to attract talent.

Office Economy

The share of professional and office workers is 2.60, ranking near the median at the 54th percentile, indicating a moderate depth of professional talent. This city is relatively well-suited for businesses that require a mix of office and non-office skills, but may not be the best fit for businesses that rely heavily on specialized professional or tech talent.

The New York Newark-Jersey City metro area offers businesses a large and diverse labor market, but its high cost of living and slow wage growth pose significant challenges. The single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the city's expensive cost of living, which may require businesses to offer wage premiums to attract and retain talent, potentially limiting their competitiveness and growth prospects.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #37 OF 50

Sacramento

Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom

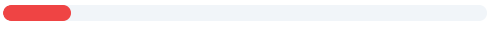
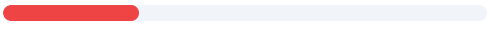
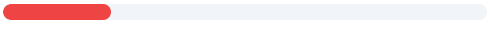
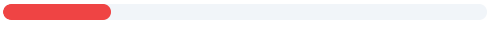
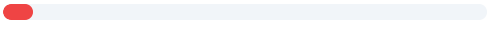
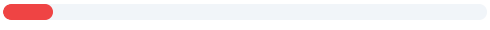
C

VERY POOR

38.6th percentile

Rank 37 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand (25% weight)		74
Unemployment (20% weight)		14
Wage Growth (15% weight)		28
Cost of Living (12% weight)		22
Labor Force YoY (10% weight)		22
Bldg. Permits (10% weight)		76
Days on Market (5% weight)		6
Office Economy (3% weight)		10

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT
5.0%
of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY
+2.6%
avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH
+0.8%
nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE YOY
-1.3%
civilian labor force growth

BUILDING PERMITS
+15.8%
residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET
52 days
median, -10.3% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

STRONG

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom metro area has an overall grade of C, ranking 38.6th percentile out of 50 US metros, with a composite score defined largely by its labor demand and unemployment metrics. The city's labor demand composite score of 6.29, which combines a +0.82% employment growth rate and a +0.838% weekly hours deviation from its own trend, signals genuine demand expansion. This is further complicated by an unemployment rate of 5.00%, which is in the bottom tier at the 14th percentile.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate of +0.82% and weekly hours deviation of +0.838% from its own trend indicate that Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom is experiencing genuine demand expansion, with more jobs being added and hours running above trend. This combination suggests a strong labor market where businesses are likely to face competition for talent. The labor demand composite score of 6.29, ranking in the 74th percentile, reinforces this interpretation.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate of 5.00% places Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom in the bottom tier at the 14th percentile, indicating a relatively loose labor market with some slack. For businesses trying to hire, this means that while there may be available candidates, the market is not as competitive as in tighter labor markets, potentially easing hiring pressures but also signaling weaker local consumer demand.

Wage Growth

With a year-over-year wage growth rate of +2.60%, Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom experiences below-average wage growth, ranking in the 28th percentile. This moderate wage growth implies that labor costs for employers are increasing, but at a slower pace, and worker purchasing power is not growing as quickly as in other metros. This could be a mixed blessing for businesses, offering some cost stability but also potentially weaker consumer spending.

Cost of Living

Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom has a cost of living score that ranks in the 22nd percentile, indicating that it is less affordable relative to its peers, with a PSF to earnings ratio of $338/sqft to $38.15/hr, or 8.86. Although the PSF is falling by -0.3% YoY, the city's affordability is still a concern, which could make it harder to attract talent without offering wage premiums to compensate for the higher cost of living.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom is shrinking at a rate of -1.29% year-over-year, placing it in the 22nd percentile. This contraction in labor force supply poses a structural headwind for hiring, as businesses may find it challenging to fill positions due to a dwindling pool of available workers.

Building Permits

The city saw a +15.85% year-over-year increase in residential building permits, ranking in the 76th percentile. This significant expansion in housing supply signals improving affordability and a more accommodating environment for the workforce in the future, which could help attract and retain talent.

Days on Market

Homes in Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom are currently selling after 52 days on the market, with a -10.3% year-over-year change, placing the city in the bottom tier at the 6th percentile. This fast-paced market makes it challenging for relocating workers to find and secure housing, potentially complicating recruitment and retention efforts for businesses.

Office Economy

With an office and professional worker share ranking in the 10th percentile, Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom has a relatively shallow talent pool in these sectors. This makes the city less suited for businesses in tech, finance, consulting, or HQ operations that rely heavily on professional and office workers, but it may be more accommodating to industries with different workforce needs.

The Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom metro area offers businesses a mix of genuine labor demand expansion and a loose labor market, but it is constrained by a shrinking labor force and high cost of living. The single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the challenge of attracting and retaining talent due to the city's affordability issues and competitive housing market, which could necessitate wage premiums and strategic recruitment planning.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #38 OF 50

Minneapolis

Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington

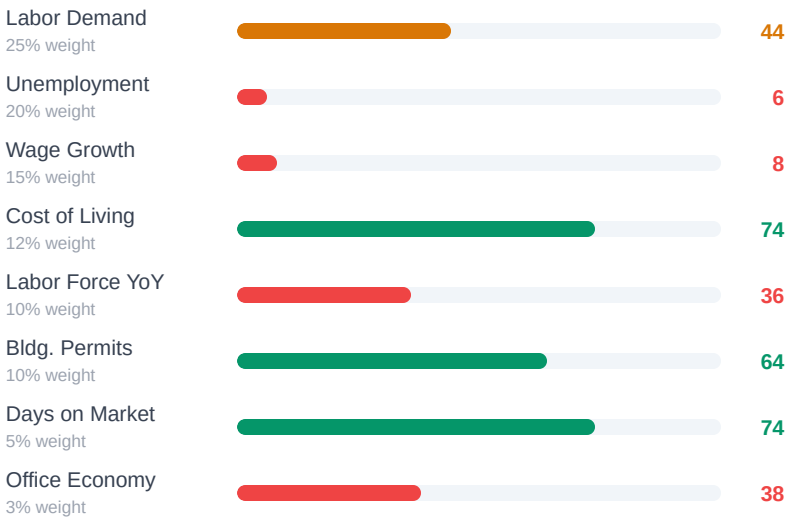
C-

CRITICAL

37.1th percentile

Rank 38 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT **4.5%** of civilian labor force	WAGE GROWTH YOY **+0.7%** avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH **+1.1%** nonfarm payrolls YoY	LABOR FORCE YOY **-0.7%** civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS **+10.9%** residential YoY (3mo avg)	DAYS ON MARKET **43 days** median, +4.9% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

GROWING

Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington metro area has an overall grade of C- with a composite score ranking at the 37.1th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its low unemployment rate of 4.50% and its slow wage growth of +0.68% year-over-year, indicating a tight labor market with moderate labor cost pressure. The labor demand composite score of 5.05, near the median, suggests a relatively stable job market.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate of +1.12% year-over-year and weekly hours deviation of -0.822% from the city's own trend signal a moderate expansion of genuine demand, as hours are not significantly above trend during job growth. This combination indicates that the city is adding jobs, but at a pace that is not excessively straining the existing workforce. The labor demand composite score of 5.05 reinforces this interpretation, suggesting a stable and moderately growing job market.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate of 4.50% is relatively low, ranking in the bottom tier at the 6th percentile, indicating a tight labor market with limited slack. This means that businesses trying to hire in this city may face challenges in finding available workers, leading to potential wage pressure and recruitment difficulties. As a result, employers may need to offer competitive salaries and benefits to attract top talent.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate of +0.68% is slow, ranking in the bottom tier at the 8th percentile, suggesting moderate labor cost pressure. This implies that employers may not face rapidly rising labor costs, but workers may not have strong bargaining power to demand higher wages. As a result, the city's wage growth may not keep pace with inflation, potentially affecting worker purchasing power.

Cost of Living

The city's cost of living, with a PSF of $204/sqft and a ratio of 5.00 to average hourly earnings of $40.79, ranks in the 74th percentile, indicating a relatively affordable market. The fact that PSF is falling by -2.9% year-over-year further supports this assessment, making the city more attractive for talent without requiring wage premiums. This affordability advantage can be a significant draw for businesses looking to relocate or expand in the area.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force is contracting at a rate of -0.73% year-over-year, ranking below average at the 36th percentile, indicating a shrinking labor pool. This contraction implies a structural headwind for hiring, as the supply of available workers is decreasing, making it

more challenging for businesses to find the talent they need. As a result, employers may need to invest in training and development programs to upskill existing workers.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in building permits is +10.95%, ranking above average at the 64th percentile, signaling an expansion of housing supply. This increase in permits suggests that developer confidence is rising, and future housing supply is likely to improve, leading to better affordability and workforce accommodation. As a result, the city may become more attractive to relocating workers and businesses.

Days on Market

The current median days on market is 43 days, with a year-over-year increase of +4.9%, ranking in the 74th percentile, indicating a slower market. This means that homes are sitting on the market for a relatively long time, making it more accessible for workers relocating to the city. However, this slower market may also indicate a normalization of the housing market, rather than a demand erosion.

Office Economy

The share of professional and office workers is 2.40, ranking below average at the 38th percentile, indicating a relatively shallow talent pool in these sectors. This suggests that the city is less suited for businesses that require a deep knowledge-economy talent pool, such as tech, finance, or consulting firms, but may be more suitable for industrial or logistics-dominant businesses.

The Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington metro area offers a relatively affordable cost of living and a stable job market, making it an attractive location for businesses looking to relocate or expand. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the tight labor market, which may lead to recruitment challenges and wage pressure, requiring employers to adapt their hiring strategies and compensation packages to attract and retain top talent.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #39 OF 50

Virginia Beach

Virginia Beach-Chesapeake-Norfolk

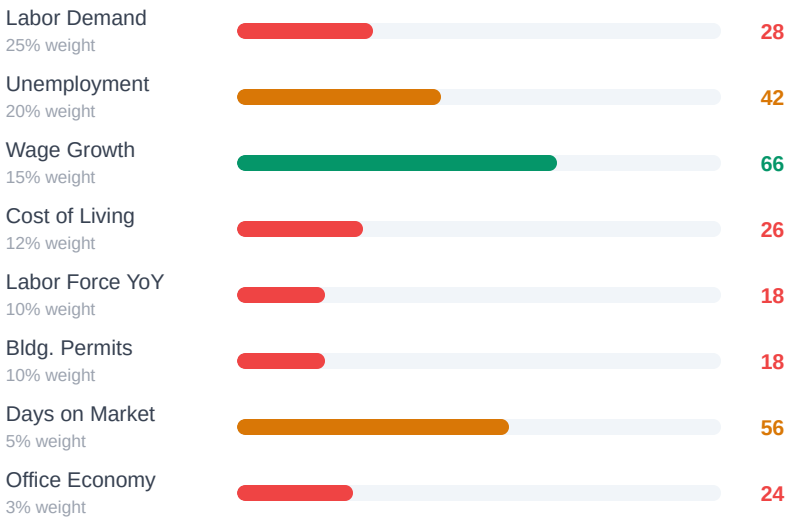
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CRITICAL

35.6th percentile

Rank 39 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT **3.8%** of civilian labor force	WAGE GROWTH YOY **+4.5%** avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH **-0.2%** nonfarm payrolls YoY	LABOR FORCE YOY **-1.4%** civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS **-17.5%** residential YoY (3mo avg)	DAYS ON MARKET **45 days** median, +2.3% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

WEAK

Both employment and hours declining — broad contraction.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Virginia Beach-Chesapeake-Norfolk metro area has an overall grade of C- with a composite score ranking it 35.6th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its below-average labor demand, with a composite score of 3.98, and its above-average wage growth of 4.48% year-over-year. The labor demand and wage growth metrics suggest a complex economic environment, with a mix of job market contraction and rising labor costs.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in this metro area is -0.23% year-over-year, and weekly hours are deviating -0.074% from the city's own 12-month baseline. This combination signals a contraction in labor demand, indicating that the job market is not expanding. The negative employment growth rate and below-trend hours suggest that businesses may not be adding new jobs at a significant pace.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in this metro area is 3.80%, ranking near the median at the 42nd percentile. This suggests that the labor market has some slack, making it slightly easier for businesses to hire compared to tighter markets. However, the relatively low unemployment rate still implies some competition for talent, and businesses may need to offer competitive wages to attract workers.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in this metro area is 4.48%, which is above average, ranking at the 66th percentile. This rapid wage growth signals rising labor costs for employers, but it also indicates strong worker purchasing power. As wages continue to grow, businesses may need to adjust their pricing strategies or operational efficiencies to maintain profitability.

Cost of Living

The cost of living in this metro area is below average, with a percentile rank of 26th, due to a PSF of $222/sqft and average hourly earnings of $34.92, resulting in a ratio of 6.36. However, the PSF is increasing by 2.3% year-over-year, which may erode affordability over time. The relatively low affordability score suggests that businesses may need to offer wage premiums to attract talent, as the cost of living is relatively high compared to other metros.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in this metro area is contracting at a rate of -1.37% year-over-year, ranking in the bottom tier at the 18th percentile. This decline in labor force supply implies a structural headwind for hiring, as the pool of available workers is shrinking. Businesses may need to invest in workforce development or recruitment strategies to attract talent from other areas.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in this metro area is decreasing by 17.54% year-over-year, ranking in the bottom tier at the 18th percentile. This sharp decline in building permits suggests a tightening housing supply, which may lead to affordability challenges and difficulties in accommodating a growing workforce. As housing supply contracts, businesses may need to consider the potential impact on employee relocation and retention.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in this metro area is 45 days, with a year-over-year increase of 2.3%. This relatively slow market, ranking near the median at the 56th percentile, suggests that workers relocating to this city may have a more accessible and less competitive housing market. However, the rising days on market may also indicate a normalization of the market, rather than a demand erosion.

Office Economy

The professional and office worker share in this metro area is below average, ranking at the 24th percentile. This suggests a relatively shallow talent pool for businesses requiring specialized knowledge-economy workers, such as tech, finance, or consulting firms. While this city may be suitable for industrial or logistics-dominant businesses, it may not be the best fit for companies requiring a deep pool of professional talent.

The Virginia Beach-Chesapeake-Norfolk metro area offers a complex economic environment with both opportunities and challenges for businesses. While the above-average wage growth and relatively low unemployment rate suggest a strong labor market, the below-average labor demand and declining labor force supply pose significant risks for hiring and workforce development. The single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the potential affordability challenges and tightening housing supply, which may impact employee relocation and retention.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #40 OF 50

Milwaukee

Milwaukee-Waukesha

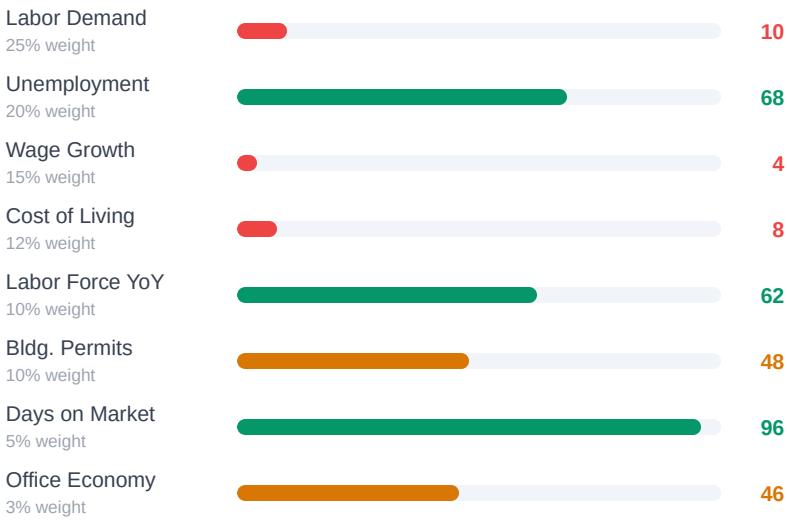
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CRITICAL

34.9th percentile

Rank 40 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT **3.2%** of civilian labor force	WAGE GROWTH YOY **-0.2%** avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH **+0.2%** nonfarm payrolls YoY	LABOR FORCE YOY **+0.4%** civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS **-4.2%** residential YoY (3mo avg)	DAYS ON MARKET **37 days** median, +15.6% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

GROWING

Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Milwaukee-Waukesha metro area has an overall grade of C- with a composite score ranking it 34.9th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its low labor demand, with a composite score in the bottom tier (10th percentile), and its stagnant wage growth, at -0.19% year-over-year. The combination of these metrics suggests a challenging environment for businesses looking to expand or relocate.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Milwaukee-Waukesha is +0.19% year-over-year, while weekly hours are deviating -1.889% from the city's own 12-month baseline. This combination signals a contraction in labor demand, indicating that the city is not experiencing genuine demand expansion. The low labor demand composite score of 3.07 further reinforces this assessment.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Milwaukee-Waukesha is 3.20%, which corresponds to an above-average percentile rank of 68th. This suggests that the labor market has some slack, making it slightly easier for businesses to hire. However, the relatively low unemployment rate may still lead to some wage pressure, as workers have more bargaining power.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Milwaukee-Waukesha is -0.19%, indicating stagnant wage growth. This slow wage growth environment means that labor costs for employers are not rising rapidly, but it also implies weak bargaining power for workers and potentially limited purchasing power.

Cost of Living

Milwaukee-Waukesha has a cost of living percentile rank of 8th, making it an expensive city relative to its peers. The PSF-to-earnings ratio is $227/sqft vs $36.28/hr, resulting in a ratio of 6.26. This high cost of living may deter talent attraction, as businesses may need to offer wage premiums to compensate for the expensive housing market.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Milwaukee-Waukesha is growing at a rate of +0.39% year-over-year, indicating an expanding labor force supply. This positive growth rate suggests that the city has a growing pool of potential workers, which can support hiring capacity.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in residential building permits is -4.20%, indicating a tightening housing supply. This decline in building permits may signal future affordability challenges and workforce accommodation constraints, as the supply of new housing is not keeping pace

with demand.

Days on Market

The current median days on market is 37 days, with a year-over-year increase of +15.6%. This corresponds to a top-tier percentile rank of 96th, indicating a slower market. For workers relocating to this city, the slower market may make it easier to find a home, but it also suggests a less competitive environment.

Office Economy

The professional and office worker share in Milwaukee-Waukesha is 2.48, corresponding to a near-median percentile rank of 46th. This suggests a moderately deep talent pool, making the city suitable for businesses that require a mix of professional and non-professional workers. However, it may not be the best fit for businesses that require a highly specialized or knowledge-intensive workforce.

In conclusion, Milwaukee-Waukesha offers a relatively affordable labor market with some slack, but its low labor demand and stagnant wage growth pose significant challenges for businesses. The single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the city's expensive housing market, which may require wage premiums to attract and retain talent, ultimately affecting business competitiveness and growth prospects.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #41 OF 50

Denver

Denver-Aurora-Centennial

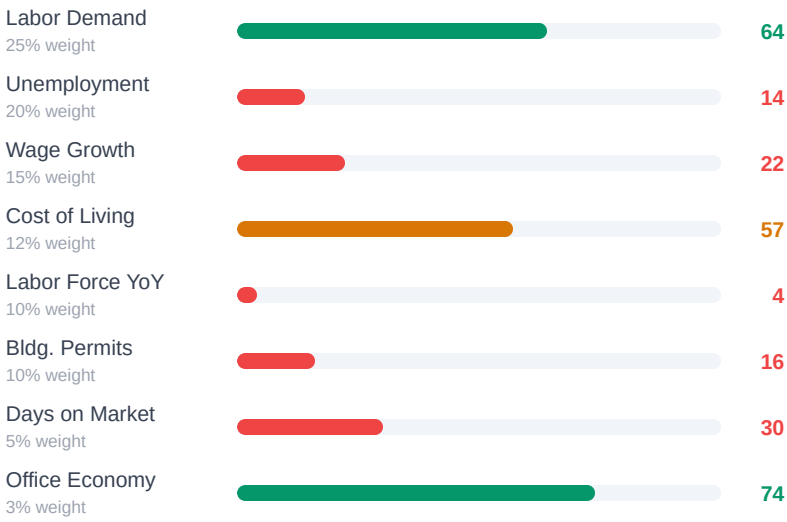
C-

CRITICAL

34.7th percentile

Rank 41 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT **4.3%** of civilian labor force	WAGE GROWTH YOY **+1.9%** avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH **+0.2%** nonfarm payrolls YoY	LABOR FORCE YOY **-2.4%** civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS **-18.6%** residential YoY (3mo avg)	DAYS ON MARKET **60 days** median, -4.8% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

STRONG

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Denver-Aurora-Centennial metro area has an overall grade of C- with a composite score ranking it 34.7th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its labor demand, which is above average with a 64th percentile ranking, and its labor force growth, which is in the bottom tier with a -2.37% year-over-year change. The combination of these metrics suggests a city with some job growth but significant challenges in expanding its workforce.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Denver-Aurora-Centennial is +0.25% year-over-year, and weekly hours are deviating +1.245% from the city's own 12-month baseline, indicating genuine demand expansion. This combination signals that jobs are being added and hours are running above trend, suggesting a strong labor market. The labor demand composite score of 5.89 further supports this, ranking above average at the 64th percentile.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Denver-Aurora-Centennial is 4.30%, which is in the bottom tier at the 14th percentile, indicating a relatively tight labor market. This means that there is less slack in the market, making it harder for businesses to hire and potentially leading to upward pressure on wages. For a business trying to hire in this city, the tight labor market may require offering competitive salaries to attract top talent.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Denver-Aurora-Centennial is +1.91%, which is below average at the 22nd percentile. This moderate wage growth suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but not as quickly as in other cities. For workers, this means that purchasing power is increasing, but not at a rapid pace.

Cost of Living

Denver-Aurora-Centennial has a cost of living percentile rank of 57th, with a PSF of $277/sqft and average hourly earnings of $43.06/hr, resulting in a ratio of 6.43. The fact that PSF is falling -3.5% year-over-year suggests that the city is becoming more affordable relative to wages. This makes it more attractive for talent, as businesses may not need to offer significant wage premiums to compensate for high living costs.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Denver-Aurora-Centennial is shrinking at a rate of -2.37% year-over-year, which is in the bottom tier at the 4th percentile. This contraction in labor force supply implies that hiring capacity may be limited, making it challenging for businesses to find

and retain workers.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Denver-Aurora-Centennial has decreased by -18.55% year-over-year, which is in the bottom tier at the 16th percentile. This decline in permits suggests that housing supply is tightening, which may lead to future affordability issues and challenges in accommodating a growing workforce.

Days on Market

The current median days on market in Denver-Aurora-Centennial is 60 days, with a year-over-year decrease of -4.8%. This relatively fast market means that homes are selling quickly, making it competitive for workers relocating to the city. However, the decreasing trend may indicate a normalization of the market.

Office Economy

Denver-Aurora-Centennial has a deep professional talent pool, with an office economy percentile rank of 74th. This makes the city well-suited for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors, which require specialized knowledge-economy workers. However, it may be less suitable for industries with more industrial or logistics-oriented workforces.

The Denver-Aurora-Centennial metro area offers businesses a strong labor demand and a relatively deep professional talent pool, but it also presents significant challenges in terms of labor force growth and housing affordability. The single biggest risk or constraint for a decision-maker to factor in is the shrinking labor force supply, which may limit hiring capacity and require businesses to offer competitive salaries to attract and retain top talent.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #42 OF 50

Birmingham

Birmingham

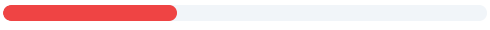
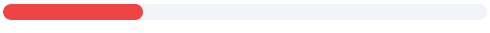
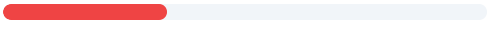
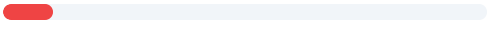
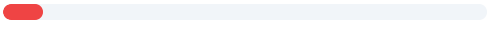
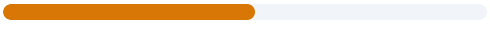
C-

CRITICAL

34.3th percentile

Rank 42 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand 25% weight		68
Unemployment 20% weight		36
Wage Growth 15% weight		2
Cost of Living 12% weight		29
Labor Force YoY 10% weight		34
Bldg. Permits 10% weight		10
Days on Market 5% weight		8
Office Economy 3% weight		52

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT
3.5%
of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY
-0.4%
avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH
+1.2%
nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE YOY
-0.7%
civilian labor force growth

BUILDING PERMITS
-23.8%
residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET
66 days
median, +10.0% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

GROWING

Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Birmingham, with an overall grade of C- and a composite score ranking it 34.3th percentile out of 50 US metros, is characterized by its below-average unemployment rate of 3.50% and stagnant wage growth of -0.40% year-over-year. These two metrics most define the city's current economic character, indicating a tight labor market with limited upward pressure on wages. The labor demand composite score of 5.99, ranking in the 68th percentile, suggests a moderate level of job growth.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate of +1.24% year-over-year, combined with a weekly hours deviation of -0.047% from the city's own trend, signals a genuine demand expansion, albeit with some moderation in hours worked. This combination indicates that the city is adding jobs, but the pace of hours growth is slightly below trend. The labor demand composite score of 5.99, ranking in the 68th percentile, confirms this assessment.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate of 3.50% is below the national average, indicating a tight labor market with limited slack. This means that businesses trying to hire in Birmingham may face challenges in finding available workers, leading to potential wage pressure. With a percentile rank of 36, the city's unemployment rate is lower than 64% of the metros in the comparison set.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate of -0.40% is stagnant, indicating that labor costs for employers are not rising significantly. However, this also means that worker purchasing power is not increasing, which could have implications for local consumer demand. As the 2nd percentile rank suggests, Birmingham's wage growth is among the weakest in the country.

Cost of Living

With a cost of living ratio of $157/sqft to $32.33/hr, and a year-over-year decline of -0.6% in PSF, Birmingham is relatively expensive, ranking in the 29th percentile. This means that the city may struggle to attract talent without offering wage premiums, as the cost of living is higher than in many peer cities.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force is contracting at a rate of -0.74% year-over-year, indicating that the supply of workers is shrinking. This contraction will likely create a structural headwind for hiring, making it more challenging for businesses to find the talent they need. The 34th percentile rank confirms that Birmingham's labor force growth is weaker than most metros.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in building permits is -23.78%, indicating that housing supply is tightening. This decline in permits suggests that future affordability and workforce accommodation may be at risk, as the supply of new housing is not keeping pace with demand. The 10th percentile rank is a concern, as it indicates that Birmingham's permit activity is among the weakest in the country.

Days on Market

The current median days on market is 66 days, with a year-over-year increase of 10.0%. This means that homes are sitting on the market for longer periods, indicating a slower and more buyer-friendly market. However, for workers relocating to Birmingham, this may make it easier to find a home, as the market is less competitive.

Office Economy

With an office/professional worker share of 2.58, ranking in the 52nd percentile, Birmingham has a near-median depth of professional talent pool. This makes the city suitable for businesses that require a moderate level of specialized knowledge workers, but it may not be the best fit for companies that require a deep pool of tech, finance, or consulting talent.

In conclusion, Birmingham offers a tight labor market with limited wage pressure, but also a shrinking labor force and stagnant wage growth. The single biggest risk or constraint for businesses considering locating in Birmingham is the potential difficulty in attracting and retaining talent due to the city's relatively high cost of living and limited housing supply.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #43 OF 50

Riverside

Riverside-San Bernardino-Ontario

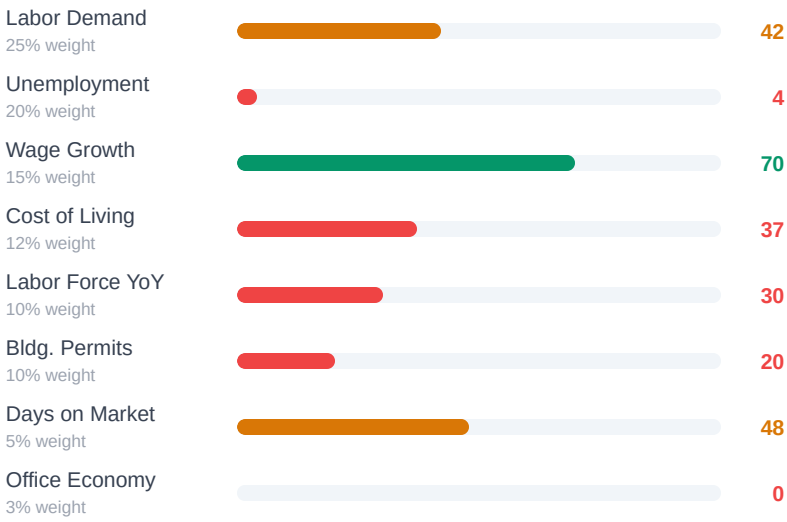
C-

CRITICAL

33.6th percentile

Rank 43 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT **5.7%** of civilian labor force	WAGE GROWTH YOY **+4.7%** avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH **+0.6%** nonfarm payrolls YoY	LABOR FORCE YOY **-0.9%** civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS **-17.2%** residential YoY (3mo avg)	DAYS ON MARKET **62 days** median, -1.6% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

GROWING

Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Riverside-San Bernardino-Ontario metro area has an overall grade of C- with a composite score ranking it 33.6th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its high unemployment rate of 5.70% and its above-average wage growth of +4.69% year-over-year. These two metrics suggest a complex labor market with both challenges and opportunities for businesses.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Riverside-San Bernardino-Ontario is +0.63% year-over-year, while weekly hours are deviating -0.150% from the city's own 12-month baseline. This combination signals a moderate labor demand expansion, with some genuine demand for jobs but also a slight decrease in working hours. The labor demand composite score of 5.03 is near the median, indicating a relatively stable labor market.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Riverside-San Bernardino-Ontario is 5.70%, which is in the bottom tier, ranking 4th percentile. This indicates a labor market with significant slack, making it easier for businesses to hire workers. However, this also suggests weaker local consumer demand, which could impact businesses that rely on local spending.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Riverside-San Bernardino-Ontario is +4.69%, which is above average, ranking 70th percentile. This signals fast wage growth, which is good for worker purchasing power but may increase labor costs for employers. Businesses may need to adjust their budgets to accommodate rising wages.

Cost of Living

Riverside-San Bernardino-Ontario has a cost of living score that ranks 37th percentile, with a PSF of $330/sqft and average hourly earnings of $35.36. The PSF is falling -2.1% year-over-year, making the city relatively more affordable. This could be a talent attraction advantage, as workers may not require wage premiums to afford the cost of living.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Riverside-San Bernardino-Ontario is shrinking at a rate of -0.92% year-over-year, which is below average, ranking 30th percentile. This indicates a contracting labor supply, which could create structural headwinds for hiring and business expansion.

Building Permits

The number of building permits in Riverside-San Bernardino-Ontario is decreasing by -17.17% year-over-year, which is below average, ranking 20th percentile. This suggests a tightening housing supply, which could lead to decreased affordability and make it harder for workers to relocate to the area.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Riverside-San Bernardino-Ontario is 62 days, with a year-over-year decrease of -1.6%. This indicates a relatively fast-paced market, which could make it challenging for relocating workers to find housing. The market is still relatively competitive, but the slight decrease in days on market may signal a healthy normalization.

Office Economy

Riverside-San Bernardino-Ontario has a very shallow professional talent pool, ranking 0th percentile. This makes the city less suited for businesses that require a deep knowledge-economy talent pool, such as tech, finance, or consulting firms. However, it may be more suitable for industries with fewer specialized roles, such as logistics or manufacturing.

The Riverside-San Bernardino-Ontario metro area offers businesses a complex labor market with both opportunities and challenges. While the high unemployment rate and above-average wage growth present a mixed picture, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the shrinking labor force and tightening housing supply, which could limit business expansion and talent attraction. Overall, businesses should carefully weigh these factors when considering a location decision in this city.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #44 OF 50

Jacksonville

Jacksonville

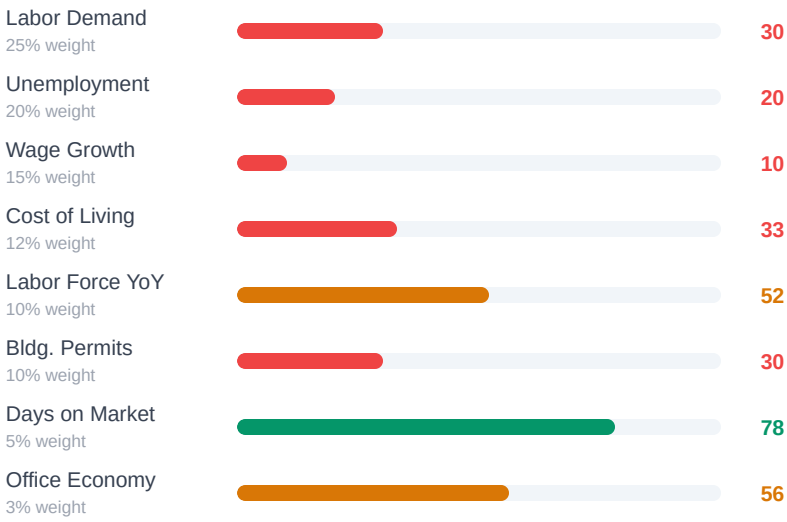
C-

CRITICAL

30.7th percentile

Rank 44 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT **4.5%** of civilian labor force	WAGE GROWTH YOY **+1.0%** avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH **+0.3%** nonfarm payrolls YoY	LABOR FORCE YOY **-0.1%** civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS **-10.8%** residential YoY (3mo avg)	DAYS ON MARKET **66 days** median, -13.2% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

GROWING

Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The city of Jacksonville has an overall grade of C- with a composite score ranking it 30.7th percentile out of 50 US metros. The city's economic character is most defined by its labor demand composite score of 4.20, which ranks in the 30th percentile, and its wage growth rate of +0.97%, which is in the bottom tier at the 10th percentile. These metrics suggest a city with sluggish job market dynamics and stagnant wage growth.

Labor Demand

Jacksonville's employment growth rate is +0.30% year-over-year, while weekly hours are deviating -0.520% from the city's own 12-month baseline. This combination signals a contraction in labor demand, as the city is not adding jobs at a significant rate and hours worked are below trend. This suggests that the city's job market is not experiencing genuine demand expansion.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Jacksonville is 4.50%, which ranks in the 20th percentile, indicating a relatively loose labor market. This means that there is some slack in the market, making it slightly easier for businesses to hire, but it also implies weaker local consumer demand. As a result, businesses may not face intense wage pressure, but they may also not benefit from a highly skilled and competitive workforce.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate in Jacksonville is +0.97%, which is in the bottom tier at the 10th percentile. This stagnant wage growth rate implies that labor costs for employers are not rising rapidly, but it also means that worker purchasing power is not increasing significantly. As a result, businesses may not face significant labor cost pressures, but they may also not benefit from a highly motivated and productive workforce.

Cost of Living

Jacksonville has a cost of living score that ranks in the 33rd percentile, with a PSF of $212/sqft and average hourly earnings of $36.45/hr, resulting in a ratio of 5.82. The fact that PSF is falling -1.4% year-over-year suggests that the city is becoming more affordable. This means that Jacksonville has a talent attraction advantage, as workers can afford to live in the city without requiring significant wage premiums.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Jacksonville is growing at a rate of -0.12% year-over-year, which ranks near the median at the 52nd percentile. This means that the labor force supply is contracting slightly, which may pose a structural headwind for hiring in the city. As a result, businesses may face challenges in finding skilled workers, which could limit their growth prospects.

Building Permits

The number of building permits in Jacksonville is decreasing by -10.81% year-over-year, which ranks in the 30th percentile. This decline in building permits suggests that housing supply is tightening, which may lead to future affordability issues and challenges in accommodating a growing workforce. As a result, businesses may face increased competition for talent and higher labor costs in the long run.

Days on Market

The median days on market in Jacksonville is 66 days, with a year-over-year decrease of -13.2%, which ranks in the 78th percentile. This means that homes are selling relatively slowly, making the market more accessible for relocating workers. However, this also suggests that the market may be normalizing, and businesses should monitor the trend to ensure that it does not signal demand erosion.

Office Economy

Jacksonville's office economy has a composite score of 2.62, which ranks near the median at the 56th percentile. This suggests that the city has a moderately deep professional talent pool, making it suitable for businesses in the tech, finance, and consulting sectors. However, the city may not be as well-suited for businesses that require a highly specialized or knowledge-intensive workforce.

The city of Jacksonville offers businesses a relatively affordable cost of living and a loose labor market, which can make it easier to hire and attract talent. However, the city's sluggish job market dynamics, stagnant wage growth, and tightening housing supply pose significant risks and constraints for businesses looking to locate or expand in the area. The single biggest risk for decision-makers is the potential for labor shortages and increased competition for talent, which could limit business growth prospects and increase labor costs in the long run.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #45 OF 50

Indianapolis

Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood

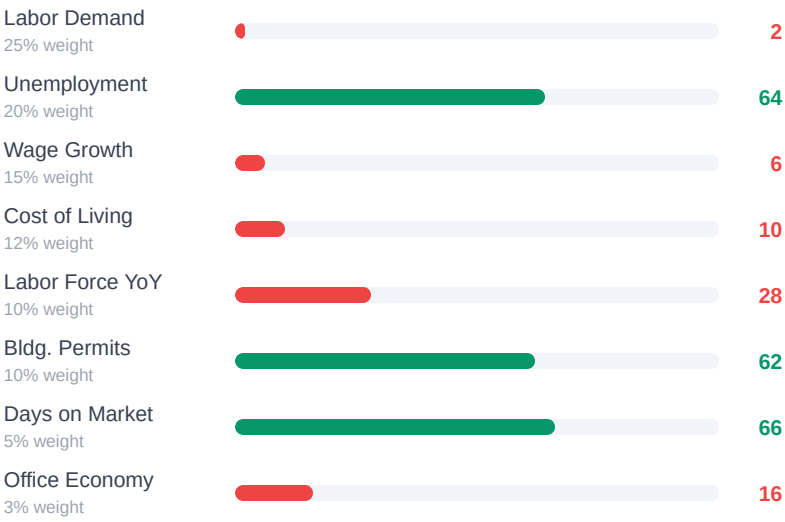
D

EMERGENCY

28.2th percentile

Rank 45 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT **3.4%** of civilian labor force	WAGE GROWTH YOY **+0.5%** avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH **-0.6%** nonfarm payrolls YoY	LABOR FORCE YOY **-1.1%** civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS **+10.4%** residential YoY (3mo avg)	DAYS ON MARKET **55 days** median, +10.0% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

SQUEEZE

Payrolls contracting while hours rise — survivor squeeze signal.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood metro area has an overall grade of D, ranking in the 28.2th percentile out of 50 US metros, with a composite score driven largely by its weak labor demand and stagnant wage growth. The labor demand composite score of 2.73, combining a -0.59% employment growth rate and a +0.742% weekly hours deviation, signals a contraction in labor demand. This is further exacerbated by the low wage growth rate, which is among the lowest in the country.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood is -0.59% year-over-year, while weekly hours are deviating +0.742% from the city's own 12-month baseline. This combination signals a contraction in labor demand, rather than genuine demand expansion or survivor squeeze. The low labor demand composite score of 2.73, ranking in the 2nd percentile, indicates a challenging environment for businesses looking to expand their workforce.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood is 3.40%, ranking in the 64th percentile, indicating a relatively tight labor market. This means that businesses may face challenges in hiring, as the pool of available workers is smaller, and may need to offer higher wages to attract talent. The tight labor market also puts upward pressure on wages, which could increase labor costs for employers.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate in Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood is +0.53%, ranking in the 6th percentile, indicating stagnant wage growth. This slow wage growth means that labor costs for employers are not increasing rapidly, but it also implies weak bargaining power for workers and potentially limited purchasing power. The low wage growth rate may make it difficult for businesses to attract and retain top talent.

Cost of Living

Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood has a cost of living score ranking in the 10th percentile, with a PSF of $164/sqft and an average hourly earnings of $33.83/hr, resulting in a ratio of 4.85. This indicates that the city is relatively expensive, which could make it challenging to attract talent without offering wage premiums. The 5.1% year-over-year increase in PSF further exacerbates the affordability issue.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood is contracting at a rate of -1.13% year-over-year, ranking in the 28th percentile. This decline in labor force supply means that businesses may face structural headwinds in hiring, as the pool of available workers is shrinking. The implications for hiring capacity are negative, making it more challenging for businesses to find the talent they need.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood is increasing at a rate of +10.41% year-over-year, ranking in the 62nd percentile. This expansion in housing supply is a positive signal for future affordability and workforce accommodation, as it may help to alleviate some of the pressure on the housing market. However, the current cost of living issues may still pose a challenge.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood is 55 days, with a year-over-year increase of +10.0%, ranking in the 66th percentile. This indicates a relatively slow market, which may be more accessible for workers relocating to the city. However, the rising days on market may also signal a normalization of the housing market, rather than a decline in demand.

Office Economy

The share of professional and office workers in Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood is 0.92, ranking in the 16th percentile, indicating a relatively shallow talent pool. This city is best suited for businesses that do not require a deep knowledge-economy talent pool, such as industrial or logistics companies, and less suited for tech, finance, or consulting firms that rely on specialized office workers.

The Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood metro area offers a relatively low-cost business environment, but the weak labor demand, stagnant wage growth, and expensive cost of living pose significant challenges for businesses looking to expand or relocate. The single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the limited availability of skilled workers, which may require businesses to offer higher wages or invest in talent development programs to attract and retain top talent.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #46 OF 50

Grand Rapids

Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood

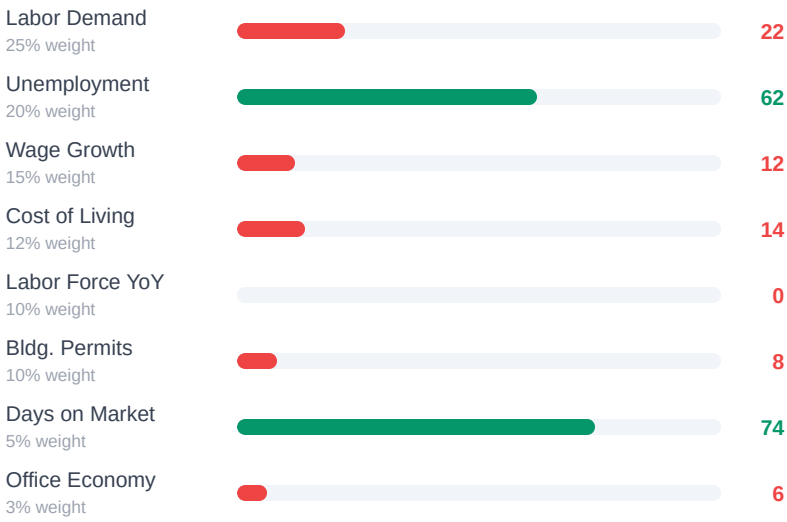
D

EMERGENCY

26.1th percentile

Rank 46 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT **3.7%** of civilian labor force	WAGE GROWTH YOY **+1.2%** avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH **+0.1%** nonfarm payrolls YoY	LABOR FORCE YOY **-8.5%** civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS **-31.1%** residential YoY (3mo avg)	DAYS ON MARKET **43 days** median, +4.9% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

GROWING

Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood metro area has an overall grade of D, ranking 26.1th percentile out of 50 US metros, with a composite score driven largely by its low labor demand and stagnant wage growth. The labor demand composite score of 3.86, combining a +0.12% employment growth rate and a -0.611% weekly hours deviation from trend, signals a contraction in genuine demand. This, coupled with a wage growth rate of +1.21%, suggests a challenging economic environment.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate of +0.12% and weekly hours deviation of -0.611% from trend indicate a lack of genuine demand expansion, suggesting that the city is experiencing a contraction in labor demand. This combination signals that the labor market is not growing robustly, with hours worked below the city's own trend. The labor demand composite score of 3.86, ranking in the 22nd percentile, further reinforces this assessment.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate of 3.70% ranks in the 62nd percentile, indicating a relatively tight labor market with some slack. This means that while it may not be extremely difficult to hire, there is still some competition for talent, and businesses may face moderate wage pressure. The relatively low unemployment rate suggests that workers have some bargaining power.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate of +1.21% is in the bottom tier, ranking 12th percentile, indicating stagnant wage growth. This slow wage growth environment means that labor costs for employers are not rising rapidly, but it also implies weak bargaining power for workers and potentially limited purchasing power. As a result, businesses may not face significant wage pressure, but workers may not have strong disposable incomes.

Cost of Living

With a cost of living ratio of $214/sqft to $32.90/hr, resulting in a ratio of 6.50, and a percentile rank of 14th, the city is relatively expensive. The fact that PSF is rising 2.4% YoY further exacerbates the affordability issue. This means that the city is at a talent attraction disadvantage, as workers may require wage premiums to afford the cost of living, making it less competitive for businesses looking to attract talent without additional compensation.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force is contracting at a rate of -8.53% year-over-year, ranking in the bottom tier. This significant decline in labor force supply indicates a structural headwind for hiring, as the pool of potential workers is shrinking. Businesses looking to expand or staff new

operations may find it challenging due to this contraction.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in building permits is -31.15%, indicating a sharp decline in new housing supply. This signals a potential future affordability crisis and suggests that the city's housing market may become even less accommodating for workers, potentially exacerbating talent attraction and retention challenges for businesses.

Days on Market

The current median days on market is 43 days, with a year-over-year increase of 4.9%, ranking in the 74th percentile. This indicates a slower market, which can be more accessible for workers relocating to the city, as they have more time to find suitable housing. However, this also suggests a less competitive housing market, which could be a sign of weaker demand.

Office Economy

With an office/professional worker share composite score of 0.80, ranking in the 6th percentile, the city has a relatively shallow professional talent pool. This makes it less suited for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, or HQ sectors that rely on deep knowledge-economy talent, but it may be more appropriate for industries with different workforce requirements, such as industrial or logistics.

The Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood metro area presents a challenging economic environment for businesses, with low labor demand, stagnant wage growth, and a shrinking labor force being significant concerns. The single biggest risk or constraint for a decision-maker is the city's limited and contracting labor pool, which could severely hinder hiring and expansion plans. Overall, businesses should carefully weigh these factors when considering the Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood area for location decisions.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #47 OF 50

Richmond

Richmond

D

EMERGENCY

25.1th percentile

Rank 47 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	8
Unemployment	20% weight	34
Wage Growth	15% weight	16
Cost of Living	12% weight	18
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	6
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	96
Days on Market	5% weight	16
Office Economy	3% weight	22

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT
3.8%
of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY
+1.6%
avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH
-1.0%
nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE YOY
-2.2%
civilian labor force growth

BUILDING PERMITS
+130.8%
residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET
44 days
median, -2.2% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

WEAK

Both employment and hours declining — broad contraction.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Richmond metro area has an overall grade of D, ranking in the 25.1th percentile out of 50 US metros, with a labor demand composite score of 2.96, placing it in the bottom tier. The city's economic character is most defined by its weak labor demand, with employment growth of -0.96% YoY, and its rapidly expanding housing supply, with building permits increasing by 130.84% YoY. These metrics suggest a city with significant challenges in job creation, but with a potential for improved affordability in the future.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Richmond is -0.96% YoY, and weekly hours are deviating from the trend by -0.122%, signaling a contraction in labor demand. This combination indicates a lack of genuine demand expansion, with the city experiencing a decline in both jobs and working hours. As a result, businesses may face a challenging environment for growth and expansion.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Richmond is 3.80%, which is below average, ranking in the 34th percentile. This suggests a relatively tight labor market, with some slack, but still presenting challenges for businesses trying to hire, as they may face upward pressure on wages. However, the market is not extremely tight, and businesses may still be able to find suitable candidates.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Richmond is +1.57%, which is relatively slow, ranking in the 16th percentile. This moderate wage growth rate implies that labor costs for employers are rising, but at a manageable pace, while worker purchasing power is increasing, but not rapidly. As a result, businesses may need to balance their labor costs with the need to attract and retain talent.

Cost of Living

Richmond has a cost of living score that places it in the bottom tier, with a percentile rank of 18th, and a PSF to earnings ratio of $226/sqft vs $35.71/hr, resulting in a ratio of 6.33. This suggests that the city is relatively expensive, making it challenging for businesses to attract talent without offering wage premiums. The fact that PSF is increasing by 0.4% YoY further exacerbates the affordability issue.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Richmond is contracting at a rate of -2.25% YoY, indicating a shrinking labor pool. This decline in labor force supply presents a structural headwind for hiring, as businesses may struggle to find qualified candidates to fill open positions. As a result, companies may need to invest in training and development programs to upskill the existing workforce.

Building Permits

The number of building permits in Richmond has increased by 130.84% YoY, signaling a rapid expansion of housing supply. This growth in permits suggests that the city's housing market is poised for improved affordability, which could, in turn, enhance its attractiveness to workers and businesses. However, it remains to be seen whether this increased supply will be sufficient to meet demand and drive down costs.

Days on Market

The median days on market in Richmond is currently 44 days, with a YoY decrease of -2.2%. This relatively fast pace of home sales suggests a competitive market, which may make it challenging for relocating workers to find suitable housing. As a result, businesses may need to offer relocation assistance or other incentives to attract talent to the area.

Office Economy

Richmond's professional and office worker share is ranked in the 22nd percentile, indicating a relatively shallow talent pool. This suggests that the city is less suited for businesses that require a deep knowledge-economy talent pool, such as tech, finance, or consulting firms. However, it may be more suitable for companies with industrial or logistics-oriented operations.

The Richmond metro area presents a challenging environment for businesses, with weak labor demand, a relatively expensive cost of living, and a shrinking labor force. However, the city's rapidly expanding housing supply and moderate wage growth rate offer some potential for future improvement. The single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the city's limited talent pool, which may require businesses to invest in training and development programs or offer relocation incentives to attract qualified candidates.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #48 OF 50

Detroit

Detroit-Warren-Dearborn

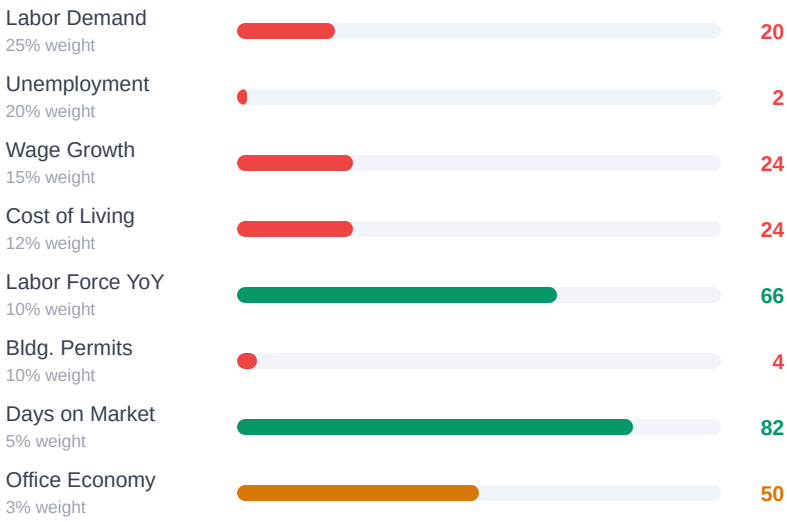
D

EMERGENCY

24.5th percentile

Rank 48 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT **5.6%** of civilian labor force	WAGE GROWTH YOY **+2.1%** avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH **-0.2%** nonfarm payrolls YoY	LABOR FORCE YOY **+0.5%** civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS **-35.8%** residential YoY (3mo avg)	DAYS ON MARKET **45 days** median, +7.1% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

SQUEEZE

Payrolls contracting while hours rise — survivor squeeze signal.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Detroit-Warren-Dearborn metro area has an overall grade of D, ranking in the 24.5th percentile out of 50 US metros, with a labor demand composite score of 3.71 and an unemployment rate of 5.60%. The city's economic character is most defined by its struggling labor market, with below-average employment growth and high unemployment, as well as its relatively low cost of living, with a PSF to wages ratio of 5.01. These metrics suggest a challenging environment for businesses looking to hire and grow.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Detroit-Warren-Dearborn is -0.16% year-over-year, while weekly hours are deviating 0.366% above the city's own 12-month baseline. This combination signals a survivor squeeze, where remaining workers are absorbing the load of eliminated roles, rather than genuine demand expansion. This is a concern for businesses looking to expand their workforce in the area.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Detroit-Warren-Dearborn is 5.60%, which is in the bottom tier, ranking 2nd percentile. This indicates a slack labor market, making it easier for businesses to staff, but also suggesting weaker local consumer demand. However, this also means that businesses may not face significant wage pressure, as there are more workers available than jobs.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Detroit-Warren-Dearborn is +2.10%, which is below average, ranking 24th percentile. This moderate wage growth suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but not rapidly, and worker purchasing power is increasing, but not strongly. This may be a concern for businesses looking to attract and retain top talent.

Cost of Living

Detroit-Warren-Dearborn has a cost of living percentile rank of 24th, with a PSF to wages ratio of 5.01, and a PSF of $185/sqft that is increasing 3.4% year-over-year. This suggests that the city is relatively expensive, ranking below average in terms of affordability. However, this also means that businesses may need to offer wage premiums to attract talent, as the cost of living is relatively high compared to other cities.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Detroit-Warren-Dearborn is growing at a rate of +0.49% year-over-year, which is above average, ranking 66th percentile. This indicates that the workforce supply is expanding, which is a positive sign for businesses looking to hire and grow in the area. However, this growth may be limited by the city's overall economic challenges.

Building Permits

The number of building permits in Detroit-Warren-Dearborn is decreasing by -35.82% year-over-year, which is in the bottom tier, ranking 4th percentile. This suggests that housing supply is tightening, which may lead to future affordability and workforce accommodation challenges. This is a concern for businesses looking to attract and retain talent, as a limited housing supply can drive up costs and make it harder for workers to relocate.

Days on Market

The median days on market in Detroit-Warren-Dearborn is 45 days, with a year-over-year increase of +7.1%, ranking in the top tier, 82nd percentile. This suggests a slower market, where homes are sitting longer before being sold, making it more accessible for workers relocating to the city. However, this may also indicate a weaker demand for housing, which could be a concern for businesses looking to attract talent.

Office Economy

The professional and office worker share in Detroit-Warren-Dearborn is near the median, ranking 50th percentile, with a composite score of 2.52. This suggests a moderate depth of professional talent pool, making the city suitable for businesses that require a mix of office and industrial skills. However, it may not be the best fit for businesses that require a deep knowledge-economy talent pool, such as tech or finance companies.

The Detroit-Warren-Dearborn metro area offers businesses a relatively low-cost environment and an expanding workforce supply, but it also poses significant challenges, including a struggling labor market, high unemployment, and a tightening housing supply. The single biggest risk or constraint for businesses considering locating in this city is the limited availability of skilled workers and the potential for future affordability and workforce accommodation challenges.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #49 OF 50

Chicago

Chicago-Naperville-Elgin

D

EMERGENCY

22.5th percentile

Rank 49 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	14
Unemployment	20% weight	20
Wage Growth	15% weight	34
Cost of Living	12% weight	20
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	12
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	44
Days on Market	5% weight	12
Office Economy	3% weight	42

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT
4.4%
of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY
+3.2%
avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH
-0.1%
nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE YOY
-2.0%
civilian labor force growth

BUILDING PERMITS
-5.0%
residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET
37 days
median, -2.6% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

SQUEEZE

Payrolls contracting while hours rise — survivor squeeze signal.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Chicago-Naperville-Elgin metro area has an overall grade of D, ranking in the 22.5th percentile out of 50 US metros, with a labor demand composite score of 3.52, placing it in the bottom tier. The city's economic character is most defined by its negative employment growth rate of -0.08% and its weekly hours deviation of +0.673%, indicating a weak labor market. The unemployment rate of 4.40% and labor force growth rate of -2.01% also contribute to the city's economic challenges.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate of -0.08% and weekly hours deviation of +0.673% suggest a scenario where hours are above trend during job losses, indicating a survivor squeeze where remaining workers are absorbing the load of eliminated roles. This combination signals a contraction in labor demand, rather than genuine demand expansion. The labor demand composite score of 3.52, ranking in the 14th percentile, further supports this conclusion.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate of 4.40% is relatively high, ranking in the 20th percentile, indicating a labor market with some slack. This means that businesses may find it relatively easier to hire workers, but may also face weaker local consumer demand. The practical implication for a business trying to hire in this market is that they may have a larger pool of potential candidates to choose from.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate of +3.23% is moderate, ranking in the 34th percentile. This rate suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but not extremely quickly, and worker purchasing power is increasing. However, the wage growth rate is not high enough to significantly drive up labor costs or boost consumer demand.

Cost of Living

The city's cost of living, with a PSF of $219/sqft and an earnings ratio of 5.86, ranks in the 20th percentile, indicating that it is relatively expensive. The 3.8% year-over-year increase in PSF further contributes to the city's low affordability score. This means that the city may struggle to attract talent without offering wage premiums to offset the high cost of living.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force is contracting at a rate of -2.01% year-over-year, ranking in the 12th percentile. This decline in labor force supply implies that hiring capacity may be constrained, making it more difficult for businesses to find and recruit workers. The shrinking labor pool is a structural headwind for hiring in this city.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in residential building permits is -4.95%, ranking in the 44th percentile, indicating a moderate decline in housing supply. This suggests that the city's housing market may be tightening, which could lead to decreased affordability and make it more challenging for workers to relocate to the area.

Days on Market

The current median days on market is 37 days, with a year-over-year decrease of -2.6%, ranking in the 12th percentile. This indicates a relatively fast-paced market, making it competitive for workers relocating to the city. However, the decreasing days on market suggests that the market may be heating up, which could further constrain affordability.

Office Economy

The city's professional and office worker share is 2.46, ranking in the 42nd percentile, indicating a moderate depth of professional talent pool. This suggests that the city is relatively well-suited for businesses in the tech, finance, and consulting sectors, but may not be as attractive for industries with more specialized or industrial roles.

The Chicago-Naperville-Elgin metro area offers a business a relatively large pool of potential candidates due to its higher unemployment rate, but its weak labor demand, declining labor force, and tightening housing market pose significant risks to hiring capacity and affordability. The single biggest risk or constraint a decision-maker should factor in is the city's low labor force growth rate, which may limit the availability of skilled workers and constrain business expansion.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #50 OF 50

Louisville

Louisville-Jefferson County

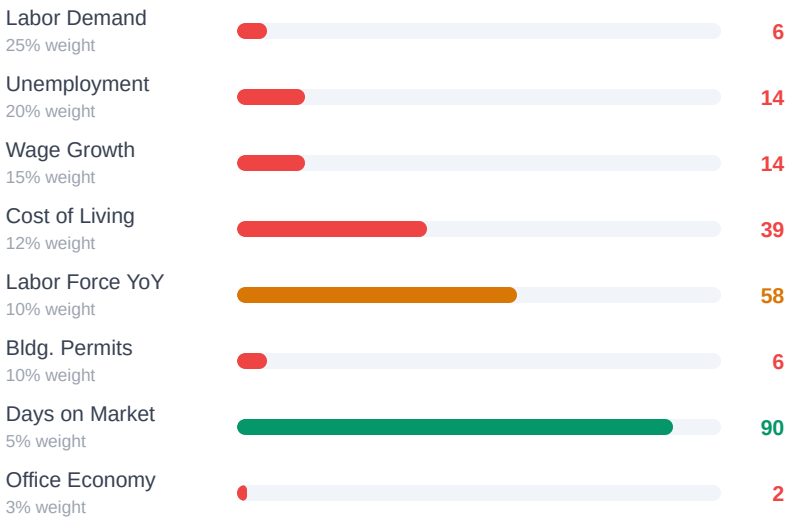
D

EMERGENCY

22.0th percentile

Rank 50 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT **4.4%** of civilian labor force	WAGE GROWTH YOY **+1.4%** avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH **-0.0%** nonfarm payrolls YoY	LABOR FORCE YOY **+0.2%** civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS **-31.7%** residential YoY (3mo avg)	DAYS ON MARKET **45 days** median, +9.8% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

SQUEEZE

Payrolls contracting while hours rise — survivor squeeze signal.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Louisville-Jefferson County metro area has an overall grade of D, ranking in the 22.0th percentile out of 50 US metros, with a composite score driven largely by its weak labor demand and declining building permits. The labor demand composite score of 2.93, combining a -0.03% employment growth rate and a +1.332% weekly hours deviation, signals a contraction in genuine demand. This, coupled with a -31.69% year-over-year change in building permits, defines the city's current economic character.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate of -0.03% and weekly hours deviation of +1.332% suggest a scenario where hours are above trend during job losses, indicating a survivor squeeze where remaining workers are absorbing the load of eliminated roles. This combination signals a contraction in genuine demand, rather than an expansion. The labor demand composite score of 2.93, ranking in the 6th percentile, reinforces this interpretation.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate of 4.40% ranks in the 14th percentile, indicating a moderate level of slack in the labor market. While this is not an extremely tight market, it still presents some challenges for businesses trying to hire, as they may face competition for available workers. However, it is not as severe as in tighter markets, with some wage pressure but not extreme.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate of +1.43% is relatively slow, ranking in the 14th percentile. This moderate wage growth suggests that labor costs for employers are not rising rapidly, but worker purchasing power is also not increasing significantly. This could lead to a relatively flat cost environment for businesses but may limit worker bargaining power.

Cost of Living

With a cost of living ratio of $177/sqft to $31.18/hr, and a year-over-year decrease of -0.6% in PSF, Louisville ranks in the 39th percentile for affordability. This means the city is relatively affordable compared to its peers, which could be a talent attraction advantage without necessitating significant wage premiums. The falling PSF relative to wages is a key driver of this affordability.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force is growing at a rate of +0.22% year-over-year, ranking near the median at the 58th percentile. This indicates a slowly expanding workforce supply, which could support hiring capacity over time. However, the growth rate is not strong, suggesting that labor supply expansion is not a significant driver of the local economy.

Building Permits

The -31.69% year-over-year change in building permits signals a tightening housing supply, which could lead to future affordability challenges and impact workforce accommodation. This sharp decline in permits suggests that developer confidence is waning, potentially leading to a supply squeeze that could affect the city's attractiveness to both businesses and workers.

Days on Market

Homes are currently sitting on the market for a median of 45 days, with a year-over-year increase of +9.8%, ranking in the 90th percentile. This slower market means that workers relocating to Louisville may find it more accessible in terms of housing, with less competition and potentially more negotiating power.

Office Economy

With an office/professional worker share of 0.20, ranking in the 2nd percentile, Louisville has a relatively shallow professional talent pool. This makes the city less suited for businesses requiring deep knowledge-economy talent, such as tech, finance, or consulting firms, but might be more appropriate for industries with different workforce needs.

The bottom line for a business considering Louisville is that while the city offers some advantages in terms of affordability and a moderate labor market, the significant risk is the constrained labor demand and tightening housing supply, which could limit growth and talent attraction. The single biggest constraint a decision-maker should factor in is the city's weak labor market dynamics, which could hinder the ability to expand or maintain a workforce.